

# MUSLIM FREEDOM FIGHTERS

Contribution of Indian Muslims in  
the Independence Movement

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Global Media Publications

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## Introduction

Muslims have been presented by people of certain ideology as unpatriotic. For the last seventy years, there has been a conscious and continuous effort to paint Muslims as anti-nationals and unpatriotic. This is a lie that has been told and retold so many times, that many innocent people have started believing it without ever questioning the narrative.

This is a monumental lie and has no basis. Muslims led the first war of independence and fought the initial incursion of the East India Company in the country. Tipu Sultan and his father, Hyder Ali, the rulers of Mysore, were the only rulers in the country who tried to face the British expansionism in India and gave it a tough fight, beating the colonial armies on multiple occasions. Without the support of Marathas and Nizam, the East India Company wouldn't have been able to emerge victorious.

The first war of Independence, called Mutiny of 1857, too was led by none other than last Moghal emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar. In Lucknow, it was Begum Hazrat Mahal who gave a tough fight to the marauding colonial armies and their

agents. She defeated the British army and for around a year remained a thorn in the neck of the British Raj, before being defeated and driven out of the country.

The Mutiny of 1857 and the subsequent freedom movement were launched and fought together by Hindus and Muslims.

In the first and the second decades of the last century, it was neither Indian National Congress nor anyone else that was in the forefront of fighting for the nation's independence. The struggle was waged by Mahmud al-Hasan and supported by the ulama of Deoband.

While Indian leaders were still trying to find a way to raise their voice for even a dominion status, these people, with the help of their Hindu comrades, were setting up government in exile and negotiating with Russia, France, Germany and Turkey to recognize their government in exile in Kabul.

Mahmud al-Hasan was a true leader and a visionary. A legend who mesmerized the Muslims of the Indian Subcontinent, he was nicknamed Shaykhul Hind, the leader of India. With his academic accomplishments at Darul Uloom, initially as a teacher and later as the principal, he won the hearts of many people in the entire Indian Subcontinent. It was pretty soon that the Shaykh-ul-Hind realized that the people of India need to drive the British Raj out of the nation as soon as possible.

Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan launched a programme to train volunteers from among his disciples in India and abroad who joined this movement in a large number. The most eminent among them were Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi and Maulana

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Mohammad Mian Mansoor Ansari besides his friend Maulana Barakatullah Bhopali. Maulana Bhopali was an ideologue, who set the agenda for the freedom struggle and travelled extensively throughout Europe, Americas and Asia. He spent five years in Japan, the epicenter of freedom movements across Asia, and the hope of Asian nations struggling to wriggle out of the European occupation.

Crispin Bates, in his seminal work, *Subalterns and Raj: South Asia Since 1600* says, "Mahmud al Hasan, was later to become known as Shaykh ul-Hind (leader of India) forming a government in exile headquartered in Medina in Saudi Arabia with Mahmud al-Hasan as its amir (chief), Barkatullah Bhopali as its minister and Maharaja (Mahendra) Pratap Singh as its president. This government in exile began to seek international support against the British rule. Unfortunately one of the international communications between the leaders, written on a silk cloth, fell into the hands of the British in 1916: this tehrik-e-reshmi rumal (silk kerchief conspiracy) led to the arrest of more than 200 ulema. In 1919, the Jamiat Ulema-e-Hind, a Muslim political organisation based in India, was then started by the ulama of this madrasa. This organisation, which opposed the two-nation theory of the Muslim League on the ground that culture, not religion, defines a nation's identity..."

Tara Chand, in his *History of Freedom Movement in India, Vol. 3* says, "Mahmud al Hasan, Husain Ahmed Madni, Obaidullah Sindhi, Abul Kalam Azad and many other Ulama (learned Muslims) suffered uncomplainingly the hardships and deprivations which were heaped upon them and which

they welcomed as an offering in the service of the country and God".

Shamsul Islam, in the book, *Religious Dimensions of Indian Nationalism*, while discussing the contributions and sacrifices of ulama of Deoband says, "The sacrifices which the leaders of the Deoband School and the Jamiat made in the cause of the freedom form a glorious chapter in the history of the freedom movement. Their intense devotion to the cause is manifest in their daily lives; there was no sacrifice which they didn't or were not prepared to offer --financial or otherwise...They spent years in exile -voluntary or otherwise, or in British prisons - abused, maltreated, denied ordinary conveniences of life and put on the poorest rations".

When Shaykhul Hind finally returned to the country in his twilight years, he issued a fatwa (religious edict) making it mandatory for all the Muslims in the entire Indian Subcontinent to not just support but also participate with Mahatma Gandhi and the Indian National Congress. Maulana Muhammad Mian Mansoor Ansari is another stalwart who was in the forefront of the struggle against the British Raj. He was not just a great scholar but a leader with huge fan following across the nation. He was instrumental in setting up the first Indian government in exile in Kabul that survived for several years despite all efforts by the British authorities to shut it down.

Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi, another disciple of Mahmud al-Hasan, was on the forefronts of war against the colonial occupation. He was a revolutionary who, despite being among the top Islamic scholars in the region always opposed

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the establishment of a Muslim religious government. On the contrary he was a staunch supporter of Mahatma Gandhi and along with Shaykh ul-Hind, supported Mahatma Gandhi's Non Co-Operation Movement. He met Lenin in Moscow and sought his support for the government in exile. He and Shaykhul Hind Mahmud al-Hasan, both, despite being among the top Islamic scholars were secular to the core.

Muslims were equal partners when Indian freedom struggle came of age under Mahatma Gandhi. As many as nine Muslims were elected presidents of the Indian National Congress till the year 1947, when India finally attained independence. Without leaders like Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, Muhammad Ali Jauhar, Dr MA Ansari, Hakim Ajmal Khan, Dr Syed Mahmud, Hasrat Mohani, Maulana Mazharul Haq etc, the story of war of independence cannot be complete.

Hindus and Muslims fought together on every front. When Indian National Army or Azad Hind Fauj was formed by Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose, his closest associates included Gen. Shah Nawaz Khan, Col. Mehboob and Captain Abbas Ali. The war of independence was truly a national war and had equal participation of the Muslims of all hues.

When Shaheed Bhagat Singh and Batukeshwar Dutt were arrested, their case was fought in different courts by none other than Asaf Ali, one of the best finest minds of the nationalist Indians.

Can the history of war of independence be complete without mentioning the names of Ashfaqulla Khan and his friend



Ram Prasad Bismil? Both were hanged to death on the same day by the ruthless British Raj following Kakori train robbery.

Both, Muslims and Hindus walked the same path and fought together for independence. In the Round Table Conference, held in London, Muhammad Ali Jauhar said "We have 320,000,000 of people. When they can afford to die in millions from famine and from plagues, surely they can afford to die from British bullets too...Nobody wins in a battle if there is merely the will to kill. You must have the will to die even before the will to kill. In India we have not the power to kill, but the moment we develop the will to die, numbers will tell. 320,000,000 of people cannot be killed. There is no mechanization for which you can find money to kill 320,000,000 people. Even if you have got that mechanization, even if you have got the material, you have not the morale to dare to kill 320,000,000 people. We must have in us the will to die for the birth of India as a free and united nation".

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## Shaikhul Hind Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan

Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan, popularly known as Shaikhul Hind was one of the foremost freedom fighters, scholars and educationists of nineteenth and early twentieth century India. No one has any iota of doubt that it was he who launched the long struggle to attain freedom for the country, enslaved by the British Raj.

Given his stature, he was called Shaikhul Hind that literally translates as the leader of India. Born in the year 1851 in Bareilly, Uttar Pradesh, he became the foremost scholar and theologian in the entire Indian Subcontinent. His father, Maulana Zulfeqar Ali, is said to be a renowned scholar of Arabic and Persian who was respected by a large number of people. Maulana Zulfeqar Ali was employed with the Department of Education in Bareilly, United Province that later became Uttar Pradesh.

His tryst with history began rather very early. Mahmud al-Hasan has the distinction of being the first student of Darul Uloom Deoband, that has grown into a preeminent center of Islamic education in the Indian Subcontinent.

Being the first student of the Darul Uloom, Deoband, got him the privilege of being taught by none other than Maulana

Mohammad Qasim Nanotvi, one of the most distinguished scholars of our times. Many historians believe Maulana Nanotvi of being in the same league of scholars as Sir Syed Ahmad Khan, the founder of Aligarh Muslim University. While Sir Syed Ahmad Khan is perceived to have laid the foundation of modern education for Indian Muslims, Maulana Nanotvi is said to have reformed and remodeled religious education in the Indian Sub-Continent.

Shaikhul Hind Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan graduated from Darul Uloom in the year 1873 and then went on to serve the institution as a teacher from 1874 onwards. In the year 1890, he was appointed the rector of the Darul Uloom.

Before going to Darul Uloom, he was well-versed in Persian as well as Urdu and had been provided strong academic foundation of the Arabic language. His biographers suggest that Shaykhul Hind received his education under the able guidance of Hazrat Maulana Mongeri, Maulana Abdul Latif, and later, from his uncle, Maulana Mahtab Ali. He was still studying mid-level subjects and studying books like *Mukhtasar al-Quduri* and *Sharh-i-Tahdhib*, when Maulana Nanotvi opened the gate of Darul Uloom, Deoband to students.

Maulana Zulfeqar Ali, the father of Shaykhul Hind was an old admirer of Maulana Nanotvi, and thus as soon as the announcement for the opening of the school was made, he was sent to the newly established seminary.

With his academic accomplishments at Darul Uloom, initially as a teacher and later as the principal, he won the

hearts of many people in the region and beyond. While he didn't witness the vagaries of war during the 1875 Mutiny in which his teacher, Maulana Nanotvi, and the ulama of the region, had played a major role, he knew the destruction that came in its wake. Pretty soon, Shaykhul Hind realized that the Muslim community and India need to drive the British Raj out of the nation as soon as possible. When the Ottoman Empire entered World War-I against the British Empire, Muslims across the world were concerned about the future of the Sultan of the Ottoman Empire, who claimed to be the caliph of Islam and spiritual leader of the global Muslim community.

Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan didn't want to be a mute spectator as the British continued to occupy the huge country called India while continuing to gain further foothold in Muslim hinterland like West Asia and Turkey. Shaykhul Hind organised efforts to start an armed revolution against British rule from both within and outside India. He launched a programme to train volunteers from among his disciples in India and abroad who joined this movement in a large number. The most eminent among them were Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi and Maulana Mohammad Mian Mansoor Ansari. Maulana Sindhi and Maulana Ansari hogged limelight across the world for being India's voices for Pan Asian identity.

Sending Maulana Sindhi to Kabul and Maulana Ansari to the North-West Frontier Province to mobilize popular support and recruit volunteers, Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan himself travelled to Hijaz to secure Turkish government's support for

the freedom movement initiated by him and his disciples. Obtaining the Turkish Governor Ghalib Pasha's signature on a declaration of war against the British Raj, Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan planned to return to India via Baghdad and Balochistan to start the rebellion, drive out the occupation forces and establish a secular government in the country.

This plan that later came to be known as the Silk Letter Conspiracy (Reshmi Rumal Tehrik), was somehow discovered by the Punjab CID. It is no secret that the British Raj had established a multi-layered, dreaded intelligence network across the region. Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan was arrested in the holy city of Mecca and was imprisoned in Malta for more than three years before his release in 1920.

In order to further the anti-British crusade, Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan set up an organisation called "Thamaratu-Tarbiyah" (result of training) in the year 1877. This outfit actually chalked out long-term planning to prepare his pupils for the freedom struggle at an opportune time. These people were given advanced armed training by many army veterans who also happened to be the disciples or the sons of his disciples in Deoband.

Historical accounts suggest that this outfit remained dormant after being active for a couple of years. It was in the year 1909 when this organization was revived and renamed as Jam'iyatul Ansar or the society of the helpers.

Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi was entrusted with running and managing this organization. This decision was not taken at the spur of the moment, but after long term planning and

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consultation with thousands of people. A brainstorming session was held at Deoband. Historic accounts suggest that more than 30,000 people from across the Indian Subcontinent attended the meeting that was held under the guise of Dastarbandi (graduation) ceremony of Darul Uloom in 1911. Soon after, a three day meeting was also organized from 15 to 17 April 1911 in Moradabad. While speaking on the occasion another renowned scholar and alim of the time Maulana Ahmad Hasan Amrohwi said in his presidential address that it is a revival of Thamaratu-Tarbiyah and that "its aims and objectives are of utmost importance for our times."

Many more meetings of the outfit were held over the next two years. The British Raj, annoyed at such activities put pressure on Darul Uloom to stop meddling in political affairs. At one point, the British Raj toyed with the idea of shutting down the Darul Uloom, Deoband itself for its openly anti-British activities. The Raj knew the reach and influence of these clerics and realized that antagonizing them at this juncture will be suicidal for it.

While the Shaykhul Hind remained steadfast in his goal of ridding India off the British misrule, he launched another organization, Nazaratul Ma'arif, in 1913 in Delhi.

While Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan confined himself to nearby areas, he mobilized his disciples, many of whom had advanced military training and sent them to different areas across the country including Karachi, Kolkata and many other places. Besides, he also dispatched a number of missions to Russia, Turkey, Japan, China, America, France, Afghanistan and Burma. Details of these missions and similar

activities were lost as records in Deoband were destroyed when it became known that the British government was about to arrest Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan.

In the year 1915, he took the most daring decision of his life and established a government-in-exile in Kabul. Maulana Sindhi was dispatched along with Maharaja Mahindra Pratap Singh who had to act as President, Maulana Barkatullah Bhopali as Prime Minister and Maulana Sindhi as the Home Minister. Historic accounts suggest that this government got wholehearted support of German and Turkish governments and the government in exile established a ragtag army too that occasionally attacked British posts inside the British India.

Reshmi Roomal Tehrik or "the Silken letters movement" is mentioned in detail in para 164 of the report of the Rowlatt Committee. Giving the details, the Committee says:

"The events of Silken letters were discovered in August 1916. This was a plan that had been proposed in India with the idea that disturbance be created on the north-western border on the one hand and, on the other, bolstering it up with the uprising of the Indian Muslims, the British Government be put to an end. To put this proposal into shape a man named Maulawi Ubaydullah crossed the north-western border in August, 1915/1333, with three of his companions. Ubaydullah was formerly a Sikh, who had later on become a Muslim. He acquired religious education in Deoband. The greatest personality among, those people whom Ubaydullah had influenced were that of Maulana Mahmood Hasan who had been a principal of this institution for a long time.

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Ubaydullah wanted to start a universal Islamic movement against the British in India through the graduate Ulema of Deoband. Secret meetings used to be held at Maulana Mahmood Hasan's house. It is said that some men of, the northwest border also used to participate in them. On September 8, 1915/1333, Maulana Mahmood Hasan left India and reached Hejaz. The important objective of both Ubaydullah and Maulana Mahmood Hasan was to simultaneously cause an aggression on India from outside and stir rebellion in India itself. Ubaydullah and his friends first contacted the fanatical India party of fighters (Mujahidin), and then they reached Kabul. There Ubaydullah met the Turk-German Mission. After some days his Deobandi friend, Muhammad Mian also joined him. This man had gone to Hejaz along with Maulana Mahmood Hasan from where he had come back in 1916/1334, having obtained a proclamation of jihad which Maulana Mahmood Hasan had taken from the Turkish commander in chief of Hejaz, Ghalib Pasha. This document is known as "Ghalib Nama". Muhammad Mian distributed its photocopies on the way in India and among the frontier tribes".

Tariq Hasan, in his seminal work *Colonialism and the Call to Jihad in British India* says, "By the close of the 19th century, Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan's name had already become a household name in India. By Virtue of his strong character, he exercised tremendous influence over his pupils".

Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan also comprehended the importance of modern education. Unlike common perception, it was neither Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan, nor



any other cleric associated with Deoband movement who opposed Sir Syed's attempt to popularize modern education. This is the reason he sought closer relations of Aligarh and Deoband. Tariq Hasan, while writing in his book *Colonialism and the Call to Jihad in British India* says, "Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan also wanted better relations between Aligarh and the Deoband School. The MAO College, Aligarh had been founded by Sir Syed Ahmad Khan in 1877 for primarily imparting modern education to the upper class and the middle class Muslims. The Darul Uloom Theological School Deoband, on the other hand was focused entirely on the teaching of Islamic theology...Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan therefore introduced an exchange program between the two schools. Special arrangements were made for the teaching of theology to the Aligarh students. Deoband students on the other hand were given lessons in English language and some introductory courses in science and maths".

When he returned to the country after three year long incarceration in Malta, he saw that the nation was up in arms against the British Raj. Shaykhul Hind sensed that and issued a fatwa making it mandatory for all the Muslims in the entire Indian Subcontinent to not just support but also participate in the freedom movement with Mahatma Gandhi and the Indian National Congress. Later, Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan laid the foundation stone of Jamia Millia Islamia, in Aligarh that was later shifted to Delhi. Jamia Millia Islamia was also a sign of defiance against the British hegemony. He also wrote a well known translation of the Quran, the commentary of

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which was written by one of his students, Shabbir Ahmad Usmani. Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan died on 30 November 1920.

## Maulana Barkatullah Bhopali

**M**aulana Barkatullah Bhopali was a freedom fighter who became the first Prime Minister in India's first government in exile established in Kabul in 1915. Maharaja Mahindra Pratap Singh was the President of the Indian government in exile and Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi was its home minister. This government survived for several years before being disbanded under immense British pressure.

Maulana Barkatullah Bhopali's original name was Abdul Hafiz Mohamed Barakatullah. He was born in Bhopal on 7 July 1854. One of the confidantes of Shaykhul Hind Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan, he was among the foremost freedom fighters who never allowed the fear to come close to him, let alone intimidate or stop him from doing something he thought was right. Without his courage and determination, India's first government in exile in Kabul, would have never materialized and lasted for so long.

He was a born revolutionary and great disciplinarian. His father, a police officer, might have shaped his personality in such a way that he abhorred indiscipline. He was among the top leaders of the freedom movement and initially worked under Shaykhul Hind Mahmud al-Hasan and after his death

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in 1922, was the leader of the freedom movement till his death. After leaving India and establishing the Indian government in exile in Kabul, he toured the entire world crisscrossing almost every major capital. He visited and met the rulers and the top officials in different nations including United States, Russia, France, Egypt, Turkey, Japan, Malay, Hejaz and many other nations. He spent more than five years in United States and then went to Japan where he joined other revolutionary leaders. He edited a well received magazine while staying there. Later, the Maulana was appointed professor of Indian studies in University of Tokyo. He knew the art of diplomacy so well that he brought support for the government in exile from different nations including Germany, Russia and Turkey.

Abdullah Khan, in his paper, 'Mawlana Barakatullah Bhopali's Role in the Freedom Movement', says "Mawlänä Barakatulläh Bhopäli...had been endowed with an amazing zeal, vim and vigour, that has been rarely seen among contemporary Indian Muslims...he took upon himself the task of unseating the British power from India by working with, and soliciting help from, the powers hostile to Britain. With this objective in mind, he embarked upon his self-styled political exile lasting for 45 long hectic years, travelling around the globe twice, visiting the world capitals, settling his gaze and pinning his hopes, now on Japan, now on Germany, now on Soviet Russia. He spent 11 years in England, 6 years in the USA, 5 years in Japan, and a considerable part of his life in Central Europe, Central Asia and Soviet Russia. (He was a member of) Turkish-German mission, president of the

Indian Independence Party at Berlin and one of the founders of the Ghadar Party based in the USA...In the midst of such tireless efforts to free the country of his birth from foreign yoke, he died on 27th September 1927 in a hospital at San Francisco and was buried at the Muslim cemetery of Marysville, Sacramento, California, U.S.A.”

During his stay in England, Maulana Barkatullah Bhopali came in contact with revolutionaries like Lala Hardayal and Raja Mahendra Pratap, son of the Raja of Hathras. It was at the same time when he befriended the Afghan Emir and the editor of the Kabul newspaper *Sirejul-ul-Akber*. During his stay in the United States he co-founded the Ghadar Party in 1913 in San Francisco.

Earlier, during his stay in United States, he, along with one of his associates founded Pan-Aryan Association. This association was reportedly helped by the Irish revolutionaries of the Clan-na-Gael, a well-known anti-British lawyer Myron H. Phelps and of the equally anti-British Swami Abhedananda.

There is no denying that his personality was so impressive that people were awed by him in their first meetings itself. Towards the second decade of the twentieth century he had become a legend not just in India but in much of the world. His words were authoritative and his speeches were heard in pin-drop silence. His exposure to the European nations, besides Japan, the rising power from the east that was increasingly challenging the world, gave him a unique insight into what was happening across the world and how to create meaningful changes on the ground.

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It is rather surprising that unlike Japanese who tried to create changes from the ground, he couldn't initiate something meaningful that could really strengthen the people in India in general in the long term and Muslims in particular. It may be the impact of Jamal ad-din Afghani, that like Afghani he tried to create change from top, without working among the common people including peasants, farmers, labors etc. Towards the end, Jamal ad-din Afghani retorted himself for not working among the masses to make any meaningful change, and looking at the ruling classes for bringing revolution and transformation.

Pankaj Mishra, while writing in his best-selling book, *From the Ruins of Empire: The Revolt Against the West and the Remaking of Asia*, says:

"A more militant kind of Indian had made Japan his home before Tagore's arrival in 1916. These Indians were part of the foreign communities that had flocked to Japan to learn the secrets of modernization. Along with New York and London, Tokyo was part of an international network of 'Indian Houses', where activists and self styled revolutionaries exiled from India gathered. An Indian Muslim, Maulavi Barkatullah (1854-1927), edited a magazine titled *The Indian Sociologist* from Tokyo. In 1910 he revived *The Islamic Fraternity*, the English monthly that Abdurreshid Ibrahim had set up, and which the Japanese, yielding to British requests, had closed down. Barkatullah turned it into an explicitly anti-British forum. He also wrote for the influential Japanese pan Asianist thinker Okawa Shumei,

who had begun to outline a Japanese version of the Monroe Doctrine for Asia”.

He was a great supporter of Hindu-Muslim unity and believed that without their unity, any meaningful changes would be impossible in the Indian Subcontinent. The sage revolutionary is reported to have said that the two chief duties of Muslims in India were patriotism and friendship with all Muslims outside India.

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## Hakim Ajmal Khan

**H**akim Ajmal Khan will always remain relevant for the nationalists across the country. He was a freedom fighter who was not just a top leader in India's freedom movement, he was also the one who funded the freedom movement from his own pocket. When he ran out of money, Ajmal Khan raised it through donations from masses, who always reposed faith in his persona.

Despite being a devout Muslim, he was a nationalist who confronted the British occupation forces in every way possible, led the Indian National Congress and the Khilafat Movement besides Muslim League. The League in its infancy was an out and out nationalist movement.

He was a born leader who naturally occupied the leadership slot wherever he went. He headed Khilafat Movement that was the main unifying force of the freedom movement and brought the Indian Muslims closer to the Indian National Congress after initial phase of apprehension. There is no denying that personalities like Hakim Ajmal Khan, Maulana Abul Kalam Azad and Dr Mukhtar Ansari played a stellar role in unifying the freedom struggle and bringing Hindus and Muslims together. Hakim Ajmal Khan was instrumental in setting up Jamia Millia Islamia, an initiative of freedom fighters who didn't want to send their kids to government



financed educational institutions including Aligarh Muslim University. Jamia Millia Islamia was set up by the nationalist Muslims after a call by Mahatma Gandhi to avoid government funded schools and colleges.

Hakim Ajmal Khan was born on 11 February 1868 when the memories of the Mutiny of 1857 were still very fresh in minds of the people who survived the unprecedented oppression in the wake of Mutiny by India's freedom fighters. Hundreds of thousands of people were slaughtered, Muslims and Hindus, whoever took part in the Mutiny were summarily executed. Muslim mosques were destroyed in a large number and Delhi's historic Jama Masjid was turned into a stable where occupation forces tied their horses and donkeys. For close to ten years, the mosque was out of bounds for the devotees and it hurt them badly. The gates of the mosque were opened merely a year before the birth of the renowned physician.

Hakim Ajmal Khan was born into a noble family of Delhi who were practicing hakims for the last many generations. His grandfather, Hakim Sharif Khan, was a physician to Mughal Emperor, Shah Alam and had built the Sharif Manzil, a hospital-cum-college teaching Unani medicine. Hakim Ajmal Khan, himself a renowned hakim was the personal physician of the Nawab of Rampur. His father, Hakim Mahmud Khan, had a roaring medical practice in Delhi and people from across North India came to consult him.

His initial education took place at home and was taught Arabic and Persian there. Later he studied medicine by his close relatives, who were renowned physicians and teachers

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of the time. It is said that he completed his Unani studies under Hakeem Abdul Jameel of Siddiqui Dawakhana, Delhi. Initially he was full time physician who treated patients visiting his clinic free of cost, but charged hefty fee of Rs 1000 when visiting a patient outside Delhi. It was royal sum that only nawabs and royals could manage to pay.

The book '*Eminent Mussalmans*', while describing his ascent to the height of freedom movement says, "From that time forward the Hakim Sahib became a staunch supporter of Mahatma Gandhi; and when Mr. C. R. Das was arrested on the eve of the Ahmedabad Congress in 1921, he accepted the post of President, which was unanimously offered to him and thus devoted his life in the cause of Hindu-Muslim unity. Since the arrest of Mahatma Gandhi, the leadership of the whole movement, for the time being, has practically devolved upon him, and in spite of failing health and a weakened physical constitution he has done his very utmost to fulfill the work. In all this arduous undertaking, he has had the devoted sympathy and support of Dr. A. M. Ansari who has been, all through, his translator into English as well as active helper in organisation. The friendship between Dr. Ansari and the Hakim Sahib has been very close indeed, and it has become closer than ever during the past year".

His adulation and love for Mahatma Gandhi is in full display in a letter he wrote to Gandhiji while he was in Sabarmati Jail. "I can feel happy at your arrest only when I find that as a mark of the profound respect, which it has for you, the country takes still greater interest in the national movement than it did when you were free. It gives me infinite pleasure

to see that the country observed perfect peace. This is a clear sign of the spread of the spirit of non-violence in the country, which is as essential for our success as pure air is necessary for life. I have no doubt that the secret of the progress of our country lies in the unity of the Hindus, the Mussalmans and other races of India. Such a unity should not be based on policy, for that in my opinion would be only a kind of an armistice”.

The unity of Hindus and Muslims was of paramount importance in the eyes of Hakim sahib. It is very clear from the letter he addressed to Gandhi. While writing further he said, “But I clearly see that the two great communities are coming closer together every day, and although the number of men, whose hearts are absolutely free from any sectarian prejudices, may not be very great, I feel convinced that the country has found the road to real unity and will advance on it with steady steps towards its goal. So highly do I prize this unity, that if the country gave up all other activities and achieved that alone, I would consider the Khilafat and Swaraj questions automatically solved to our satisfaction. For the achievement of our objects is so intimately connected with this unity. The question, then, naturally arises, how are we to achieve this living and lasting unity? We can achieve it only by the sincerity and purity of our hearts. Not until everyone of us has driven selfishness out of his mind, will our country succeed in achieving its objects.”

Hakim Ajmal Khan was among the founders of the Jamia Millia Islamia. He was elected its first chancellor on 22 November 1920, holding the position until his death in 1927.

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During this period he oversaw the University's move to Delhi from Aligarh and helped it overcome various crises, including financial ones, when he carried out extensive fund raising and often bailed it out using his own money.

Hakim Ajmal Khan forayed into nationalist movement rather late. He was fully into medical practice and humanitarian work. He had launched Hakim Ajmal Khan Tibbiya College, besides Sadar Dawakhana. Along with his personal practice, the two kept him occupied for a large part of his day. His foray into politics came when he started writing for the Urdu weekly *Akmal-ul-Akhbar* launched by his family. In the year 1906, Hakim sahib led the Muslim team that met the Viceroy of India in Shimla and presented him with a memorandum written by the delegation. He attended Muslim League's launch program in Dhaka on 30 December 1906. At that time Muslim League was the initiative of nationalist Muslims and it remained the same for the next two decades. He was among the foremost leaders of the Khilafat Movement despite not opposing Britain in the World War-1. Nonetheless, he became restless when he saw the Turkish Khilafat being dissected between different European powers and other Arab, African Muslim nations being occupied by European colonial powers. Hakim sahib was the only person to be elected to the presidency of the Indian National Congress, the Muslim League and the All India Khilafat Committee.

Hakim Ajmal Khan breathed his last on 29 December 1927.

## Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi

**M**aulana Ubaidullah Sindhi, a disciple of Shaykhul Hind Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan, was a stalwart of India's freedom struggle. He established a government in exile in Kabul, Afghanistan along with Raja Mahendra Pratap Singh.

He was a revolutionary who, despite being among the top Islamic scholars in the region always opposed the establishment of a Muslim religious government as was being advocated by many. On the contrary he was a staunch supporter of Mahatma Gandhi and along with Shaykhul Hind supported Gandhi's Non Co-Operation Movement.

He was a revolutionary who never stayed still and travelled to different parts of the world to seek support for their freedom movement and the government in exile that he had established. He met Lenin in Moscow and sought his support for the government in exile.

He and Shaykhul Hind Mahmud al-Hasan, both, despite being among the top Islamic scholars were secular to the core. This is the reason that the President of their government in exile in Kabul was a Hindu and not Muslim. Maharaja

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Mahindra Pratap Singh was the President while Maulana Barkatullah Bhopali was the Prime Minister.

There is no denying the fact that Deobandi ideology has never looked divisive or sectarian. It was very multi-cultural and multi-religious ideology in twenties of the last century and it remains the same to date. The only difference being the fact that during the twenties and thirties of the last century there were many leaders of vision and fortitude who saw the future clearly, while the present lot doesn't seem to be in the same league in any way.

In Maulana Sindhi's persona, we have one of the most impressive representatives of the Deobandi ideology and its services to Islam and the Subcontinent.

Born on 10 March 1872, Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi was a noted scholar, political activist and freedom fighter of the Indian independence movement. Born into a Sikh family at Chilanwali, in the district of Sialkot (now in Pakistan) his father Ram Singh Zargar died 4 months after Ubaidullah was born. He was initially brought up by his grandfather.

He was very young when he converted to Islam and got himself enrolled at the newly launched Darul Uloom, Deoband, under the tutelage of the visionary founder of the institution, Maulana Muhammad Qasim Nanotvi. His conversion to Islam was caused by inspiration from a book that he was gifted by a young Hindu friend. The book that is mentioned in history as inspiration behind his conversion to Islam is *Tuhfatul Hind*. The writer of the book is another convert scholar Maulana Ubaidullah of Malerkotla. After

reading this book and others, Ubaidullah's interest in Islam grew, leading eventually to his conversion to Islam.

Before moving to Darul Uloom, Deoband, he studied at Deen Pur under Maulana Ghulam Muhammad, where he was provided education in *fiqh*, *tafseer*, *hadith*, *nahw* and *balaghah* besides Arabic literature, both classical and modern. It was in the year 1888 when Ubaidullah Sindhi was admitted to Darul Uloom, Deoband, where he studied various Islamic sciences at depth under the tutelage of noted Islamic scholars of the time, including Maulana Abu Siraj, Maulana Rasheed Gangohi and Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan.

Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi was a brilliant student and within merely three years he graduated from Darul Uloom Deoband and left for Sukkhur, where he taught in Amrote Shareef. His biographers claim that here he married the daughter of Maulana Azeemullah Khan, a teacher at Islamiyah High School. Before too long, in the year 1901, Ubaidullah Sindhi launched the foundation of Darul Irshaad in Goth Peer Jhanda in Sindh. As Shaykhul Hind needed able people around him, in the year 1909, he requested Ubaidullah Sindhi to come back to Deoband.

Maulana Sindhi worked with Hakeem Ajmal Khan and Dr. Mukhtar Ansari as directed by Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan. In the year 1912, he established a madrasa, Nazzaaratul Ma'arif which achieved much in the field of propagating Islam.

One of the earliest freedom fighters, who took to modern means to fight the British occupation and made preparations

long before launching the government in exile, Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan, tried to further strengthen his movement to oust British Raj from India with the onset of World War-I in 1914. Led by Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan, plans were sketched out for an uprising beginning in the tribal belt of North-West Frontier Province of British India. Mahmud al-Hasan, left India to seek the help of Galib Pasha, the Turkish governor of Hijaz, while at his directions, Ubaidullah proceeded to Kabul to seek Emir Habibullah's support there. Initial plans were to raise an army headquartered at Medina, with an Indian sub-headquarter in Kabul. Maulana Mahmu al-Hasan was to be the commander-in-chief of this army. While at Kabul, Ubaidullah came to the conclusion that focusing on the Indian Freedom Movement would best serve their interests.

Later Shaykhul Hind Mahmud al-Hasan sought German and Turkish support against the British occupation of India. Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan proceeded to Hijaz. In late 1915, Sindhi was met in Kabul by the 'Niedermayer-Hentig Expedition' sent by the Indian Independence Committee in Berlin and the German war ministry. Nominally led by the exiled Indian prince Raja Mahendra Pratap, it had among its members the Islamic scholar Maulana Barakatullah Bhopali, and the German officers Werner Otto von Hentig and Oskar Niedermayer, as well as a number of other notable individuals.

It was on 1st December 1915, that the Provisional Government of India was founded at Emir Habibullah's 'Bagh-e-Babur palace' in the presence of the Indian leaders



and German and Turkish bureaucrats. All these bureaucrats were high ranking officers in the two major world powers. This government in exile was expected to take charge of independent India when British rule is overthrown. Mahendra Pratap was proclaimed its President, renowned ideologue Maulana Barkatullah Bhopali the Prime minister, Ubaidullah Sindhi the Minister for India, another Deobandi leader Moulavi Bashir its War Minister, and Champakaran Pillai its Foreign Minister. Under sustained pressure from the British government, this government in exile was dissolved in the year 1919.

After his brainchild, the government in exile was scrapped, Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi went to Russia where he was warmly received and given the status of a guest of state. Later he left for Turkey in 1923 where he reportedly initiated the third phase of the 'Shah Waliullah Movement' in 1924. He issued the 'Charter for the Independence of India' from Istanbul. Ubaidullah then left for Mecca in 1927 and remained there until 1929.

Rowlatt Committee, in its report on the Silken letters conspiracy talks of major role played by Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi. The report said, "Ubaidullah and his companions had prepared a plan of a provisional government at the dissolution of the British government. According to this plan, a man named Mahendra Pratap was to be the president. This man was an ardent Hindu of a respectable family. In the end of 1914/1332 he had been given a passport to go to Switzerland, Italy, France, etc. He went straight to Geneva and there he met the notorious Hardayal, who introduced

him to the German consul. From there he came to Germany and was sent on a special mission to Kabul. Ubaydullah himself wanted to be the home-minister of India and Barkatullah to be the prime minister. Barkatullah was a friend of Krishna Verma and a member of the American Ghadr Party.

The report went on to add, "On behalf of the provisional government they sent letters to the governor of Russian Turkestan and the Czar of Russia, requesting them to Part Company with Britain and to extend help in putting an end to the British rule in India...The provisional government had also made a suggestion to establish connection with the Turkish government. To achieve this end Ubaydullah wrote a letter on July 9, 1916/1334 to Maulana Mahmood Hasan. Along with it there was a letter from Muhammad Mian Ansari in which there was a mention of the dissemination of the Ghalib Nama and the proposal for the establishment of a provisional government and an army under the name "Hizbullah". It had been suggested to mobilize this army from India...These letters have been written on yellow silk".

Rowlatt Committee report further said, "There was a complete and arranged outline of the Hizbullah in Ubaydullah's letter. The center of this army was to be established at Madina. Maulana Mahmood Hasan himself had to be its commander in-chief. Secondary centers under local commanders were to be established at Constantinople, Tehran and Kabul. Ubaydullah was to be the commander at Kabul. The names of three patrons, twelve generals and several high military officers are given in this list. These

“Silken letters” have come into the hands of the British government. On account of the informations given in these letters some precautions were considered necessary. In 1916/1335 Maulana Mahmood Hasan and tour of his companions were apprehended by the British government. They are at present war prisoners under British surveillance the signatory of the Ghalib Nama, Ghalib Pasha is also a war prisoner. He has confessed that he has signed the letter, which Mahmood Hasan’s Party had put before him”.

Given his stature and experience in leading negotiations at the international level, the Indian National Congress requested him to return to India, he finally came back in the year 1937. Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi settled in Delhi where he taught Shah Waliullah’s magnum opus *Hujjatullahil Baalighah* to Maulana Akbarabadi. In 1944 he died in Lahore, where he had gone to visit his ailing daughter.

While delivering a speech in Karachi, after return from exile, Maulana Sindhi said, “I have returned to India as a messenger of revolution. That day is not far when Britain and America will find it difficult to look after themselves. Do not consider this revolution less than the Day of Reckoning. In my days I have seen men of great learning and fortune begging in the streets. I have seen respectability, honour and status being sold in the bazaars”.

He forewarned the Muslim scholars to reorient and come out of the slumber saying “The world is in danger of confronting the Noah’s Deluge. Dark clouds have gathered all around: the threatening skies are going to burst. Our scholars whose gazes do not go beyond their books are not prepared to look at the

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world around. The knowledge that they are seeking, gaining and imparting, has given them no pulsation and perception in their lives—nor has it given the students any sense of direction, will and vigour to live. Your politicians are busy making great, big schemes and plans which do not fit in with the exigencies and objectives of the day”.

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## Maulana Abul Kalam Azad

**M**aulana Abul Kalam Azad was one of the most prominent freedom fighters who made an ever-lasting impact not just in the war against the British imperialism but also when it came to India's survival as a secular and democratic nation. He was a multidimensional personality whose temporal authority was as deep rooted as his political activism. His spoken words were as powerful as his written texts and his fiery speeches were as forceful as articles published in his magazines Hilal and Comrade.

When boys of his age were busy learning the nuances to write a good line, he was already editing a very well-received magazine and teaching people several times older than him. His achievements in his youth defied logic and his stubborn belief in India's secular credentials –despite widening schism and communal riots – disregarded common perceptions that Hindus and Muslims' living together in a single union was now impossible.

Born on 11 November 1888 in the holy city of Mecca, Hejaz, now known as Saudi Arabia, his full name was Sayyid Abul Kalam Ghulam Muhiyuddin Ahmed Azad. His father, Maulana Sayyid Muhammad Khairuddin bin Ahmed Al Hussaini, was a renowned author and educator who had a

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large number of disciples spread across the world. His mother, Sheikha Alia *bint* Mohammad was the daughter of Sheikh Mohammad bin Zaher AlWatri, a well-known, Medina based scholar.

He was a genius, who was clearly ahead of his time. Maulana was not just a great scholar, a political leader of highest order but also a visionary who, after being appointed India's first education minister, laid the foundation of a revolutionary education system. If the world is enamored by the graduates of Indian Institute of Technology (IITs), the foundation stone of the IIT was laid down in 1951 by none other than Maulana Abul Kalam Azad.

Azad was initially taught by his father. He was an exceptional learner and was interested in mastering as many languages as possible from a very young age. Before he turned 12, he could easily speak Urdu, Hindi, Persian, Bengali, Arabic, and English. His penchant with Arabic and Persian led him to master the two languages like no one else and soon was contributing to different literary magazines even before he turned twelve. Besides language, he was taught complete Darse Nizami that he completed before he turned 15 and started teaching voluminous books of *fiqh*, *hadith*, *ilmul kalam* and other subjects to people much older than him. It is said that Maulana Abul Kalam Azad was also trained in different schools of thoughts as far as Islamic jurisprudence or *fiqh* is concerned. He also studied *tarikhul alam* or the history of the world, science and mathematics. His father hired some of the best teachers available to teach his son these subjects.

The exemplary son didn't disappoint his father and always performed better than his father's expectations.

While Azad was influenced by religion and usually confined himself to writing and contributing to different magazines and teaching, his revolutionary writings created millions of admirers for him at a very young age. These were the people who wanted him to lead the community and the nation at a time when the future of the nation looked bleak. The Muslim community thought it had found in him a messiah or a genius who will remove their miseries and solve their outstanding issues. Initially his writings focused on pan-Islamism. Many people think that renowned Islamic thinker and scholar Maulana Syed Abul Ala Maududi was inspired by Maulana Abul Kalam Azad's writings in his youth.

His writings were inflammatory and he had no inhibition or fear to criticize the British regime. His different magazines that were always critical of the British Raj, espoused the causes of Indian nationalism. His love and obsession with global Islamic Ummah made him the natural leader of the Khilafat movement despite the presence of several stalwarts who were much older than him. His support for the Ottoman Turkey was, besides other reasons, due to the fact that Turkey had sided against the British in the war. Azad saw an opportunity to energize Indian Muslims and achieve major political and social reforms through the struggle.

The British Raj felt threatened due to his increasing popularity across India and banned his very popular journal Al-Hilal. Never to be deterred by such gimmicks, the Maulana launched a new journal, Al-Balagh.

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Soon the new journal, Al - Balagh, was also banned by the Government. Maulana had become such a big threat for the British Raj and their agents across India that he was exiled from Calcutta under the Defence of India Regulations Act. Many provincial governments across the country including those of Punjab, Delhi, United Provinces and Bombay banned him from entering their respective provinces. This ban on his entry in the above mentioned provinces literally blocked his entry into entire North India, except a few states. So he went to Ranchi in Bihar where he was imprisoned till 1 January 1920. It was not the last time he went to jail. From 1920 till 1945 Abul Kalam Azad was in and out of prison a number of times. Nevertheless, these stints in jail didn't deter him from speaking out his mind, criticizing the British Raj or contributing revolutionary articles to different journals in India and beyond.

In the year 1920, after his release from Ranchi prison, Maulana Azad was elected the President of the All India Khilafat Committee at the Calcutta session in 1920. Khilafat Movement was not a Muslim specific movement. On the contrary, it had taken the form of anti-imperial platform that brought Hindus and Muslims onto a single platform. Merely four years later, he was given another huge responsibility in the form of the Presidency of the Unity Conference at Delhi in 1924.

He became one of the most ardent supporters of Mahatma Gandhi and took active role in the Non-Cooperation Movement. Very soon he was at the forefront in the Indian National Congress that he finally joined in January 1920. He



presided over the special session of Congress in September 1923 and was elected as the President of the INC. He was the youngest President that the Congress had in its history.

Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, who had emerged as one of the biggest pillars of India's independence movement, was appointed the President of the Indian National Congress not once but twice. When the Maulana was appointed Congress' President for the first time, he was all of 35-years and was preferred over many old hands who were seeking election as INC president. The first time he was elected the President of the Indian National Congress in 1923 and the second time in 1940. He continued as the President of the Congress till 1946, as no election was held during this period due to the fact that almost every Congress leader was in prison on account of the Quit India Movement in 1942. In the meantime, the Maulana was appointed a member of the Congress Parliamentary Sub - Committee to guide the Provincial Congress Ministries in 1937.

When the Maulana was released from prison, he was given very important responsibility of leading the negotiations with the British Cabinet Mission in 1946.

Maulana Abul Kalam Azad was one of the most secular leaders in the country. He was a firm believer in the co-existence of religions and lived by what he talked. He was one of the most ardent opponents of the partition of the country. While other leaders like Jawaharlal Nehru and Sardar Wallabh Bhai Patel were ready to allow the formation of two nations after the departure of the British Raj, he never supported the creation of Pakistan. There is no denying that

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Maulana Abul Kalam Azad breathed his last on 22 February  
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## Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar

**M**aulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar's name is so much attached to Khilafat Movement that not many people know that he was also the President of Indian National Congress (INC). He was one of the tallest leaders of the freedom movement and was loved and respected by everyone. His fan-following among Hindus was as large as his support base among Muslims.

He was a multi-faceted personality and born in a literary family of Rampur state, a great center of art and culture of the time. Nawabs of Rampur were the most well-known benefactors and patrons of art and literature and Mohammad Ali Jauhar, who was born in the year 1878 in Rampur had the good fortune of being born in a well to do and a literary family.

Abdul Ali Khan, father of Maulana Mohammad Ali, who passed away when the Maulana was just two year old, was associated with the court of the Nawab of Rampur. Nevertheless, despite the fact that he was orphaned at such a young age, he never felt the lack of support while growing up. He was initially taught by his mother, who came to be known to the world as Bi Amma. Later he was formally educated in leading centers of education in Rampur and

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Bareilly. Mohammad Ali Jauhar spent several years in Aligarh, that had become a center of excellence under the leadership of Sir Syed Ahmad Khan.

He was lucky to have an elder brother who acted no less benevolently than a father. When Mohammad Ali impressed everyone with his academic achievements while in Aligarh, he sent him to Oxford for I.C.S. where he chose History and Law as his subjects.

When he returned to India in the year 1898, he was appointed the education director for the entire Rampur state. He helped reform the education scenario in the princely state that was not just a center for art and literature, but also a business and industrial hub in the entire region. He soon felt suffocated in the princely state and left the job. It was certainly a small place for a man who had global ambitions. He went to Baroda where he joined the civil service.

His visionary personality started attracting admirers as he started writing extensively in leading Indian and British journals and newspapers. He was a statesman who never wavered in his resolve and never feared anyone however big or influential that person may be.

His regular writings in leading Indian and foreign newspapers like *The Times*, *London*, *The Manchester Guardian* and *The Observer* made him look like a visionary that the Indian Muslims and the general public was awaiting for decades. Later, in the year 1911 he launched his well-received magazine *The Comrade* in Calcutta. But Kolkata didn't suit

him much and he shifted base to Delhi, from where he launched an Urdu daily, *Hamdard*, in the year 1913.

Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar was not an ordinary person. He was a visionary who foresaw the future and realized that the nation and the Muslim community need to make strides in modern education. This is the reason that he wholeheartedly supported his alma mater and worked for its expansion and development in every possible manner. There is no denying that Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental College that later developed into one of the biggest centers of education in the Sub-Continent had substantial contribution from this born leader. He was one of the people who launched Jamia Millia Islamia in the year 1920. It has become a central university now and has contributed substantially in nation building.

Khilafat Movement that was not exclusively a Muslim movement, but a nationalist movement that was supported by Mahatma Gandhi and Nehru was his brainchild. His Urdu daily, *Hamdard*, that had won him admirers across North India, was instrumental in the success of Khilafat Movement and winning the support of millions and millions of people. The Khilafat Movement was launched in the year 1919.

His unflinching support for the nationalist movement and his abhorrence for everything related to British Raj made him one of the biggest targets of the British rule in the country. Despite all efforts by the British Raj, he continued to express his opinions against the British occupation of the country fearlessly. It was the reason that he spent several years behind bars. But his imprisonment and efforts to sabotage his efforts

to bring the nation onto one platform against British rule couldn't muzzle his voice.

Muhammad Ali Jauhar was in the forefront in the war against British Raj. He wholeheartedly supported Mahatma Gandhi's call for a national civil resistance movement, and inspired hundreds of protests and strikes all over India. He was arrested by British authorities and imprisoned for two years for what was termed as a seditious speech at one such meeting.

Maulana Muhammad Ali Jauhar was elected the President of Indian National Congress (INC) in 1923.

The fearless Maulana, despite his ill-health, went to attend the first Round Table Conference in London in the year 1930. He told the British Government in very clear tone that he would not return to India alive unless the country was set free. "I would prefer to die in a foreign country so long as it is a free country, and if you do not give us freedom in India, you will have to give me a grave here", the Maulana said.

In the Round Table Conference, held in London, Muhammad Ali was very blunt. While speaking during the Round Table Conference, he said, "I have not come to ask for Dominion Status. I do not believe in the attainment of Dominion Status. The one thing to which I am committed is complete independence. In Madras in 1927, we passed a resolution making that our goal."

If that was not enough he went on to add, "We have 320,000,000 of people. When they can afford to die in millions from famine and from plagues, surely they can

afford to die from British bullets too. That is the lesson which Gandhiji wanted to teach us, and that is the lesson which we must learn now. In 1913 I was in this country when Gandhiji was leading his movement in South Africa. Mr. G. K. Chesterton presided over a meeting in the Essex Hall; he called upon me to speak. Other speakers had spoken of Gandhi's new philosophy. I said, "Please understand one thing about that. Whether it is his philosophy or Tolstoy's, Jesus Christ's or mine, it is the universal human philosophy". Nobody wins in a battle if there is merely the will to kill. You must have the will to die even before the will to kill. In India we have not the power to kill, but the moment we develop the will to die, numbers will tell. 320,000,000 of people cannot be killed. There is no mechanization for which you can find money to kill 320,000,000 people. Even if you have got that mechanization, even if you have got the material, you have not the morale to dare to kill 320,000,000 people. We must have in us the will to die for the birth of India as a free and united nation".

The true freedom lover, Maulana Muhammad Ali Jauhar died during the same journey in London on 4 January 1931. He was buried in Jerusalem in the proximity of the Dome of Rock.

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## Dr Maghfoor Ahmad Ajazi

Maghfoor Ahmad Ajazi will always be remembered for his courage to stand up against divisive forces. Despite being rather not very well-known outside Bihar, he fought an all-out war against Muhammad Ali Jinnah by launching an organization that supported Mahatma Gandhi and the Indian National Congress. He didn't give in despite increasing communalization of Indian landscape in the run up to the independence and remained firm in his belief that Muslims and Hindus can take the nation forward through co-operation and working together shoulder to shoulder.

He was a born dissenter and freedom lover. This is the reason that he became active in politics from very early age. It is said that he was expelled from his school for opposing the Anarchical and Revolutionary Crimes Act, 1919 that later came to be known as Rowlatt Act. It was a draconian legislation that was passed by the Imperial Legislative Council in Delhi on 18 March, 1919, indefinitely extending the emergency measures of preventive detention, incarceration without trial and judicial review enacted in the Defence of India Act 1915 during the First World War. The Rowlatt Act was passed to muzzle dissenting voices in the country and not allow the nationalist and revolutionary forces to become



powerful while the British Raj was facing its toughest time in centuries. This gave unlimited power to the British Raj to detain anyone at will and keep him or her behind bars for as long as the Raj wished.

Maghfoor Ahmad Ajazi was born in Dihuli village, Muzaffarpur district in Bihar on 3 March 1900 in a landed and influential family. His father, Moulvi Hafizuddin Husain, initially sent him to a madarsa, then to North Brooke Zila School, Darbhanga, from where he was expelled for opposing the Rowlatt Act. Later he was admitted in another school, Pusa High School, from where he successfully completed his High School. Later he got admission in B.N. College, Patna.

There is no denying that he completely dedicated his life to freedom struggle. This cause was so dear to his heart can be gauged by the fact that when he married Azizul Fatima, the bride and groom both wore hand woven Khadi clothes. It is said that the nikah ceremony was completely transformed into a public meeting where anti-Raj and pro-freedom slogans were raised.

He entered the freedom struggle full throttle in the year 1921, at the age of 21 and joined Mahatma Gandhi's non-cooperation movement. It is said that he used every trick to bring people together behind Mahatma Gandhi. He mobilized people for freedom fight through Ramayan Mandali, and also collected fund for freedom struggle through 'Muthia' drive. 'Muthia' meant to take out a muththi or fistful of grains before preparing every meal to fund freedom struggle. Once, Ajazi unknowingly reached the house of his cousin sister in a remote village. He asked for a 'muthia'. He

got answer in negative. Then his cousin recognised him and requested him to take meal with the family. But Ajazi not just refused to take meal but also a glass of water. When his sister promised him to take out muthia and donated the dues only then he agreed to take meal. He organised 'Sewa Dal' established by Sarojini Naidu and formed 'Ajazi Troop' to promote and train youngsters for freedom struggle.

He came onto the national stage pretty soon and was part of the AICC session held at Ahmedabad in 1921. He was not in support of the dominion status for India as many people in the Congress wanted. He claimed time and again that India cannot remain under British occupation even for a single day and that the Raj had no moral right to subjugate a great nation like India.

This is the reason that he went against many top Congress leaders who had fallen for token freedom under dominion status. Instead he whole-heartedly supported the motion of Maulana Hasrat Mohani for 'Complete Independence'.

When Muhammad Ali Jinnah revived Muslim League and started demanding the creation of Pakistan, Dr Ajazi launched a scathing attack against him and tried to counter him and his ideology at every forum and on every occasion. If that was not enough, he launched Jamhur Muslim League to fight the divisive agenda of Jinnah and his cohorts. This led to his fight with many diehard Jinnah fans who thought him to be the messiah of Muslims.

Dr Ajazi also mobilized workers under various platforms and motivated them to support the Indian National Congress. He

founded several trade union organizations and was the founder president of the Muzaffarpur Electric Supply Workers Union, Arthur Butler Workers Union, North Bihar Railway Labour Union, Motipur Sugar Factory Workers Union and Rickshaw Pullers Union besides many other similar organizations.

He also worked for the progress and development of Urdu language, the lingua franca of the freedom movement. It must be kept in mind that the entire freedom struggle was fought in Urdu, as Hindi was yet to take root as a written or spoken language. Urdu was the main language in much of the present day Hindi heartland besides in areas like Punjab, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Deccan and even present day Maharashtra. Ajazi was one of the founders of Anjuman Taraqqi Urdu since its inception. He was one of the leading lights of Urdu movement in Bihar and when the first Urdu conference in Bihar was held in the year 1936 at Anjuman Islamia Hall, Patna, he was elected its Vice President. The conference was presided over by none other than Babaye Urdu (father of Urdu language) Molvi Abdul Haq. Ajazi breathed his last on 26 September 1966 at his residence in Muzaffarpur city.

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## Dr Mukhtar Ahmad Ansari

Dr Mukhtar Ahmad Ansari was one of the top leaders of India's freedom movement. Born on 25 December 1880 in Ghazipur, in Uttar Pradesh (United Province at that time), he rose to become the president of the Indian National Congress. He was one of the nine Muslim leaders who served as the President of the Indian National Congress.

In the twenties of the last century, when Khilafat Movement became part of the Indian freedom movement and Mahatma Gandhi supported it whole heartedly, Mukhtar Ahmad Ansari seemed to be in his elements. He was not just espousing the cause of the Turkish caliph and opposing the British Raj and its colonial footprints, he was working on the ground too.

As a top medical practitioner, he received both MS and MD degrees from England. He belonged to a very wealthy family and had a roaring practice in Delhi. Dr Ansari was the best choice for the rich and the famous when it came to be treated by a medical physician. At a time when political leadership was dominated by lawyers, Dr Mukhtar Ansari was among the very few exceptions. He was one of the wealthiest people in Delhi and hosted top Indian National Congress leaders

including Mahatma at his palatial house in the heart of Shahjahanabad, Old Delhi.

Dr Ansari was a firm believer in doing what he believed. So no one was surprised when he decided to go all the way to the actual battle ground during the Balkans war and treat the injured Turkish troops. He must be among very few committed people from India who treated Turk soldiers during the Balkan War. It proves his dedication to the cause and very strong character.

While writing about him in *Scroll*, Danish Khan says, “Ansari was a close companion of Gandhi and an icon of the Khilafat movement. The few scholars who have studied his life have focused solely on his role as a Congress leader, and on his skills on the negotiating table of high politics. His exploits with the scalpel have been ignored. More than 80 years after he died, on May 10, 1936, it is remarkable that forget any serious study, there is hardly any discussion about the hundreds of operations he conducted in India in which he grafted animal testicles – from bulls, monkeys and sheep – onto human beings.

It is said that Dr Mukhtar Ahmad Ansari’s forefathers came to India during the reign of Sultan Muhammad Bin Tughlaq. They settled at Yusufpur, now in the Ghazipur District of UP and held respectable governmental positions. The family, over the course of several centuries held many positions in different kings’ and nawabs’ courts and enjoyed leadership role in the entire region.

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Mukhtar Ahmad Ansari graduated from Victoria High School, Ghazipur in the year 1896. He moved to Hyderabad, where two of his brothers were in the royal court of the Nizam of Deccan and got admission in Madras Medical College. After completing his medical degree from Madras Medical College, Mukhtar Ahmad Ansari was awarded prestigious Nizam State Scholarship for higher medical education. He went to England and qualified for M.D. and M.S. in 1905, topping the list of successful candidates. Due to his exceptional academic performance, he became the only Indian to be appointed Registrar at Lock Hospital, London. Later he was taken as the House Surgeon at Charing Cross Hospital, London. The hospital acknowledged Dr Ansari's outstanding services in the field of surgery by opening a ward in his name as the Ansari Ward.

Mukhtar Ahmad Ansari became politically active during his stay in England where he came in contact with Indian National Congress leaders who used to visit London quite frequently. It is said that it was during his stay in London that he not just came in contact with top leaders of the freedom movement but developed close friendship with the likes of Motilal Nehru and Hakim Ajmal Khan, besides many others. Historic accounts suggest it was here that he met Muhammad Ali Jinnah, who was still a nationalist leader. Besides, he also met Jawaharlal Nehru, who after Independence became the first Prime Minister of India.

Mukhtar Ahmad Ansari came back to India in the year 1910 and after staying for sometimes in places like his hometown and Hyderabad, decided to settle down in Delhi. He bought a

palatial house here and soon became the royal physician of wealthy maharajas and nawabs in North India.

Despite being very active in politics and India's freedom movement, medical research remained his passion. A report in *The wire* says, "Along with his political activity, Ansari turned his mind to a matter that has obsessed physicians for centuries: the quest for medical interventions to help ageing clients produce heirs. In the early 20th century, medical journals in Europe and America were increasingly documenting cases of xenotransplantation – the transplantation of living cells, tissue or organs from one species to another. It was through such articles that Ansari became interested in this field".

The report goes on to add, "In 1921, 1925 and 1932 he visited Vienna, Paris, Lucerne and London and spent a considerable amount of time in laboratories, hospitals and clinics. He met and observed urologist Dr Robert Lichtenstern, Eugen Steinach, Dr Serge Voronoff – all of whom are considered pioneers in the field of grafting animal testicles onto humans. He also collected vast amounts of literature on the subject, sourcing books and journals from Germany, France, Switzerland, Austria and the US".

After getting back to India, Dr Ansari joined both the Indian National Congress and the Muslim League. At that time, the Muslim League was a nationalist outfit mainly representing the Muslims. It is no secret that he was instrumental in the negotiation of the 1916 Lucknow Pact and served as the Muslim League's president in 1918 and 1920. Lucknow Pact refers to an agreement reached between the moderates,

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militant factions of the Indian National Congress and the Muslim League at the joint session of both the parties, held in Lucknow, in the year 1916. Dr Mukhtar Ahmad Ansari and Jinnah both of whom were members of the Congress as well as the Muslim League, made both the parties reach an agreement to pressurize the British government to adopt a more liberal approach to India and give Indians more authority to run their country, besides safeguarding basic Muslim demands. Dr Ansari's role in the Lucknow Pact went on to increase his popularity among two nationalist core groups, Hindus and Muslims.

Dr. Ansari served several terms as the AICC General Secretary as well as the President of the Indian National Congress during its 1927 session. He opposed Jinnah's divisive theory and became closer to Mahatma Gandhi and the Congress Party. He took a keen interest in the establishment of independent national institutions for higher education, two of them being the Jamia Millia Islamia, New Delhi and the Kashi Vidyapith at Benares. For him, both were close to his heart, as anti-imperialism was the reason behind their genesis.

From its inception on 29 October 1920 Jamia Millia Islamia had the unconditional support of Dr Ansari. He was elected its Chancellor after the death of the first Chancellor, Hakim Ajmal Khan



## Ashfaqulla Khan

Ashfaqulla Khan, who is reverently called Shaheed Ashfaqulla Khan by his admirers across the Indian Subcontinent was born on 22 October 1900 in Shahjahanpur, Uttar Pradesh (United Province). His ancestral home, called Kothi still stands magnificently in Shahjehanpur's Jalal Nagar locality. Every year, on 15 August and 26 January, this home becomes a place to remember the supreme sacrifices made by Ashfaqulla Khan, Bismil and others. These were the people who were prepared to give up everything for the freedom of the nation.

Most people wouldn't believe that this freedom fighter died so young. Many think that he was put to death by British Raj in his twilight years. But to be true he died when he was in the prime of his youth. When he was hanged to death by the British Raj, he was all of 27 years.

Since his supreme sacrifice for the nation, he has become a hero whose sacrifices are remembered and narrated by people of all hues. Nevertheless, in recent past, there has been a conscious effort to make people forget not just Shaheed Ashfaqulla Khan but many other people who fought for the nation and sacrificed everything for the cause of freedom of the country from British Raj. These were the people who

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spent years behind bars –many spending decades in prison cells –even going to the extent of giving up their lives for the cause.

Born to his father Shafiqur Rahman and mother Mazharunissa, Ashfaqullah Khan was the youngest of the six children. His father was associated with the police department.

The young Ashfaqulla got enamored by Mahatma Gandhi and the freedom struggle at very young age. A whole-hearted supporter of the Non-Cooperation Movement, Mahatma Gandhi had massive influence on his thinking. It later shaped him to become a freedom fighter. He was labeled as a terrorist by the British Government for his active participation in the train robbery at Kakori.

There is no denying that after the Chauri Chaura incident, Mahatma Gandhi's withdrawal of the Non-Cooperation Movement left the youth of India very depressed. Ashfaqulla was one of them. He felt the urge to free India as soon as possible and joined the extremist elements among the freedom fighters.

He was a man who never feared death. On the contrary he saw death eye to eye, without ever fearing for himself. For him the nation, its honour and its freedom were the only things that mattered. A letter that he wrote to Sachinder Nath Bakshi's sister, whom he called didi, merely three days before he was hanged, is enough proof towards this end.

"I am going to the next-world, where there is no worldly pains and there would not have to struggle for a better life.

Where, there will have death or mortality. I am not going to die but going to live forever. After comrade Bakshi's release, say my love with regards to him and tell him that I breathed last with a firm mind and cheerful heart. The last day is Monday. If circumstances are not favourable then I depart from all of you forever. Accept my last Bande Matram... let me pass away. You will come to know afterwards that how I die. May God be with you, with all His blessings. My B.C. to Baba and love to Savetri, Gaur, Kanoo and other children and Bandey to Nepal. B.C. to all my elders and love to the youngsters. It is my desire to see you all once more in my life. You may come if possible. I think of God and feel not for me. Let Bakshi know about me. I regard you as my sister and you would not forget me. Be cheerful I am dying like Heroes", wrote Shaheed Ashfaquallah Khan.

He became good friend with renowned revolutionary poet, Ram Prasad Bismil, also from Shahjahanpur at a very young age. The two came in contact in the year 1922, when Non Cooperation Movement was launched and Bismil was mobilizing youths in its favor in the region. The two met in one such meeting and hit it off immediately when Ashfaquallah told him that he also writes poems under the pen-names of 'Warsi' and 'Hasrat'. Bismil listened to some of his couplets in a private get-together at Shahjahanpur and they became good friends. To be true, when it comes to poetry, Bismil corrected Ashfaq's works.

There is no denying that their friendship seems very strange from outset. Ram Prasad Bismil was a dedicated member of Arya Samaj, while Ashfaquallah Khan was a devout Muslim.

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Religion never came in between their relationship, something very uncommon those days.

Their friendship was so strong and their resolution so pure and powerful, that they sacrificed their lives on the same day as martyrs for India. The two were hanged to death on 19 December 1927, Ashfaqullah Khan in Faizabad jail while Ram Prasad Bismil in Gorakhpur prison.

Kakori train robbery was the most daring act of defiance. Bismil and Ashfaqullah Khan came to know that government money was transported through railways. Station masters from different stations gave money to the train guard travelling on train who kept the money in a cash chest in his cabin. This cash chest was handed over to the station superintendent at Lucknow railway station. On 9 August 1925, Ashfaqulla Khan and eight other revolutionaries looted the train under the leadership of Ram Prasad Bismil. These youths had come to the conclusion that in order to fund their revolutionary war they needed funds.

The incident was a huge embarrassment to the British Raj and thus Viceroy asked Scotland Yard to investigate the case. The British government had a widespread secret service at its disposal and thus, within a month the investigation was completed and it was decided to arrest almost all of the revolutionaries overnight. On the morning of 26 September 1925, Pandit Ram Prasad Bismil and the others from Shahjahanpur were arrested by the police. Ashfaq was the only one who was able to evade the police. Ashfaq went into hiding and moved to Varanasi, from where he went to Bihar. There he worked in an engineering company for about ten

months. He also wanted to go abroad and meet Lala Har Dayal for his concrete help in the freedom struggle. He went to Delhi to find out how to move out of the country. In Delhi, he took the help of one of his Pathan friends who in turn betrayed him by informing the police who arrested Ashfaq. He was given death sentence along with Bismil and two others on 19 December 1927.

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## Maulana Hasrat Mohani

Maulana Hasrat Mohani was among the top revolutionary poets who became the bedrock of freedom movement in the country. His real name was Syed Fazl-ul-Hasan, though not many people will recognize him by his name.

Born on 1 January 1875 in Mohan, Unnao district, in United Province (present day UP), Maulana was a renowned poet and leading freedom fighter who also coined the slogan 'Inquilab Zindabad' (long live the revolution).

The word Mohani, in his pen name, actually refers to his place of Birth, Mohan. Hasrat Mohani represented a class of people in the Indian freedom struggle who were above religious differences. For him, Hindu deity Krishna was a revered personality. As he wrote *Hamd* and *Naat*, besides different genres of ghazal and Urdu poetry, he also wrote poems expressing admiration for Krishna. This was an anathema to many Muslims. Nevertheless, Hasrat Mohani shouted down everyone who commented on his love for Krishna.

While there were many people fighting for freedom on the streets, raising slogans against the British Raj, Maulana Hasrat Mohani fought for the freedom on ideological level.

Dr CM Nayeem, while writing in Outlook magazine about the inimitable revolutionary said, "In 1908 he published an anonymous article in his modest Urdu journal, *Urdu-e-Mu'alla*, which severely criticized the British colonial policy in Egypt concerning education. The authorities in India promptly charged him with "sedition." Refusing to disclose the name of the author, he took sole responsibility for the article; consequently, he had to spend over 12 months in "rigorous imprisonment"—i.e. hand-grinding with another "C" class prisoner one maund (37.3 kgs) of grain every day".

He aptly expressed his predicament in one of his couplets:

*Hai mashqi sukhan jaaree chakkee kee mushaqqat bhee*

*Ik turfah tamaashah hai hasrat kee tabee`at bhee*

(Hasrat is continuing his hobby of composing verses side by side with the grinding of wheat. What a peculiar nature does Hasrat possess!)

He was a free spirit who could never reconcile himself to the dominion status as being talked about by many in the Indian National Congress. CM Nayim, in the same article says, "In 1921 three major political parties held their annual meetings in the same week at Ahmedabad. At the All India Khilafat Conference, he succeeded in getting a resolution passed that called for India's total freedom from the colonial rule, but the next day, not surprisingly, the delegates quickly repudiated themselves. He then tried his luck in the Subjects Committee

of the Indian National Congress, but the Mahatma, rushing back from another meeting, made sure the resolution was firmly defeated. Finally, at the meeting of the All India Muslim League, he forcefully expressed his call in his presidential address, but wisely abstained from asking for a vote”.

Maulana Hasrat Mohani was one of the best poets of his time. A brilliant student throughout his student days, he topped in his first state level exam and went to Aligarh Muslim University for higher studies. In Aligarh, he had the good fortune of developing friendship with the likes of Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar and his elder brother Maulana Shaukat Ali besides many other people who later went on to play major roles in the Indian freedom struggle. These friendships seem to have moulded his mind, making him fond of independence at any cost.

Hasrat Mohani, despite not belonging to the Deobandi ulama, seemed to be very impressed by the likes of Mahmud al-Hasan and his colleague Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi. Under their influence he demanded 'Complete Independence' (*Azadi-e-Kaamil*) in 1921 as he presided over an annual session of All India Muslim League. He was jailed for many years by British Raj and was among the founders of the Communist Party of India.

Maulana was also imprisoned for promoting anti-British ideas, especially for publishing an article against British policies in Egypt, in his magazine *Urdu-e-Mualla*. Unlike some Urdu poets like Josh Malihabadi and Nasir Kazmi, and many others he chose to live in India rather than move to



Pakistan after independence to represent left over Indian Muslims on various platforms. In recognition for his efforts, he was made a member of the Constituent Assembly which drafted the Indian Constitution. Nevertheless, Hasrat Mohani never signed it.

While he was a devout Muslim, he didn't find it odd to be inspired by Krishna, the Hindu deity. Makkah, Mathura and Moscow were Hasrat Mohani's popular symbols. He did not find any conflict between them. While he performed Haj several times, he took out time on numerous occasions to visit Mathura to seek inspiration from the teachings and philosophy of Krishna.

On many occasions he was loath to accept Mahatma Gandhi's views that he thought were too lenient towards the British Raj. This may be due to the fact that he was revolutionary to the core and had no patience for tactics employed by top leadership of the Indian National Congress. Nonetheless, he admired Gandhi and once comparing him with Lenin said,

*'Gandhi ki tarah baith ke kaateinge kyun charkha,*

*Lenin ki tarah denge na duniya ko hila hum'?*

(Why waste time with Gandhi's spinning wheel,

And not usher a revolution with Lenin's zeal?)

He was a frail looking man. But his physical frailty possessed a resolute mind of steel. In a memorable speech in the Constituent Assembly, Maulana Hasrat Mohani told India's Home Minister, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel "You should not

think that Muslims are orphans today. I am here to defend their rights against all odds and will fight for them till death.”

He was a poet of highest order and authored numerous books on poetry. *Kulliyat-e-Hasrat Mohani*, *Sharh-e-Kalam-e-Ghalib*, *Nukaat-e-Sukhan*, *Mushahidaat-e-Zindaan* are his well-known publications that are still available across the Subcontinent.

## Maulana Muhammad Mian Mansoor Ansari

When it comes to the freedom movement of the country, people seem to have forgotten the contribution of many stalwarts of the past who put the foundation of the nation's independence from the British Raj. There are a large number of people who spent long years in prison cells for their anti-British Raj stance.

These were the people who risked their lives, spent long years in exile for their only crime that they wanted to see India freed from British Raj and their occupation of the sacred land of India.

One such personality is Muhammad Mian Mansoor Ansari. Born on 10 March 1884 he was one of the few people closest to Shaikhul Hind Maulana Madmud al-Hasan and instrumental in launching a government in exile in Kabul. When Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi was sent to Kabul by Shaikhul Hind in the first quarter of the last century to launch a government in exile, he accompanied the revered scholar and India's most respected freedom fighter, Mahmud al-Hasan, to Hejaz. Not many people know that this government in exile survived for as long as five years.

Muhammad Mian Mansoor Ansari was one of the top leaders of Reshmi Rumal Tehrik (The Silk Letter Movement). This movement or struggle was launched by the *Ulama* of Deoband (scholars associated with Darul Uloom, Deoband and its affiliates) who were at the forefront against British occupation in early twentieth century. The movement launched sometimes in 1912 saw them launch a government in exile in Kabul and establish relationship with the German, Russian and Turkish government, the arch of enemies of the British Raj. Nevertheless, the Silk Letter Movement was uncovered by Punjab CID with the capture of letters from Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi, one of the Deobandi leaders then in Afghanistan, to Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan, Shaykhul Hind and the top leader of the freedom movement at the time. The letters were written in silk cloth, hence the name.

Muhammad Mian Mansoor Ansari played a pivotal role in the entire Silk Letter Movement, establishment of government in exile in Kabul and seeking legitimacy for this government from world powers. Muhammad Mian Mansoor Ansari went to Hejaz with Maulana Mahmud al Hasan in September 1915. He returned to India in April 1916 with Ghalib Nama (Silk Letter) which he showed to freedom fighters in India and the autonomous areas and then took it to Kabul where he reached in June 1916.

The Maulana was born in Saharanpur, a center of education in Western UP. He grew up in the house of Allama Abdullah Ansari. Mansoor Ansari came to the Darul-Uloom Deoband and gradually became involved in the struggle for India's independence. After his graduation from Darul Uloom,

Deoband, he taught in different institutions across North India. A year before India's eventual independence, he died after thirty-one years of exile.

During World War-I, he was among the leaders of the Deoband School, who, led by Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan, left India to seek support of world powers to overthrow the British Raj. It has been well-documented as to how Maulana Mansoor Ansari went to Kabul during the war to rally the Afghan Amir Habibullah Khan. He joined the Provisional Government of India formed in Kabul in December 1915, and remained in Afghanistan until the end of the war. He traveled to Russia and spent two years in Turkey, as well as passing through many other countries.

Despite the fact that he spent decades away from the homeland due to his involvement in its freedom movement, he had a huge number of admirers in the country. Indian National Congress requested the great scholar and freedom fighter to come back to India and guide the freedom movement here. Indian National Congress asked the British Government to allow him to enter India. He was allowed, but he couldn't come here and remained in Kabul, where he began a programme of teaching and translating exegesis of Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan. This illustrious son of India breathed his last one and half years before India's independence on 11 January 1946 in Jalalabad, Afghanistan.

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## Asaf Ali

Asaf Ali wore numerous hats in his lifetime spanning 65 years. The man, who fought for India's independence after coming back to India following completion of his education from England, was among the highest rated lawyers in the country and was a great strength to Indian freedom movement.

Asaf Ali was above divisive politics based on caste or religion and wanted Hindus and Muslims to live together peacefully. He espoused it throughout his life and struggled to keep the nation united as he did everything to fight the British Raj on every possible turf.

Born on 11 May 1888, Asaf Ali was an Indian independence fighter and a renowned lawyer. He was not just another Indian lawyer. There is no denying that he became the top lawyer of India's freedom movement and fought the cases of iconic freedom fighters including Shaheed Bhagat Singh and Batukeshwar Dutt. The two had been accused of throwing a bomb in the Central Legislative Assembly on 8 April 1929, during the passage of a controversial ordinance.

A brief sketch of him in The Hindu says that he was "tried in 1918 under the Defence of India Act. He defended himself

successfully, and thereafter threw himself heart and soul into the freedom movement. Asaf Ali was jailed several times during the Congress campaign...An active member of the Muslim Nationalist Party, he was elected in 1935 from Delhi to the Central Legislative Assembly by a thumping majority drawing strong support from both Muslims and Hindus. In a later election as a Congress candidate, he was re-elected defeating a Muslim League candidate. Chosen as Deputy Leader of the Congress Party in the Assembly, he took keen interest in External Affairs, Defence, and Constitutional matters. As a member of the Interim Government of India from September 2, 1946, he held charge of Transport and Railways”.

Like most freedom fighters in the country, when Britain attacked the Ottoman Empire in the year 1914, Asaf Ali supported the Turkish side and resigned from the Privy Council. He saw this as an act of non-cooperation and returned to India in December 1914.

After coming back to India in the year 1914, Asaf Ali started his legal career at Delhi Bar. It must be added here that most of the leaders of India's freedom movement were lawyers of highest caliber who had studied in England. It is no surprise that Asaf Ali too became deeply involved in politics as the defence counsel in several celebrated trials, including the appeal of Bhagat Singh in the Punjab High Court against the sentence of death upon him in Saundeers Case. His first active role in the cause of India's freedom was played in the old Home Rule League organized by Mrs. Annie Basant during the First World War.

He was an outspoken critic of British Raj and never shied away from speaking out against the oppressive regime. Pretty soon he got attracted to Mahatma Gandhi. But it was a case of mutual respect. He and Mahatma both had respect and admiration for each other. He jumped into the Non Cooperation Movement full throttle and in as early as 1918 he was arrested and tried under the Defence of India Act. It is surprising that he fought his own case himself, pleading in his own behalf. Following his eloquent defence, he was acquitted.

He was fortunate in the year 1918 while defending himself. Nevertheless, he was not so fortunate the next time. When he was arrested in 1921 he defended himself and was sentenced to 18 months' rigorous imprisonment.

His involvement in the Khilafat Movement was result of his close proximity to Mahatma Gandhi who had supported the Khilafat Movement to further the anti-Raj sentiments in the country. When he came out of prison, he became active in the Khilafat movement. His understanding of Gandhism and the non-cooperation movement was so thorough and complete that in 1921 he wrote 'Constructive Non-Cooperation' which may be aptly described as the catechism of Gandhian political tactics. In 1927 he was made the Secretary-General of the Congress Party and three years later, in 1930, a member of the Congress Working Committee.

He remained in and out of jail, but every jail term strengthened his resolve to free India from the clutches of the oppression. From 1934 and 1946 he served in the Central Legislative Assembly, acting from time to time as his party's Chief Whip, its Secretary-General and its Deputy Leader.



In the year 1935, he was elected to the Central Legislative Assembly in 1935 as a member of the Muslim Nationalist Party and was later re-elected as a Congress candidate against a Muslim League candidate and was chosen as deputy leader. In 1945, Asaf Ali became the convener of the INA defence team established by the Congress for the defense of the officers of the Indian National Army charged with treason in November 1945.

His marriage to another leader of freedom struggle, Aruna Ganguli, who later became known as Aruna Asaf Ali created a major controversy. Besides the religious differences –she was a Hindu and he was a Muslim – there was huge age difference between the two. Aruna was 21 years younger than him. He was the first ambassador of India to United States and later served as the governor of Odisha. He died in office in Bern, while serving as India's ambassador to Switzerland.

## Maulana Husain Ahmad Madani

Maulana Husain Ahmad Madani was an Islamic scholar, freedom fighter and a close comrade of Shaykhul Hind Mahmood al-Hasan. There is near unanimity that Shaykhul Hind was the architect of the Indian freedom movement, Reshmi Roomal Tehrik and the founder of India's government in exile in Kabul.

Maulana Madani is one of the Deobandi leaders who have hogged maximum limelight due to the fact that his children and their later generations have remained politically relevant till now. Barbara Metcalf's book on the life of Husain Ahmad Madani brought him out of ignominy of being completely forgotten by the world. It firmly strengthened his position as a scholar of repute and a freedom fighter.

Born on 6 October 1879 in Bangarmau in Unnao district in United Province, his father's name was Sayyid Habibullah. They were originally the residents of Tanda in District Faizabad.

After being initially taught by his father, he was sent to the Darul Uloom Deoband, in the year 1892 at the age of 13. Here he had the good fortune of being taught and mentored by none other than Shaykhul Hind, Maulana Mahmud al-

Hasan, the top scholar of the time and the founder of India's freedom movement. After graduating from Darul Uloom Deoband he went to renowned sufi of the time, Rasheed Ahmad Gangohi, and became his disciple.

One aspect of India's freedom movement is the fact that the freedom movement was launched by ulama associated with Darul Uloom, Deoband. These were the people, who despite being very religious always abhorred communal division. Hussein Ahmed Madani shifted to Medina after completion of his education at Darul Uloom. His biographers believe that Madani spent close to twenty years in Medina teaching Arabic grammar, *usul al-fiqh*, *usul al-hadith*, and Quranic exegesis. Later, when Madani returned, he was appointed as Shaikhul Hadith or the Head of the Department of Hadith at Darul Uloom Deoband. He served in this position for approximately 28 years.

When Shaykhul Hind, Mahmud al-Hasan was arrested in Mecca where he had gone to seek support of the Turkish government for the government in exile in Kabul, Afghanistan and incarcerated in Malta, Husain Ahmad Madani went there to live with his teacher out of his own free will. Mahmud al-Hasan was kept in Malta prison for three years. It is said that he memorized the entire Holy Qur'an within thirty days on the wish of his teacher and read it aloud during *Taraweeh* prayers in the holy month of Ramadan.

Barbara Metcalf, while writing in her book *Husain Ahmad Madani: The Jihad for Islam and India's Freedom* says, "Maulana Husain Ahmad intended to accompany Maulana Mahmudul Hasan back to India. But it was not at all clear

whether he would stay in India or return to his shattered family in Medina. This indecision may seem astonishing given the role that Husain Ahmad was to play in the nationalist movement virtually from the moment he stepped ashore. But while his political education in Malta had intensified his anti-colonialism, that was a cause he could pursue in Medina or elsewhere and whatever he did politically, in any case, was always understood by him to be above all in the service of Islamic learning and Islamic practice”.

“Husain Ahmad's Indian ties were deep, to be sure, but his ties to the Hijaz and his two surviving brothers were deep as well. In the end, it was his bond to Maulana Mahmudul Hasan that proved critical in his decision. In the course of the trip, he agreed that he would stay in India because his revered elder said he needed him to aid in the completion of the hadith commentary that he had started during internment” Metcalf goes on to add.

After the release of his teacher from Malta he came back to India and entered the freedom struggle full throttled. He was the member of foundation committee (for Jamia Millia Islamia) headed by Sheikhul-Hind Maulana Mahmood al-Hasan.

Husain Ahmad Madani was against the two-nation theory, and predominantly due to this, a large number of Muslims from Eastern UP and Bihar refused to migrate to Pakistan at the time of creation of Pakistan and the Partition of India in 1947. He became the President of the Jamiat Ulema-e-Hind, a post he held until his death in 1957.

He was staunchly opposed to the creation of Pakistan, saying that it was completely unrealistic and was destined to be a flop. He also said that it will continue to allow the British and other European powers to meddle in the affairs of the two nations. Now we know as to how true he was. Barbara Metcalf, while writing in the introduction of her book 'Husain Ahmad Madani: The Jihad for Islam and India's Freedom' says, "Maulana Madani's opposition to British colonialism in India consistently focused on specific grievances of colonial injustice. He later would oppose Pakistan, first and foremost, because he believed that two countries, instead of one strong united one, would afford opportunities for continued European intervention and meddling (as cold war politics for decades in fact confirmed). He persistently regarded the idea of dividing the Muslim population as utterly unrealistic, given the social and economic relationship of Hindus and Muslims throughout the country, even in the Muslim majority areas".

Maulana Madani spelled out what he thought by composite nationalism in an essay. "All individuals and communities living in India have many things in common that have been violated by the foreign rulers for their vested interests...Since Indians are suffering because they have lost sight of their common interests, they need to struggle to regain their lost rights. It is incumbent on them to make a united effort to throw off the yoke of foreign slavery and open avenues for the progress of the citizens of India. The objective is to establish composite nationalism on the basis of national unity. The life of Prophet Mohammad to achieve such an

objective through the formation of a United Front with the non-Muslims” said he. Madani breathed his last in the year 1957.

## Aruna Asaf Ali (Kulsum Zamani)

**A**runa Asaf Ali was among the top Indian freedom fighters. She was one of the very few women who went on to hog limelight and at one time led the freedom movement when in early forties of the last century almost all the top leaders of the freedom struggle (jihad-e-azadi) were behind bars.

Born as Aruna Ganguly on 16 July 1909 she revived the freedom struggle in 1942 during the Quit India Movement when she hoisted the Indian National Congress flag at the Gowalia Tank Maidan in Bombay. At the tender age of 19, going against the wishes of her father, she married Asaf Ali, a renowned England educated lawyer who was Muslim and 22 years older than her.

After marriage she took the name of Kulsum Zamani, though she continued to be known as Aruna Asaf Ali. Even now, very few people seem to know her name that she took after marrying Asaf Ali.

She hailed from Barisal district in Bengal. It is now a part of Bangladesh. Her father, Upendranath Ganguly was a restaurateur while her mother was Ambalika Devi, the

daughter of Trailokyanath Sanyal, a renowned Brahmo leader who wrote many Brahmo hymns

Hers was a modern and highly educated family. One of her father's brothers was a Bollywood film director, while another brother Nagendranath, a university professor who went on to marry Nobel Prize winner Rabindranath Tagore's daughter Mira Devi. Purnima Banerjee, Aruna's sister was a member of the Constituent Assembly of India.

She got into politics through her lawyer husband Asaf Ali, who was deep into freedom struggle and was a close companion of Mahatma Gandhi. He was also active in Khilafat Movement and had fought the cases of Bhagat Singh and other freedom fighters in different courts of law. Reports suggest that Aruna's husband supported the Khilafat Movement to further the anti-Raj sentiments in the country. When he came out of prison, he became active in the Khilafat Movement. His understanding of Gandhism and the Non-Cooperation Movement was so thorough and complete that in 1921 he wrote 'Constructive Non-Co-operation' which may be aptly described as the catechism of Gandhian political tactics. Inspired by her husband she devoted herself to the cause of freedom struggle of the country.

Her biographers suggest that Aruna Asaf Ali was greatly influenced by Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru and thus soon joined the Civil Disobedience Movement of 1930. When her husband was arrested during the Salt Satyagraha, she didn't hesitate for a moment before joining the bands of Satyagrahis. She too was arrested and packed off to Lahore jail to serve a one-year prison term. If that was not enough,



Aruna Asaf Ali was arrested for being part of the freedom movement in 1932 and was put behind bars. She remained active in jail and organized women from behind prison wall. Aruna was later packed off to Ambala, where there was no separate prison for women.

Inder Malhotra, while writing in *The Guardian* says, "Aruna Asaf Ali was among the tens of thousands of young Indians who immediately responded to the Mahatma's call. She was, in fact, given the honour of hoisting the Congress tri-colour in Bombay at the meeting in August 1942 where Gandhi asked the British Raj to pack up and go...A documentary film made at that time shows Aruna to be a woman of striking beauty and energy. While 100,000 Indians, including such prominent Congress socialists as Jaya Prakash Narayan, were arrested and imprisoned, Aruna successfully went underground and escaped arrest, despite the best efforts of the police...In 1946, when the endgame of the British Raj had already begun, Gandhi personally asked her to come out into the open because 'your mission has been fulfilled'.

Finally on the request of Mahatma Gandhi she emerged from her long absence from limelight. It is surprising as to how, despite their best efforts, intelligence agencies and police couldn't arrest Aruna Asaf Ali. It is all the more surprising as police had offered a huge reward of Rs 5000 for anyone giving information leading to her arrest. It must be kept in mind that this was a princely sum at that time. When on Mahatma Gandhi's request, she emerged from underground and returned to Delhi, it was an occasion rejoiced by her family and friends. After years of struggle and action, the rebel in

Aruna had emerged stronger than ever before. She openly differed with leaders like Gandhiji, Nehru and Maulana Azad, but mutual respect and affection did not allow a serious break.

To be true, she even differed from her husband when he joined the Interim Government. When Asaf Ali accepted the ministership of Communications, Aruna was unhappy. She made it her mission to work for the women community who were oppressed by men. She wanted women to be emancipated from the clutches of men. She said that only through education women can be liberated. Aruna wanted to establish a printing and publishing organization to spread intellectual enlightenment. It was thus that the "Link" a weekly journal, and later "Patriot", a daily newspaper, were started. She breathed her last on 29 July 1996.

## Peer Ali Khan

Peer Ali Khan is one hero of India's war of independence who has been completely forgotten by the nation. Not many people seem to have any knowledge about his contribution, nor how badly he was treated by the British Raj and how the English officers hanged him to death for spearheading the war of independence in the year 1857 in Patna and surrounding places.

Peer Ali Khan played a stellar role in India's first war of independence, known in history as Ghadar or the Mutiny. While many people with not really much role have been praised for their 'contribution' in India's freedom struggle, people like Peer Ali Khan don't find much mention despite giving supreme sacrifices with their lives.

He remains rather an unsung hero. Not much is known about his childhood life, but what is known is that he was born in Muhammadpur village, Azamgarh district of present day Uttar Pradesh. Peer Ali Khan ran away from his home to Patna at the age of seven, and was raised there by a local landlord, Nawab Mir Abdullah. It is said that he was fiercely independent. Nawab Mir Abdullah raised him like his own son and provided him education like other kids of his age. It

is said that Peer Ali learned Urdu, Arabic and Persian and some basic mathematics from teachers at a local school. Nawab Mir Abdullah inculcated the hatred for the occupation forces in his young mind and helped him learn more about the oppressive tactics of the British Raj and East India Company.

Being raised as a fiercely independent individual who cherished his independence he opened a book shop in the heart of Patna. It is said that he used to sell beautifully handwritten and calligraphed books and literature. The shop soon started attracting youths from all over Patna who also had similar hatred for the occupation forces of Britain and East India Company. Many Indians working in British Army in Danapur camp came in contact with him at his shop and became good friends of Peer Ali Khan.

There are stories suggesting that Peer Ali Khan also arranged regular meetings and get togethers of his friends, admirers and followers. Besides, he and his friends also tried to educate the local population about the oppression and exploitation of the common people by the British Raj.

*Excavation of Truth: Unsung Heroes of 1857 War of Independence* by KM Khan throws very valuable light on the life and contribution of Peer Ali Khan. The book while discussing the contribution of Peer Ali Khan says that Khan was planning for a big uprising against the Britons with the support of the Indian soldiers of Danapur. Nevertheless, as the British officials got hold of two letters addressed by Danapur cantonment's Indian soldiers to Peer Ali Khan, the entire plan was revealed to them. The British officials arrested

Waris Ali, an officer in the British army, who was Khan's close associate and main link between him and mutineers of Danapur.

The book by KM Khan says that Peer Ali and his supporters had a flag of white and blue colour. When Peer Ali Khan and his supporters launched their mutiny against the British Raj, he distributed as many as 50 guns among his supporters which were arranged with the help of Maulwi Mehdi (a patrolling magistrate of Patna who was arrested and sentenced to death without trial on 20th June, 1857). Moreover, Ghulam Abbas was given the charge of flag bearer and Nandu Khar was directed to take position at the Haweli of the Padri and keep a watch on the insiders.

The book goes on to add that when the mutineers rebelled against the British Raj, Peer Ali Khan and his 200 followers marched towards Gulzar Bagh, the headquarters of the state administration. They were waylaid by Dr. Lloyal, the Assistant to the Agent of Opium Godown in Patna who was accompanied by some local soldiers. When these people were attacked by the British officer's companions, they retaliated, killing Dr. Lloyal on the spot. Commissioner of Patna W. Taylor, the top official of the British Raj in the area came to know about the incident and ordered a Sikh battalion to rush to the troubled spot and crush turbulence. Subsequently, the British forces indiscriminately fired at the crowd and this resulted in killing and injuring of a large number of people.

Most surprising is the fact that the Indian troops employed by the British Raj didn't confine to killing the protesters, they went on rampage in the city, looting a number of houses

and killing many people and arresting a large number of people, many of whom had nothing to do with the uprising. A number of people, arrested from their homes were hanged to death on trees in full public view to create terror in the minds of the onlookers. On 4<sup>th</sup> July, Peer Ali and 33 of his associates were arrested in pre-dawn attack and by the order of the Commissioner, most of them were hanged the next day. Peer Ali's shop was broken open, thoroughly searched and documents seized from there. For three days, he was interrogated and tortured to obtain information about conspiracy and details of his close associates, especially Lutf Ali. But Peer Ali Khan did not open his mouth despite promise by Taylor to spare his life if he gives full details of his associates".

He endured the worst sort of torture but didn't reveal anything about his friends and comrades. The British officials couldn't get any information from him. In response to his offer of pardon, Peer Ali is reported to have said, "There are some occasions on which it is good to give up life and that if I sacrificed; thousands others, everyday, will fill their place". Later, Peer Ali Khan was charged with killing of Dr. Lloyel and waging war against the Crown. He was hanged in full public view in Patna on 7<sup>th</sup> July, 1857 by the order of W. Taylor. The latter also ordered for the execution of all those who were connected or associated with Peer Ali and confiscation of their properties.

## Saifuddin Kitchlew

Saifuddin Kitchlew was not just a freedom fighter, he was much more and will always remain part of the history that will be told and retold whenever the Jalianwala Bagh massacre is mentioned. It was following his arrest and the arrest of one of his close friends, Satya Pal, a homeopathic doctor, that actually prompted massive outpouring of public sentiment that brought tens of thousands of people on roads, in protest against the power hungry British Raj.

What followed this massive and rather unprecedented act of defiance by common Indians against the occupation forces is something that will be among the blackest days of history.

A report in The Hindu, while describing the sequence of events leading to Jallianwala Bagh says, "In March 1919, things came to a head with the Rowlatt Act, which allowed the government to imprison any person suspected of terrorism for up to two years without trial, being passed...In Punjab, two Congress leaders Dr. Satya Pal and Saifuddin Kitchlew were arrested and taken to a secret location. On April 10, soldiers fired upon demonstrators demanding their release. As violent outbreaks increased, railway lines, telegraph posts and government buildings were destroyed and Europeans and Indians killed. By April 13, most of Punjab

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was under martial law and civil liberties, including freedom of assembly, were curtailed. On April 13, the festive day of Baisakhi, a crowd had gathered at Jallianwala Bagh near the Harmandir Sahib, Amritsar...That evening, Brigadier-General Dyer, the local commander, arrived with Gurkha and Balochi soldiers armed with rifles...With the entrance blocked by his soldiers, Dyer gave the command to fire. For 10 minutes, the firing continued as people tried to escape by jumping into a well or stampeding through the entrances. Once the ammunition ran out, the soldiers left. But curfew was declared and the injured could not be moved”.

Born on 15 January 1888, Saifuddin Kitchlew was the president of Indian National Congress' Punjab chapter. He was later elevated to the general secretary of the Indian National Congress in the year 1924. He was totally against the division of the nation and had deep hatred for the British Raj. Saifuddin had no fear of anyone and had a carefree attitude towards everything including life.

His father Azizuddin Kitchlew, was a Kashmiri Muslim, whose forefathers had converted to Islam. His mother's name was Dan Bibi. His father was a renowned trader and owned a pashmina and saffron trading business. It is said that Saifuddin's grandfather, Ahmed Kitchlew, migrated from Kashmir to Amritsar in the last quarter of the 19<sup>th</sup> century following the great Kashmir famine of 1871. Hundreds of thousands of people lost their lives in the famine that reportedly lasted for several years.

Kitchlew, who was very good in studies from the very beginning, studied at Islamia High School in Amritsar. He



was sent to England where he got admission in Cambridge University from where he did his BA and went to a German university from where he completed his law and PhD.

When he returned to India, the freedom movement was still in its infancy. He started his legal practice in Amritsar where it soon flourished. It was not long after his setting his foot on the Indian soil when he met Mahatma Gandhi. He entered public life very early and in the year 1919 he was elected the Municipal Commissioner of the city of Amritsar. He took part in the Satyagraha (Non-cooperation) movement and soon left his practice, to become part of the freedom movement, as well as the All India Khilafat Committee.

His involvement with the Khilafat movement was also due to his proximity to Mahatma Gandhi who stood firmly behind the Khilafat Movement due to the fact that it was essentially an anti-Raj movement. Due to their opposition to Rowlatt Act, Indian nationalist leaders were put in different jails and Saifuddin Kichlew was arrested with Mahatma Gandhi and Dr. Satyapal for leading protests in Punjab against the legislation. The Anarchical and Revolutionary Crimes Act, 1919, generally known as the Rowlatt Act, was a legislative act passed by the British Raj in Delhi on March 18, 1919, indefinitely extending the emergency measures of preventive indefinite detention, incarceration without trial and judicial review enacted in the Defence of India Act 1915 during the First World War. This act effectively authorized the government to imprison any person suspected of terrorism living in the Raj for up to two years without a trial, and gave

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the imperial authorities power to deal with all revolutionary activities.

Saifuddin Kitchlew's graph rose in the Congress party and he was given the post of Indian National Congress' General Secretary in 1924. He was also appointed the chairman of the reception committee of the Congress session in Lahore in 1929-30, where on 26 January 1930, the Indian National Congress declared Indian independence and inaugurated an era of civil disobedience. Kitchlew was a founding leader of the Naujawan Bharat Sabha that later became known as Indian Youth Congress. Besides, he was also the member of the Foundation Committee of Jamia Millia Islamia, which met on 29 October 1920 and led to the foundation of Jamia Millia Islamia University.

For some time, he also dabbled in journalism and launched an Urdu daily "*Tanzim*" to create awareness about freedom movement and literacy. Throughout the 1930-1934 struggles, Kitchlew was repeatedly arrested, and spent several years behind bars.

He was a stalwart who espoused nationalism without colouring it in religious shades. This is the reason that he always opposed Muslim League's demand for Pakistan. He never reconciled with the idea of division of the country and in 1947 he strongly opposed the acceptance of the Partition of India by the Congress Party. He spoke against it at public meetings all over the country, and at the All India Congress Committee session that ultimately voted for the resolution. He called it a blatant "surrender of nationalism for communalism". He was awarded the Stalin Peace Prize in

1952 and a Government Act made him along with Jawaharlal Nehru, and Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, the life trustees of the Jallianwala Bagh National Memorial Trust.

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## Mohammed Abdur Rahiman

The war of independence or the freedom movement brought many people into the limelight from North India. But there were very few people who hogged limelight from South India when it came to war of independence and in the case of Muslims, the number of such people is even smaller.

Mohammad Abdur Rahiman, popularly known in Kerala as Mohammad Abdur Rahman Sahib was a towering personality who rose in the ranks of freedom fighters from God's Own Country (Kerala) and remained steadfast for the cause till he breathed his last. His biggest wish throughout his life was to see his nation freed from the clutches of colonial occupation and the defeat and eviction of the British Raj from India.

Alas, he couldn't see the free India as he died at a young age of 47 years on 23 April 1945 around two years before the independence of the country.

Mohammed Abdur Rahiman was always in favor of a secular democratic nation where both, Muslims and Hindus, lived in peace and harmony. Born in Azhikode in Thrissur District in the Kingdom of Cochin, present day Kerala on 13 May 1897, he completed his schooling at Veniyambadi and Calicut.

The original name of Muhammed Abdur Rahiman was Kunhu Muhammed. Later on, the first name Kunhu was given up and the name of his father, Abdurahiman was added with his second name and he came to be known as Mohammed Abdurahiman. On completion of primary education, Abdurahiman left the school and joined Government High School Kodungallu. Being a member of an orthodox religious family, his parents were very particular to give him religious education along with modern education. For higher studies he was sent to Madras and then to Aligarh Muslim University, the foremost center of education for Indian Muslims of the time. Nevertheless, he couldn't complete his studies in Aligarh and jumped into Khilafat Movement and in Non-Cooperation movement along with other top leaders of Indian freedom movement.

His tryst with the independence movement began in Madras (Chennai) as here he got the opportunity to listen to the great nationalist leaders including Justice Tyabji and Yakub Hasan besides many others. Under their influence he became a regular reader of the *Muslim Herald* and the *Muhammadian*. It was at this time that he happened to read the *Mas'-ala-e-Khilafat-wa-Jazirah- e-'Arab*, 'a scholarly and illuminating discourse on the concept and history of Khilafat' written by Maulana Abul Kalam Azad. The very words of Azad that 'English education given in the colleges are cups filled with poison' stirred the sentiments of Abdurahiman.

As his mind swung between continuing education or leaving it midway, he had the good fortune of listening to great freedom fighter, Maulana Shaukath Ali, who happened to

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visit Madras at that time. While addressing the students, the renowned freedom fighter who was the main force behind Khilafat Movement said, "If the end and aim of your education is to seek government service, death is preferable to such an education."

When Gandhiji asked the freedom loving people to withdraw from government run educational institutions, he was one of the very few students who answered the call and left Presidency College in November 1920 abruptly. Criminal Investigation Department (CID), in a report said "Two Mussalman students of Madras have withdrawn from the Government Colleges, one Abdurahiman from the Madras Presidency College and the other Mohiuddin from the Madrasa-e-Asam college...It is learnt that this contagion is not likely to spread and cause the ruin of the Musalman youths."

When Jamia Millia Islamia was launched by nationalist leaders like Abul Kalam, Azad, Maulana Mahmud al-Hasan, Maulana Muhammad Ali Jauhar and Dr Mukhtar Ansari, besides many others, he joined the institution as he was enthused by the prospects of being taught by scholars like Abul Kalam Azad and Ali Brothers who were among the teachers of the newly launched institution.

Reports suggest that besides being a student of Maulana Azad and Ali Brothers, Abdurahiman was fortunate to have close contacts with other nationalist leaders like Dr. M.A. Ansari, Hakim Ajmal Khan, Khwaja Abdul Hameed etc.

He came into the limelight during the Nagpur session of the Indian National Congress as a student delegate in December

1920. Congress leaders contemplated with the idea of having a separate Congress set-up in Kerala, encompassing all the Malyalam speaking areas. While there were arguments against this proposal, the counter arguments of Abdurahiman were so convincing that Gandhiji and Rajagopalachari supported the motion and Kerala Chapter of the Congress was launched.

Abdurrahiman Sahib was non-partisan and never believed in communalism. He wanted the Muslims, Hindus and Christians to progress together and thus was never against one community or the other. He was becoming a major threat in the eyes of British Raj and they got an opportunity to punish him following the Moplah Riots of 1921. Historic accounts suggest that Sahib worked towards establishing peace in riot affected areas but was arrested and sentenced to two years imprisonment in October 1921 by the British authorities. For his participation in the Salt Satyagraha of 1930 where he participated in the breaking of the salt law on the Calicut beach, he was canned and sentenced to nine months rigorous imprisonment and lodged at the Kannur Central Jail.

He realized the importance of media very early and launched Malayalam daily newspaper, *Al-Ameen*, which was published from Calicut during 1929–1939. The most important objective of this newspaper was to prepare a dedicated group of people to support the freedom struggle and convince others to accept its necessity and futility of supporting the Raj. It is needless to say that the *Al-Ameen* (trustworthy) was

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an eyesore in the eyes of the British Raj and they finally closed it down in 1939.

He was elected a member of Calicut Municipal Council from 1931 to 1934 and the Malabar District Board of Madras Presidency from 1932. Later, in the year 1937, he was elected to Madras Presidency. He became President of Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) and a member of All India Congress Committee (AICC) in 1939.

The most important feature of his political journey is his opposition to the concept of the two-nation theory of the Muslim League. He always opposed Muslim League and other divisive forces. He was also a great admirer of Subhash Chandra Bose and this may be the reason that he was arrested and put behind bars from 1940 to 1945 by the British Raj. After the release from jail, he returned to Calicut and started active participation in Congress activities. He died on 23 November 1945 aged 47 at Pottashery village near Chennamangallur.



## Captain Abbas Ali

Captain Abbas Ali was a freedom fighter who went on to fight as part of the Indian National Army of Subhash Chandra Bose. He is one of the very few people who are said to have met and interacted closely with Subhash Chandra Bose till he mysteriously disappeared.

There were many reports indicating that Captain Abbas Ali may be privy to the disappearance of Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose. Netaji, who had spent decades with the Congress, was an Indian nationalist whose defiant patriotism made him a hero in India. He attempted to forge an alliance with Nazi Germany and Imperial Japan to drive the British Raj out of India. Thousands and thousands of people from across the country joined hands with him and fought on behalf of the Indian National Army. Captain Abbas Ali, who survived the war, came back to India and joined the mainstream politics.

Born on 3 January 1920, in Khurja, United Province, Captain Abbas Ali had a very long and healthy life. He belonged to a Muslim Rajput family and seems to have been infatuated by the legendary stories of Bhagat Singh from a very early age. His biographers claim that Captain Abbas Ali became a member of Naujawan Bharat Sabha, an organization founded

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by Singh and his colleagues while he was a high school student at Khurja.

Later, like many well-off Muslims from North India, he went to Aligarh Muslim University for higher studies where he befriended Kunwar Muhammed Ashraf and became a member of the All India Students Federation. He was a revolutionary from a very early age and somehow got inspired to revolt against the British Raj from within. This led him to join the British Indian Army in 1939. His biographers claim that Captain Abbas Ali, during the Second World War, was posted at various officers training schools of India such as Bangalore, RIASC Depot Ferozpur (Punjab), Waziristan (N.W.F.P), Naushera (N.W.F.P) Khanpur Camp (Delhi), Bareilly Cantt (United Province), Bhiwandi Army Training Camp (Maharashtra), Singapore, Ipoh, Penang, Kualalampur (Malaya), and Rangoon (now Yangon).

He seemed to be waiting for an opportune time to revolt against the British colonial rulers. When in the year 1945 Subhash Chandra Bose called for revolt, he deserted the British Army and joined the Indian National Army (INA) or 'Azad Hind Fauj' but later he was arrested, court-martialed and sentenced to death.

He was inspired by Lohia from very early age and was a socialist in his thinking. In 1948, Abbas Ali joined the Socialist Party led by Narendra Deva, Jayaprakash Narayan and Ram Manohar Lohia and remained associated with all the Socialist organizations namely the Socialist Party, Praja Socialist Party, Samyukta Socialist Party and Socialist Party until its merger with the Janata Party in 1977.

Captain Abbas Ali remained relevant in socialist camp for a long time and in 1966, he was appointed State General Secretary of Sanyukt Socialist Party. He was appointed a member of the national executive of the Socialist Party. He was arrested again during the Emergency under the Defence of India Rule (DIR) and remained behind bars during the entire period of emergency. It seems like the British occupation forces, the oppressive regime during emergency was also fearful of the Captain. In 1977, when emergency was lifted and his party merged with the Janata Party, he was elected to Uttar Pradesh Legislative Council and was appointed as the first President of Uttar Pradesh Unit of the Janata Party.

There is no denying that his infatuation with Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose was life-long. Shortly before his death, while attending a public function in Aligarh on the eve of 15th August, Captain Ali had said, "There is only one unfulfilled wish of my life and that is that the true story behind the last few days of my leader Subhash Chandra Bose should see the light of the day.

He compiled his autobiography *Na Rahoon Kisi ka Daste Nagar-Mera Safarnama* in 2008, which was released on 3 January 2009, on his ninetieth birthday in New Delhi. Ali died on 11 October 2014 at Jawaharlal Nehru Medical College, Aligarh due to heart failure.

Dr. G.G.Parikh while paying homage to Captain says, "He was as much committed to equality as to communal harmony and he felt very strongly that the socialists, and also perhaps communists, could ensure peace and harmony between the

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two communities. He believed that the fight against oppression, against injustice, against inequality would be better waged by socialists than other forces. Ageing and with a frail body, he ruminated in the evening of his life over his own past, the problems of the socialist movement, and felt helpless, in fact, frustrated. Frustrated because he could not do much to pursue what he believed to be the need of the hour. Anyone who met him would get a feel of his passion and the desire to see that socialists were restored to their past glory and also get singing for their inaction”.

## Abdul Qaiyum Ansari

**A**bdul Qaiyum Ansari's contribution in India's freedom struggle is enormous. He was a leader who always led from the front and established a precedent for his followers to follow in his footsteps. He was a reformer who fought for the deprived sections of the population and put his life in the line on fire on multiple occasions for the benefit of his people.

If there were people who were above communal differences and divisive policies, he should be among the top of any such list. He always advocated Hindu Muslim unity and treaded a path less travelled even when the communal frenzy was on its highest.

Abdul Qaiyum Ansari opposed the division of India on communal grounds and attacked Indian National Congress leadership for agreeing to the division of the nation. It is needless to say that the Muslim League saw in him, one of their fiercest opponents and they attacked him viciously trying to destroy him in every manner possible.

He was vehemently opposed to the very idea of Pakistan and spoke out openly to the extent of inviting attack by Muslim League supporters. While speaking in Patna during the Bihar Provincial Momin Conference on 21 April 1940, Abdul Qaiyum Ansari said:

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"It is blasphemy to say that Islam is in danger here. It is tragedy to place orders for a Pakistan for the segregation of Islam. It is a defeat of Islam to run away from the battle of life in search of a privilege. It is a fantastic wavering of a fevered mind. .

He went on to add:

"The scheme would not be able to protect the Muslims of the minority provinces as they would remain in the hands of the majority community with the difference that Muslims would have no control over the administration of the province which they have got in the present state of the affairs. The plea that Muslim states in India would protect the Muslim Minority province was utterly useless. Even today there were Muslim states of Afghanistan, Turkey Persia and many others, but they could not interfere in the matters of India even on the complaints made by the League that Muslims were being crushed by the Hindus. In the same way, the Pakistan states would also be unable to do anything. And the plea was simply meant to hide the reality and hoodwink the Muslims of the minority provinces."

Born on 1 July 1905 at Dehri-on-Sone, Rohtas District of Bihar, in a wealthy Ansari family, Abdul Qaiyum Ansari studied at Sasaram and Dehri-on-Sone High Schools. For his higher studies he was sent to Aligarh Muslim University, Calcutta University, and Allahabad University. He had to discontinue education due to his intense involvement in freedom moment.

He was impressed by Mahatma Gandhi, Maulana Abul Kalam Azad and Ali Borthers who were the leading lights of the freedom movement. His activism in freedom movement and social causes can be gauged by the fact that he established a national school for the students who had boycotted government schools in response to the call of the Indian National Congress. For this he was arrested and imprisoned at the young age of 16 since it amounted to participation in Non-Cooperation and Khilafat Movements.

Abdul Qaiyum Ansari was also a champion of weaker sections of the society. He was among the top leaders of the Momin Conference and used the forum to make every effort to beat Muslim League and its divisive agenda. Besides, he also stood firmly against divisive politics of other organization. He worked closely with the Indian National Congress throughout as a youth leader and even took part in the students' agitation against the Simon Commission during its visit to Calcutta in 1928. He was also an accomplished journalist, writer and a poet.

Prof. Mohammad Sajjad in his book *Muslim Politics in Bihar: Changing Contours* says:

"The Momin Conference attempted to use those very weapons against the League which it had employed against the Congress. To oppose the League's separatist resolution of Lahore, a 'Nationalist Muslims Conference' was held at Delhi from 27 to 29 April 1940. This is also known as Azad Muslim Conference...Due to the considerable influence of the Deoband educated ulama in several districts of Bihar, and the particularly great influence of Imarat-e-Shariah, the

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participation of the Muslims from Bihar was spectacularly high. Besides the ulema, Abdul Qaiyum Ansari, the leader of the All India Momin Conference, played a remarkable role in mobilizing the Muslims, particularly the Momins of Bihar."

The launch of the Momin Movement was a step not just to uplift the Ansari Momin community from the depth of deprivation and backwardness, but also to spearhead the opposition against Muslim League's divisive agenda. He launched the Momin Movement in 1937. Jawaharlal Nehru was so much impressed by the increasing popularity of a young Qaiyum Ansari that when in 1940, Sir Stafford Cripps came to India and asked Jawaharlal Nehru as to who were the Muslim leaders in the Congress with a formidable mass base in opposition to Jinnah of the All India Muslim League, Nehru responded without hesitation and named Abdul Qaiyum Ansari. He implied that Ansari wielded as much influence among Muslims as Jinnah.

In 1947, during the Pakistani aggression in Kashmir, he condemned the brazen attack, becoming the first Indian Muslim leader to do so. He strenuously worked to rouse the Muslim masses to counter such aggressions as true citizens of India. He also founded the Indian Muslim Youth Kashmir Front in 1957 to 'liberate' Azad Kashmir. The champion of freedom and equality and a true mass leader, he breathed his last on 18 January 1973, at village Amiawar of Bihar. When the call came he was still serving his people and was inspecting damages caused to the village by the collapse of the Dehri-Arrah canal and organizing relief to its homeless people.



## Prof. Abdul Bari

Prof. Abdul Bari was among the top freedom fighters from Bihar who not just fought for the freedom of the nation, but also against the divisive agenda of everyone from Hindu Mahasabha to the Muslim League. He paid the price of opposition to those forces with his life and became a martyr merely months before the independence of the nation.

Born in the year 1892 in Sahabad, Village Kansua of Jahanabad district in Bihar he studied in Patna. Prof. Abdul Bari completed his post graduation from Patna University in the year 1920. Later he joined the newly opened Bihar National College as Professor in the year 1921. The college is said to have been launched under the guidance of Mahatma Gandhi who had asked people to boycott government educational institutions and establish private schools and colleges instead.

He was a true Gandhian and lived so simple life that when Gandhiji came to visit his house in the aftermath of his assassination, he was shocked by seeing the poverty in the house of one of the top leaders of the independent movement in Bihar.

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D G Tendulkar's book *Mahatma Volume 7: Life of Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi*, while quoting the father of the nation says "as he entered the house he was struck with its simplicity and the simple life Prof. Bari had led. The house was located in an ordinary narrow lane and what he saw inside the house fully bore out what everyone had said about Prof. Bari, that he was a poor man and that though he had opportunities he scrupulously maintained his integrity as far as public finances were concerned. At a time when the administration of the country was in the Congress hands and crores of rupees had to be administered, men of Prof. Bari's honesty would have been of invaluable help. He had hoped on his return from the third tour just finished, to be more closely associated with him and to make an effective appeal to him to modify, if not altogether get rid of, his short temper which went ill with the very high office, in fact the highest in the province of Bihar, especially when there was a nationalist ministry at the head of affairs which naturally had to be influenced by the premier provincial Congress organization".

*Mahatma Volume 7: Life of Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi*, while quoting him goes on to add, "he had had full faith in Prof. Bari and knew very well that his word carried great weight among the common people. But God had willed otherwise and He had deprived Bihar of the great service of a very brave man with the heart of a fakir. But men like Bari never died, and it was for those who remained to carry on the noble work he had left behind".

Education was very close to his heart and he wanted to bring the people out of poverty and deprivation through education.

Prof. Abdul Bari met Mahatma Gandhi in the year 1917 during Gandhi's visit to Bihar. He played an active role in bringing together worker section of Bihar, Bengal and Orissa for freedom struggle movement in 1921, 1922 and 1942. He also played active role in Non-Cooperation Movement in 1922 with Dr. Rajendra Prasad, Dr Anugrah Narayan Sinha and Dr Sri Krishna Singh. He was a top workers' union leader and worked for their better working condition and higher payment.

Due to his enormous contributions, 'Tata workers' union while paying homage to Prof. Abdul Bari on its website says, "With the appearance of Prof. Abdul Bari on the scene in 1936, the movement took deep roots. A psychological thrust was given to the movement when he changed the name of the Labour Association to "Tata Workers' Union". The unity and maturity that he brought about among the TISCO workers were so strong that they survived all political onslaughts with perfect confidence. Under his dynamic leadership the Union launched its struggle for a thorough revision of the wage structure, introduction of the incentive bonus scheme, etc. through the efforts of Prof. Bari, the Bihar Labour Enquiry Committee was constituted with Dr. Rajendra Prasad as Chairman, and Prof. Bari as one of the members. The Report submitted by this august body in 1940 constituted the first authentic document on labour situation in Bihar in general and at Jamshedpur in particular".

The Tata workers' union goes on to add,

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“After a prolonged struggle for a decade and repeated strike threats in 1945 and 1946, an Agreement was signed in February 1948 by the Union and the Management which not only secured higher wages and better working conditions but also, what is more significant, stipulated the formation of joint committees with equal representation to ensure better understanding and settlement of disputes by negotiations. But, before the advent of this new era of conciliation in place of conflict, our beloved leader and great patriot, Prof. Bari, died under tragic circumstances on 28th March 1947”.

He was among the top Congress leaders in the state and in the provincial election in 1937, he was elected as an MLA from Champaran area on Congress ticket. It was the same election when his relative Barrister Mohammad Yunus was leading second largest party of Bihar- Muslim Independent Party. He became Dy. Speaker of Bihar Assembly in July, 1937 of first Congress Government which was formed on 19 July 1937 after the fall of 4 months long first democratic government of Bihar headed by First Prime Minister of Bihar province Barrister Mohammad Yunus. He became Vice Chairman of Bihar Labour Enquiry Committee under Chairmanship of Dr. Rajendra Prasad. Prof. Abdul Bari was elected the Congress party president of Bihar in the year 1946. He was shot dead close to Patna while coming back from Ranchi on 28 March 1947. His sudden death shocked the entire nation, causing grief across the political spectrum.

## Moulvi Abdul Rasul

**M**oulvi Abdul Rasul was a freedom fighter of the highest caliber. Nonetheless, despite his enormous contributions, he remains rather an unfamiliar name for people across the country. History books haven't documented his contribution, nor have Muslims tried to preserve his dedication and hard work for independence and maintenance of communal harmony. Even in the state from where he belonged, people seem to have lost track of how great a person he was and what were his contributions in freedom struggle in twenties and thirties of the last century.

He came into the limelight and won respect of both the Hindu and Muslim communities even when Bengal was dominated by towering personalities of all hues from Muslim community and caste Hindus.

His name Moulvi Abdul Rasul makes him sound like a Deobandi alim (scholar). There is no denying that Ulama-e-Deoband were leading the war of independence in the country in the first quarter of the twentieth century against the British Raj. But neither he studied in a madrasa nor was he a scholar of Islamic sciences.

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On the contrary, he was the first Bengali from both the Hindu and Muslim communities to acquire law degree from England. It is surprising as to how a child who lost his father at a tender age of just two, went on to win scholarship and study in England doing his matriculation, BA, MA and then law from the best of institutions there.

While most Indians seem to have forgotten him, a book, '*The Indian Builders*' Volume-1' has a short bio on him.

Moulvi Abdul Rasul was born when the Mutiny of 1857 had become a distant dream and the consequent oppression by the British Raj had been replaced by a quest by the oppressive occupation regime to co-opt the Indians. Abdul Rasul was born in April 1872. His father, Moulvi Golam Rasul was a well-known landlord (zamindar) of Guniank in the Tipperah district of Bengal and had been known for his social and charitable work across the region. Nevertheless, the poor Abdul Rasul couldn't see his father and didn't have any memories of him as Gulam Rasul passed away when he was just two years old.

Following the death of the father, his mother along with the family, shifted to Kishoregunge and he was schooled in a dilapidated government run school. But soon, a bright student as Abdul Rasul was, he went to the Government School at Dacca and from there passed his entrance examination in 1888. While he was in the Dacca school, his mother was advised to send him to England for education. Soon 17-year old Abdul Rasul, who had never set foot out of Bengal left for Liverpool, England in 1889. After spending a few years at Liverpool, he went to King's College London

and then to Oxford and matriculated in 1892. He took his BA degree in the year 1896 from St. John's College and took the MA degree in 1898. The same year, he was called to the Bar from Middle Temple and took the BCL degree.

Moulvi Abdul Rasul was the first Bengali to be awarded BCL degree. In London, he became close to Aurobindo Ghose, the renowned philosopher and nationalist leader from Bengal. Aurobindo studied for the Indian Civil Service at King's College, Cambridge, England. After returning to India he took up various civil service jobs under the maharaja of the princely state of Baroda and increasingly got involved in nationalist politics and the nascent revolutionary movement in Bengal. He was arrested in the aftermath of a number of bomb outrages linked to his organisation, but in a highly public trial where he faced charges of treason, Aurobindo could only be convicted and imprisoned for writing articles against British rule in India. Abdul Rasul was influenced by the revolutionary ideas of Ghose, but he came on his own soon after coming back to India. He started practicing in Calcutta and soon had a very impressive legal practice.

*The Indian Builders' Volume-I* while talking about Abdul Rasul's interest in the freedom movement says, "The country's interests occupy his time, quite as much as his profession. He has been actively trying to check polygamy among his co-religionists and is also an ardent friend of the Hindu Social Reform Movement. He has been endeavoring to bring Mussalmans into line with Hindus, in matters political and to undermine everything that stands in the way of the two communities standing shoulder to shoulder in the

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country's cause. When the partition of Bengal was proclaimed, he resolutely opposed it as being detrimental to the interests of Hindus and Muhammadan alike. Of the Swadeshi movement, he has been a whole hearted supporter and has done much to popularize it among his co-religionists. Not a single public meeting has in recent times, been held in Bengal in which he has not taken a prominent part."

"His ability and patriotism were recognized when he was invited to preside over the New Historic Bengal Provincial Conference held at Barisal. His address on the occasion was a masterly one and elicited much public admiration. In private life he is a perfect gentleman, in the fullest sense of the term and is characterized by a rare amiability. His wife is devoted to him with a passionate devotion and also loves the land which her husband loves so well...Mr Abdul Rasul is young and in the full vigour of his powers. He will be an invaluable asset in the future public life of the country. May he live long and may Muhammadans of his type endlessly multiply", the book goes on to add.

He presided over the Bengal Congress Session held at Barisal in 1906, the first Muslim leader to do it. While speaking on the occasion, he openly criticized the British Raj and its divide and rule policy in the state. While addressing the delegates, he said, "It has been a year in which we have seen how an alien bureaucracy has lorded it over patriotism, how it has trampled upon the cherished rights and privileges of the people. It has been a year in which we have seen how deeply sensible a nation may become of the calamities that may be brought upon it by foreign domination and also what a



nation can do when it is united...How some Englishmen in spite of their education, birth and position in life, after crossing the English Channel, lose their sense of justice and propriety and conscience in their dealings with other races whom they consider inferior to them”.

He asked Indians, both Muslims and Hindus to emulate what Japan did to remain competitive and said, “We must study self help, self sacrifice, self reliance and devotion to our motherland. When we have accomplished that we shall be in a position to do all. Remember the word 'Bushido' which has made Japan what it is now. Defeat of the Japanese at Kagasima, which was bombarded and destroyed by the English in 1863, was the cause of great naval victory which Admiral Togo won for Japan last year in the great battle of the Sea of Japan. The disaster at Kagasima was really a blessing in disguise for the Japanese. It opened their eyes to the fact that they, as a nation, had great responsibilities and that if they were to exist as a nation, they must give up their international quarrels, and sink all private differences and unite for the sole purpose of improving the condition of the country... Since 1863, they have turned their attention to the scientific and industrial progress of their country. They have sent their young men to Europe and America to learn what those countries could teach them in the branches of science and art”.

Moulvi Abdul Rasul was part of the group that drafted the Congress- Muslim League accord at Lucknow in 1916 in which the Congress accepted the Muslim League demand for separate electorates. He presided over the annual session of

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the Bengal Presidency Muslim League at Burdwan and was elected to the Bengal Legislative Council from Chittagong division. Abdur Rasul breathed his last in the year 1917 at a young age of 45.

## Nawab Syed Mohammed Bahadur

Not many people have heard that descendants of Tipu Sultan, the valiant ruler of Mysore, played any role in the freedom struggle. But not just his descendants, like their illustrious forefather, worked for the independence of the nation, one of his descendants, Nawab Syed Mohammed Bahadur, went on to become the President of the Indian National Congress.

Not many people are aware about the contribution of Nawab Syed Mohammed Bahadur. He started funding the Indian National Congress even before he joined the Congress. He assumed leadership role pretty soon. The support for the Congress from his family started much before Nawab Syed Mohammed Bahadur had come of age. His father, Mir Humayun Jah Bahadur, had supported the Congress since its very inception, extending financial support to a fledgling party that had yet to find its feet on the ground.

114 years after the martyrdom of Tipu Sultan, Nawab Syed Mohammed Bahadur became the President of the Indian National Congress in the year 1913 during its session in Karachi. Tipu Sultan attained martyrdom on 4 May 1799 while fighting the Colonial rulers of India who were trying to annex Mysore state into ever expanding British empire. In

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South India, he was the only ruler, apart from his father Hyder Ali who fought tooth and nail against British occupation of India, defeating them in one war after the other, seeking alliance with French and German, Ottoman Turks and even Afghanistan. He would have remained undefeated had he faced the British forces alone. But Nizam of Hyderabad and Maratha Confederates fought in alliance with the East India Company forces and he attained martyrdom fighting the enemies of a free and independent India.

While a lot has been written about Tipu Sultan and his legendary father Hyder Ali, not much is known about their descendants. Nawab Syed Mohammed Bahadur's father Mir Humayun Jah Bahadur was among the wealthiest people south of Vindhya. Mir Humayun Jah Bahadur was among the most prominent Muslim faces in South India in the late nineteenth century. He served as a non-official member of Madras Legislative Council from 1866 till 1892 and a non-official member of the Imperial Legislative Council from 1893. He was made a Companion of the Order of the Indian Empire on January 1, 1880, in the Queen's New Year Honours List.

Nawab Syed Muhammad Bahadur was the grandson of Shahzadi Shah Rukh Begum, daughter of Sultan Yasin, the fourth son of Tipu Sultan. Like his father, he started supporting the nationalist movement from an early age and joined the Indian National Congress in 1894 and became an active member of the party soon after.

He was a great orator and wielded influence not just among the Muslim community in the South, But upper caste Hindu communities too. Given his popularity, Syed Muhammad Bahadur was appointed the first Muslim Sheriff of Madras in 1896. He was reportedly awarded the title of Nawab in 1897 by the British Government when he went on the invitation of the Queen to attend the Diamond Jubilee Celebration of Queen Victoria. He was nominated to the Madras Legislative Council in 1900 and to the Imperial Legislative Council in 1905. Like Tipu Sultan, he never considered religion to be a divider, and believed in social uplift of the masses. His popularity among the non-Muslims in South India was so high that he was the President of the Madras Mahajana Sabha from 1903, and his nationalist views were rewarded by election to the Presidency of the Indian National Congress in 1913.

He was well-known to the leading Muslim figures of North India and had good relations with the likes of Ali Brothers, Maulana Abul Kalam Azad and Mahatma Gandhi. He was a severe critic of the British Government for the dismemberment of the Turkish Empire after the First World War. He maintained that all the Indian Muslims must come together and save the Turkish Empire and the Khilafat from disintegration.

In his book, *How Best Do We Survive? A Modern Political History of the Tamil Muslims*, Kenneth McPherson while talking about Nawab Syed Muhammad Bahadur, says:

“Among the descendants of Tipu Sultan, Nawab Syed Muhammad Bahadur was pre-eminent. The Nawab's

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leadership role was, however, qualified by his great interest in the nationalist movement which he actively supported as a member of the Congress from 1894 until his death in 1919. His participation in organization and activities of the Muslim community - he was the nominated Muslim representative on the Legislative Council between 1900 and 1904 - was rarely more than nominal, to the chagrin of some Urdu Muslims who came to regard him as a Hindu lackey, especially when he was elected repeatedly to the Presidentship of the Mahajana Sabha, the pre-eminent Presidency nationalist organization, between 1907 and 1917. Nevertheless, the Nawab could not be discounted."

Kenneth McPherson goes on to add, "His activities in Congress stood him in good stead with the pro-Congress members of the 'Mylapore' Clique, one of whose members, C.P. Ramaswamy Iyer, was voluntary legal adviser to the Education Association. Attacks on the Nawab tended, however, to increase after the establishment of the Muslim League in 1908. To be fair, he was not the only Madras Muslim to be involved with the Congress, although he was the most prominent. In 1902, for example, the Mahajana Sabha elected - in addition to the Nawab - three prominent Chennai Muslim merchants as delegates to the Ahmedabad session of the Congress: Abdul Hadi Badsha, Mirza Hashim Isphahani and Hyder Sheriff. In comparison with the Arcot family, however, the descendants of Tipu sultan were far less numerous. After the death of the Nawab in 1919 the family sank into political obscurity and no longer played a prominent role in the community life".

He was a born secular like Tipu Sultan and his father Hyder Ali. They never differentiated between Hindus and Muslims and gave generous donations to temples that were destroyed by vanquished Maratha Armies while going back. He was opposed to the Muslim League and its ideology since its inception. Nawab Syed Muhammad Bahadur, in all his speeches and addresses, convincingly maintained that the Muslims and the Hindus must live like brothers and their different religions must not separate them but bind them together.

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## Rahimtulla Mahomed Sayani

**R**ahimtulla M. Sayani's name doesn't seem familiar to young generation like many of the people who worked tirelessly for the development and above all for the freedom of the nation. There are not many people around, even older ones, not to talk of youngsters, who seem to have heard the name of Rahimtulla M. Sayani and other freedom fighters.

Rahimtulla Mahomed Sayani was born on 5 April 1847 in a respected Ismaili Khoja family. Khoja community that follows Aga Khan, is among the most prosperous communities for a long time and even in late nineteenth century, it was the same. One of India's leading businessmen, Azim Hashim Premji of Wipro also belongs to the same Khoja community.

Rahimtulla Mahomed Sayani, born in Kutch on April 5, 1847 had a very humble beginning. He was born in an ordinary family that was not very wealthy or very well-connected. Nevertheless, this didn't stop him from public eminence and professional excellence in the field of law by hard work and perseverance.

He plunged into public life at an early age and went on to be elected as a member of the Bombay Municipal Corporation



when he was all of 29-years of age. It was not long when he was elected the President of the Bombay Municipal Corporation in 1888. He was also elected as the Sheriff of Bombay in 1885, apparently the first Muslim sheriff of the town.

He became one of the most prominent politicians in Mumbai, then Bombay and was elected to the Bombay Legislative Council (1880 - 90 and 1894 - 96) and the Imperial Legislative Council (1896 - 98).

Being a renowned lawyer and a leader who was admired and supported by his Ismaili Khoja community, Rahimtulla Mahomed Sayani was appointed by the Government in 1874 as a member of the Commission to consider the laws of interstate and testamentary succession in the Khoja community.

He became associated with the nationalist Indian National Congress from the very beginning. To be true, he was the part of the Indian National Congress from its very inception. He was one of the two Indian Muslims who attended its first session in 1885. Sayani was a member of the committee formed by the Congress in 1886 to consider the question of Public Services.

Rahimtulla Mahomed Sayani was one of the representatives from Bombay on the Congress Executive Committee (Indian Congress Committee) formed in 1899. He presided over the 12th annual session of the Congress held at Calcutta in 1896. His presidential address hailed by a contemporary journal as the "best delivered so far" was notable for the close attention

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it paid to the economic and financial aspects of the British rule in India.

Rahimtulla Mahomed Sayani was above communal and sectarian feelings. His doors, as sheriff of Mumbai, and then as the President of Bombay Municipal Corporation, were always open to people of all communities. He urged the Muslims to join the Congress which he regarded as representing "all that is loyal and patriotic, enlightened and influential, progressive and disinterested." Enumerating Muslims' objections to joining the Congress, he refuted them point by point. An advocate of Western education, Sayani considered it particularly essential for the Muslim.

While speaking on the occasion of his presidential address at Indian National Congress session in Calcutta, in the year 1896, Rahimtulla Mahomed Sayani said, "That we should endeavour to promote personal intimacy and friendship amongst all the great communities of India, to develop and consolidate sentiments of national growth and unity, to weld them together into one nationality, to effect a moral union amongst them, to remove the taunt that we are not a nation, but only a congeries of races and creeds which have no cohesion in them and to bring about stronger and stronger friendly ties of common nationality."

Rahimtulla Mahomed Sayani presided over the 12th Annual Session of the Congress held at Calcutta in 1896 where he was elected the President of the Indian National Congress and became the Second Muslim to be elected to the post. He passed away in the year 1902 in Mumbai.

## Syed Hasan Imam

Syed Hasan Imam was a great freedom fighter and one of the foremost lawyers and jurists of his time. He served in Kolkata High Court as a judge when there were not many Indian judges in local courts let alone in a high court. But Syed Hasan Imam was not an ordinary man, nor an ordinary lawyer. He was the best of the best, who left his lucrative job as a judge in the Kolkata High Court to serve his nation, unite them against the British Raj's tyrannical rule and work for the progress and development of Indians.

Syed Hasan Imam and his elder brother, Sir Ali Imam, made the most lethal legal team the country witnessed in the late nineteenth and early twentieth century. They were the top legal minds of the nation and even the best of the best judges feared to face the intellectual minds of the two legal eagles.

Born on 31 August 1871, Syed Hasan Imam not just hogged limelight as the top jurist in the country, but also a unifying force of different sections of the society vying for the freedom of the nation from British Raj. It is said that one of his ancestors was the private tutor to Mughal emperor Aurangzeb. Born in a highly educated family of Patna, Hasan Imam's father was a professor of history at Patna College. Many legal experts in India regard Syed Hasan Imam as one of India's finest barristers in British India. He is related to

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many other barristers besides those within his own immediate family including Sir Sultan Ahmed and Syed Abdal Aziz. Hasan Imam's Cambridge University educated nephew Syed Jafar Imam was also his son-in-law who later became a Supreme Court judge.

For many people it will be rather surprising information that Syed Hasan Imam had to leave his schooling on many occasions due to several bouts of illness. He had very poor health in his childhood and it is rather surprising as to how he was able to overcome such hiccups later and developed into a very handsome man.

At the age of 18, Syed Hasan Imam went to England and joined the Middle Temple in the year 1889. While there, he campaigned actively for Dadabhai Naoroji during the General Election of England in 1891. He was called to the Bar in 1892 and his biographers claim that he came back to India the same year and registered in Calcutta High Court where he started practice soon after.

Despite his exceptional legal practice, he started taking keen interest in the political field and soon got associated with people working to drive out the British Raj and attain freedom for the country. Within a few years in the field, his importance was felt by everyone due to the fact that he had the sharpest minds and had great oratorical skills. His sharp mind and oratorical skills, both are said to have helped him immensely in his legal practice as well. In October 1909, he was elected President of the Bihar Congress Committee and in the next month he presided over the fourth session of the Bihar Students' Conference.

His keen interest and participation in the freedom movement didn't adversely impact his legal practice. Syed Hasan Imam became a Judge of the Calcutta High Court soon, but he left the lucrative position and shifted to Patna, when the Patna High Court was inaugurated in the year 1916. He had to resign from his job as High Court judge to shift to Patna. Imam sacrificed this important post and started practicing law in Patna High Court. He resumed political activism on larger scale after resigning in 1916.

Edwin Montagu, the Secretary of State for India was so much impressed by Syed Hasan Imam, his political acumen and his acceptability among the top minds of the country that he listed him among "the real giants of the Indian Political World". He presided over the special session of the Indian National Congress held at Bombay, 1918 to consider the Montagu - Chelmsford Reforms Scheme. It was an important, but difficult session to handle because opinions were sharply divided on the merits of the scheme. Hasan Imam played a moderating role. He was elected the President of the Indian National Congress the same year.

In the early twentieth century when the British Raj was being criticized the world over for its brutal rule, the Montagu-Chelmsford Reforms were introduced in India to bring an iota of self-governing institutions gradually to India. The reforms were outlined in the Montagu-Chelmsford Report prepared in 1918 and formed the basis of the Government of India Act 1919. While many in Britain thought that the Secretary of State for India was being too lenient towards increasing assertive attitude of the Indian leaders, the

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nationalist voices in India thought them to be too little and too late. The Report went before Cabinet on 24 May and 7 June 1918 and was embodied in the Government of India Act of 1919. These reforms represented the maximum concessions the British were prepared to make at that time. Given the importance of the reforms and the uproar it created during the Congress session, its handling was thought to be an exceptionally difficult task.

With his brilliant performance, Imam was nominated a Member of the Bihar and Orissa Legislative Council in the year 1921.

With his vision and commitment to the nationalist cause, he took a leading part in the Khilafat Movement and the Civil Disobedience Movement in 1930. He was elected secretary of the Swadeshi League formed in Patna. Syed Hasan Imam actively campaigned for the boycott of foreign goods and use of *khaddar* (khadi). Earlier in 1927, he "materially conduced to the success" of the boycott of the Simon Commission in Bihar. Hasan Imam was a strong advocate of social reforms, particularly the amelioration of the position of women and the depressed classes. As a member of the Tikari Board of Trustees, he promoted schemes for girls' education. He exposed the economic exploitation of the country, both under the Company and the Imperial rule. He was President of the Board of Trustees of the *Biharee*, a leading English daily of Bihar of the time; he was also one of the founders of another media venture, Searchlight.

The eminent jurist of the first half of the nineteenth century, Syed Hasan Imam breathed his last on 19 April 1933.

## Sir Syed Ali Imam

Sir Syed Ali Imam was a freedom fighter of highest order and a legal luminary who can never be forgotten by history. His name will remain alive till Patna High Court lasts as it was he who fought for the formation of a high court in Patna when Bihar and Orissa were carved out of Bengal. He was also instrumental in formation of the state of Bihar.

He is the elder brother of Syed Hasan Imam, another renowned legal mind who was a judge at Calcutta High Court and went on to become the President of the Indian National Congress in the year 1918.

Despite being such a prominent legal personality, who finds mention in innumerable legal documents for his insight and acumen, it is amazing that there is not much available on his life.

Law ran deep into his veins. Many among his forefathers, including his grandfather were judges. His brother Hasan Imam was a judge of Calcutta High Court and Sir Ali Imam's own son, Jafar Imam, went on to become the Chief Justice of Patna High Court in fifties. His father Imdad Imam was a professor of history at Patna College. The great-grandfather of Sir Ali Imam, Khan Bahadur Syed Imdad Ali, retired as a

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subordinate Judge of Patna, while his son, Khan Bahadur Shams- ul-ulama Syed Wahiduddin was the first Indian to be made a District Magistrate and a District and Sessions Judge. One of the ancestors of Ali Imam was a private tutor to Mughal emperor Aurangzeb.

Initially he was associated with the Muslim League, when the League was a nationalist party of Muslims and hadn't shown any communal colors. In 1908 Sir Ali Imam was elected as the President of Muslim League at Amritsar Annual Session. But, when under Jinnah the League metamorphosed into a party seeking separate nation for Muslims, he left it and became involved with the Muslim Nationalist Party. He was elected its president at its conference in Lucknow.

Born at Neora, Patna in the year 1869, Syed Ali Imam returned to Patna in 1890 after getting his Bar-at-Law from England. He became one of the top rated lawyers and jurists in the country and was duly recognized by legal fraternity and even the British Raj. Historic records suggest as to how important role he played in the formation of the constitution of Bihar as a separate province and the establishment of Patna High Court.

*Indian Opinion's* 30-10-1909 edition, while talking about the association of Syed Ali Imam and Mahatma Gandhi, says that when Sir Imam visited South Africa, Mahatma Gandhi threw a lavish dinner in his honor. More than hundred renowned personalities from Hindu, Muslim communities besides many renowned English royals were invited. The report goes on to add:



"Mr. Ali Imam said in his speech that India could remain with England, not under it. Indians must have the same rights as the British. They must make a success of what Lord Morley had granted and then demand more. Hindus, Muslims and Parsis must learn to live as one nation. In Turkey, Muslims, Jews and Christians lived in amity, and that was why they commanded respect. In every part of India where Hindus were in a majority and the Muslims in a minority, the former should help the latter to gain special rights, and vice versa. If this were done, there would be no Hindu-Muslim problem. There were many reforms to be carried out in India. We must ensure the spread of education and respect for women's rights. We must not be backward where we have to act on our own".

Sir Ali Imam, while trying to convince the British Raj to set up a High Court in the newly carved out state of Bihar writes in an official letter:

"...there is one point to which I should like to draw attention. A reference to the letter received from that Court will show that the proposal to establish a High Court in the new province is not looked upon by their Lordships with enthusiasm. In fact reading between the lines of their letter it is evident that for all the prospective offer of loyal co-operation, their present attitude of mind towards the proposal is one of uneasiness as they apprehend it will divide their court and curtail its "jurisdiction and powers." For a High Court that is known to have political leanings and to which the Bengali press attributes marked statesmanship such a proposal cannot but be disconcerting. It is not therefore

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surprising that their Lordships in the fifth paragraph of their letter seek an opening to have their say on the policy apart from the technical details of the scheme. They invite us to take advantage of their peculiar "knowledge and experience" to "aid" and "influence" the decision of the Government of India on the question of the policy itself. This invitation is no more than an attempt at gaining a footing which constitutionally is denied to them. They have no *locus standi* in determining or taking part in a matter of policy".

Sir Ali Imam held many responsible positions besides those as judge and chief justice of Bihar High Court. He also served as Prime Minister of Hyderabad, Deccan (1919-1922), the largest princely state in British India and was a law member in the Imperial legislative Council. British India conferred him the title of Sir. He breathed his last in the year 1932.

## M. C. Chagla

**M**C Chagla or Mahommedali Currim Chagla was one of the foremost jurists in India who not just struggled for the freedom of the nation, but fought tooth and nail against divisive forces who were bent upon dividing the nation on religious and communal lines.

Besides being a great jurist who went on to become the Chief Justice of Bombay High Court, he also worked as Cabinet Minister in the Union Government and later went on to be sent on important bureaucratic assignments including Ambassador to the United States.

Born on 30 September 1900 in Bombay (present day Mumbai) to a well-off Shia Muslim merchant family, he was educated at St. Xavier's School and College in the city. The Xavier's remains the best college in Mumbai even now. For his higher studies, Chagla went to study at Lincoln College, Oxford, and in the year 1922, he was admitted to the Bar of the Bombay High Court.

Mahommedali Currim Chagla initially worked with the giants of his time like Sir Jamshedji Kanga and Mohammed Ali Jinnah, who at that time had nothing to do with Pakistan

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and was a nationalist leader. He was also one of the best lawyers in the country at that time.

VR Krishna Aiyer, while paying homage to the great mind that Chagla was, writes in the Hindu, "M. C. Chagla was more than a great jurist, brilliant judge, impressive ambassador or successful minister. A versatile personality, uniquely secular, talented in many dimensions, a patriotic statesman and compassionate human, among the rarest of the rare we come across in our sordid planet. As a judge he illumined justice and humanised the law. His burning passion or perennial empathy was inimitable on the bench and outside in public life. Chagla, with an Oxford background and Majlis nationalism, possessing a sharp intellect and sterling character, chose to practise at Mumbai under the then great leader of the Bar, M. A. Jinnah. A few fascinating pages in Chagla's *Roses* are devoted to lovely pen portraits of the leading lights of the Mumbai Bar."

To many people, the thought that Chagla worked under Jinnah seems incredulous. Here was a man who advocated the creation of Pakistan, while on the other hand, there was Chagla, one of the most secular persons in the country. But it should be kept in mind that initially Jinnah was a nationalist who had no affiliation with religion. He was never religious and ate and drank everything that is prohibited in Islam. MC Chagla severed all ties to Jinnah after he began to work for the cause of a separate Muslim nation. Chagla, fed up with the Muslim League's divisive agenda, founded the Muslim Nationalist Party in Bombay, a party which was ignored and pushed aside in the independence struggle. He was very

outspoken critic of the British Raj's oppression in the country and never shied away from criticizing the Raj and its policies in the country.

As Chagla's fame spread as a top-notch jurist, he was soon appointed professor of law at Government Law College, Bombay, in the year 1927. It was here that he got the opportunity to work with Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, who is known as the father of the Indian Constitution. Nothing was impossible for Chagla who claims that he had to work in complete penury while working with MA Jinnah and in the year 1941, he was appointed a judge in Bombay High Court. Seven years later he became the Chief Justice of the same court and remained in his seat for as long as a decade.

One aspect of his life that has always been admired by his fans and opponents alike is the fact that he never shied away or desisted from writing and speaking against the power that be, never thinking for a second if his job will remain or if he will be thrown behind high walls of prison for speaking out.

No one can throw better light on his life and his ideals, than Chagla himself. In his autobiography, *Roses in December*, he says, "As far as I am concerned there are three things to which I have always adhered. They have represented my working faith and my abiding belief. These principles are unity, secularism and democracy. I know all the divisive factors but to my mind they are superficial. I have always thought that it was India's destiny to remain one country and one nation. One has only to look at a map of Asia to be convinced of this fact. With the Himalayas in the north and the sea in the west, south and east, India stands out as

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something distinct and apart from other countries that separate it. The Gods in their wisdom wanted India to remain one and undivided”.

He goes on to add, “Further, there is an Indian-ness and an Indian ethos, which has been brought about by the commission and intercourse between the many races and the many communities that have lived in this land for centuries. There is a heritage which has devolved on us from our Aryan forefathers. There is an Indian tradition which overrides all the minor differences which may superficially seem to contradict the unity. Even the large Muslim community, which numbers about 60 million, inherits the same tradition and legacy, because more than 90 per cent of the Muslims living in India were converted from Hinduism, which is the primary religion of this country. Hindus and Muslims have lived together as friends and comrades from time immemorial. They participate in one another's festivals and even worship together common Saints in whom they both have faith”.

When he retired from the post of Chief Justice of Bombay High Court, he was appointed the Indian ambassador to the USA from 1958 to 1961. He also served as ad hoc judge to the International Court of Justice at The Hague from 1957 to 1959. He was appointed the Education Minister in the Union Government from 1963 to 1966. Later he worked as India's Minister for External Affairs from November 1966 to September 1967.

H M Seervai, Advocate General of Maharashtra while paying tribute to Chagla when he retired as the Chief Justice of

Bombay High Court said, "The Bar is here today to express my Lord the Chief Justice the affection which everyone has for him and our pride and admiration for his work as a Judge and Chief Justice of the Court. It is a proud privilege to speak for the Bar, but I realize how inadequate my words must appear to this gathering, for, if I tried to say all that is in our hearts and minds today, I would not know where to begin or where to end...Rather, to use the words of a great Oxford man, the Earl of Oxford and Asquith, your Lordship always kept with you 'the company of great thoughts, the inspiration of great ideals, the example of great achievements, the consolation of great failures.' You thus brought to your work as a lawyer not only a first class mind, but a sense of form and values which is given by a broad and humane culture, qualities which were to prove invaluable for your work as a judge and for your work with great cultural institutions, in the Bombay University and the Royal Asiatic Society".

If that was not enough, HM Seervai went on to add, "Your elevation to the Bench in 1941 came as no surprise to anyone. Thus began a judicial career as fine as any within the memory of my generation and in 1948 when he became the Chief Justice, the whole Court felt the impress of your personality. I can best describe that impress by saying that you were determined to see that in the Court of which you were the Chief Justice, emphasis should be laid, not so much on the sternness and majesty of justice, as on its healing and protective power, for you felt that justice would be an unlovely figure if kindness and mercy did not go hand in

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hand with her. As to the Bar, it turned to you in all its difficulties and, I must say, it never turned in vain. You had a smile for all and frown for none and you made everyone feel happy and at home in your Court. All this could not have been achieved without self-discipline and natural goodness of heart."

Chagla declined an offer to become a Supreme Court judge and remained content with being the Chief Justice of Bombay High Court. In the year 1949, the Chief Justice of the Federal Court of India, Sir Harilal Kania invited him to join the Federal Court of India that would become the Supreme Court beginning 26<sup>th</sup> January 1950. "My dear Chagla...The Federal Court has to expand now very soon. I shall like to know whether you will like your name to be considered for an appointment before 26th January 1950", wrote the Chief Justice. For historical reasons, the new Constitution was going to come into force on January 26, 1950—a day on which all Federal Court judges would automatically become Supreme Court judges and the Federal Court would become the Supreme Court". But Chagla declined the offer politely.

Mahommedali Currim Chagla breathed his last on 9 February 1981.



## Yusuf Meherally

Many people erroneously believe that the slogan 'Quit India' against the British Raj was given by Mahatma Gandhi. He led the Quit India movement, finally forcing the colonial power to relinquish its rule over India. But it was not.

On the contrary, it was a Muslim youth, Yusuf Meherally, who coined the slogan, wrote a booklet on the need to get rid of the colonial misrule that became very popular within no time. Later, the same slogan was taken over by the freedom movement across the country. Another important slogan that was coined by a rather young Meherally was 'Simon Go Back'.

It was his easy charm, his dedication towards the freedom movement and his hatred for the colonial powers and the occupation of his motherland, besides his courage that made him immensely popular among common people. These were his traits that made him the youngest mayor of Mumbai, despite the fact that he was incarcerated in Lahore when he was elected to the important post.

Meherally would have easily got the best of both the worlds, as he was a child born with the golden spoon. The son of a

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well-to-do businessman, Jaffer Meherally, he was born in Bombay on September 3, 1903. His family was into business and his great grandfather had established one of Bombay's first textile mills.

He was fascinated by Mahatma Gandhi and the freedom movement that was growing as he grew. He was an exceptionally intelligent student and used to think as to why the colonial rulers had taken over India. Even in his early days, while in middle and high school he used to study not just about Indian freedom movement, but about other freedom movements in different parts of the world. He was a thinking youth and didn't take long to realize that the backwardness of India was due to the fact that it was being mulched by the British Raj.

He was also impacted by the growing labor movements across the country. Having witnessed his family's upper class prejudices against factory workers all his life, the sensitive boy was also deeply affected by the struggles of the working class.

There is no denying that his thoughts were in complete contradiction with his family and its ethos. Like any big business family, they were pro establishment and not ready to lose the working relationship with the rulers at that time. Nevertheless, unmindful of their objections and disapproval, he became a part of the freedom movement at a very young age. It is said that he joined the freedom movement immediately after finishing his schooling from Bharda High School, one of the top schools in Bombay at that time.

K Gopalaswami, while discussing the genesis of the slogan, in his book, *Gandhi and Bombay* says, "Shantikumar Morarji has recorded that Gandhi conferred with his colleagues in Bombay on the best slogan for independence – when this was not stated. One of them suggested 'Get out'. Gandhi rejected it as being impolite. Rajagopalachari mentioned 'Retreat' or 'Withdraw'. That too did not find favour. Yusuf Meherali presented Gandhi with a bow bearing the inscription 'Quit India'. Gandhi said in approval, 'Amen'."

It is said that Meherally wrote and published a small booklet titled "Quit India" before the 1942 Quit India Movement launched by Mahatma Gandhi across the country. The book was very timely and well written and thus became a huge success immediately after the launch. It is said that the slogan was actually popularized by none other than him. Later, given its increasing use and the instant chord that it created with the people, it was made the official slogan of the Quit India Movement.

There is no denying that the Quit India Movement was the final nail in the coffin of the British Raj and put the whole machinery of the colonial (mis)rule on the defensive. The movement was launched on a massive scale during the Bombay Session of the All-India Congress Committee by Mahatma Gandhi on 8 August 1942, during World War II. While demanding the end of the British occupation of India, Mahatma Gandhi made a call to 'Do or Die' in his Quit India speech delivered in Bombay at the Gowalia Tank Maidan.

Yusuf Meherally came into the limelight as a young student doing his law when the Simon Commission put its foot in

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Mumbai. The Indian Statutory Commission, known as Simon Commission, consisting of seven members, was a group of seven British MPs, who arrived in India in 1928 to study constitutional reforms in Britain's most important colonial dependency. There was not a single member in the Commission from India and this infuriated a young Yusuf Meherally and his nationalist friends.

Yusuf Meherally, who had launched the Bombay Youth League in the year 1928 itself, organised a protest against the Commission's visit. He and his agitating friends, showing extraordinary fearlessness, dressed up as coolies to get access to the Bombay port where they greeted the members of the commission with black flags and the slogan "Simon Go Back".

This courageous act and defiance, made Yusuf Meherally an instant superstar across the country and his fame reached Mahatma Gandhi who appreciated this daredevil youth. Not only had he dared to shout his slogan in front of a powerful British politician, he had also defied the directions of his political seniors who counseled inaction.

Given his increasing popularity, he was denied permission to practice law in Bombay. It was probably the first instance when a lawyer was not allowed to practice as a lawyer due to his participation in freedom movement.

During the Salt Satyagraha, Yusuf Meherally was arrested when he tried to keep the flame of independence movement alive. Merely two years later, in 1932, he was incarcerated once again for conspiracy and sentenced to a two-year term in

the Nasik prison. It was here that he met and interacted with the radical socialist leaders of the freedom struggle.

Later, he became friends with leading lights of Indian freedom movement including Jayaprakash Narayan, Asok Mehta, Narendra Dev, Achyut Patwardhan and Minoo Masani. They launched a new political front, Congress Socialist Party. It was an effort to be a combination of Congress and the Muslim League without any communal affiliation.

During the Quit India Movement, when the entire top brass of the Indian National Congress was arrested and put behind bars, leaving a vacuum in its leadership, he tried to keep it afloat with his friends Aruna Asaf Ali, Ram Manohar Lohia and Achyut Patwardhan. Nonetheless, he too was caught and put behind bars.

Yusuf Meherally suffered a massive heart attack while in jail and was shifted to St George Hospital for special treatment. But he refused treatment, saying two other ailing leaders who were not so well known be also given similar treatment. They were not given and so he too refused to undergo medication. In the year 1943 he was released, but was a pale shadow of his past.

On July 2, 1950, when this selfless freedom fighter passed away at a young age of 47, the entire Mumbai was shut down showing it respect for the great son of the soil that he was. When the next day the clock struck noon, buses, trams and trains across the city stopped for a few minutes. It is said that Bombay Stock Exchange too had no business on that day.

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## Justice Fazal Ali

Justice Fazal Ali or Khan Bahadur Sayyid Sir Fazl Ali will always be remembered by the nation. He was a great freedom fighter who not just fought for the independence of the nation from British Raj, but also went on to head the States Reorganization Commission. Besides, he also served as the Governor of two states in India.

Born on 19 September 1886, Justice Fazal Ali belonged to a Zamindar family of Bihar. His father's name was Saiyid Nazir Ali while his mother's name was Kubra Begum. His family was not just a wealthy family, but most of the family members were well-educated. His eldest son, Syed Murtaza Fazl Ali, who was the chief Justice of Jammu and Kashmir High Court, later became a judge in the Supreme Court of India. They are among the rarest of the rare father/son duo that served as Supreme Court justices in India.

Justice Fazal Ali, unlike many of his peers, was not educated in England or in any foreign university. His education took place in the country itself. After doing his law he started practicing and had a roaring practice pretty soon.

Given his sharp mind, logical style and nose for details, he won laurels from all around. He was against the divisive

ideology of the Muslim League and supported the Hindu-Muslim unity throughout his life. His no nonsense attitude made him a favorite of the nationalist movement across north India, especially in Bihar, United Province and Orissa.

Sir Fazal Ali was awarded the title of Khan Sahib and later Khan Bahadur. In the year 1918, Justice Fazal Ali was made an Officer of the Order of the British Empire (OBE). He was knighted in the new year's honour's list of 1941 and invested with his knighthood on 1 May 1942 by the Viceroy, Lord Linlithgow.

Justice Fazal Ali was made the Chief Justice of Patna High Court on 19 January 1943 and remained in his post till 14 October 1946. Later he was appointed the judge of Supreme Court on 15 October 1951 and he remained there till 30 May 1952.

Justice Sir Fazal Ali was made the Governor of Orissa (present day Odisha) and honored the post from 1952 to 1956. Later, in the year 1956 he was made the Governor of Assam and remained in his post till his death in 1959.

He was made the head of the State Reorganization Commission (SRC), constituted by the Government of India. Creation of new states or reorganization of the huge states had become an emotional issue after the partition and reorganization was a real tricky issue. The Commission submitted its report on 30 September 1955. A major recommendation of the commission said, as "it is neither possible nor desirable to reorganise States on the basis of the single test of either language or culture, but that a balanced

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approach to the whole problem is necessary in the interest of our national unity."

While he was the Governor of Assam, he tried his best to bring Naga tribals to the national mainstream. He opened the first college in the Naga area in Mokokchung and the college is still named 'Fazl Ali College' in his honour. He was awarded the second highest civilian national honor, the Padma Vibhushan. Sir Fazal Ali breathed his last on 22 August 1959 at the age of 72.



## General Shah Nawaz Khan

General Shah Nawaz Khan is one of those freedom fighters, whose contribution in the freedom movement is accepted by almost everyone. General Shah Nawaz Khan is a completely non controversial personality. His contribution for the freedom struggle was enormous, especially when it comes to the armed struggle against British Raj through Azad Hind Fauj of Subhash Chandra Bose.

He was a freedom fighter of the highest order who went on to fight the British India Army and take control of a large area in the North East. He later became a Gandhian, a Parliamentarian and an avowed Congressi who turned into a unifying force for the Congress party.

Shah Nawaz Khan not just survived the vagaries of war, the subsequent incarceration and the legal fight he had to face from the British Raj, but went on to see a free India. He fought for secular and democratic ethos during the British Raj's misrule and oppressive regime, and continued to struggle for it in the free India whenever there were signs that India may tread a different path.

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General Shah Nawaz Khan was born on 24 January 1914. Legendary and heroic stories of General Shah Nawaz Khan are still fresh in the minds of people who have studied the war of India's independence and the sort of sacrifices that the country and freedom fighters gave for the nation.

General Shah Nawaz Khan was not a born freedom fighter or dissenter. Despite his obvious mistrust of the British rule, he had joined the British Army. Given his exceptional strategic mind, he rose to the rank of the captain in the Indian Army and went on to fight the Japanese forces on different fronts.

Like a large number of his colleagues, he was also captured by the Japanese forces when they successfully defeated the British forces and took control of Singapore in 1942. A prisoner of war in Singapore, General Shah Nawaz Khan came in contact with revolutionary forces and was soon enamored by Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose.

A former president of the Indian National Congress, Subhash Chandra Bose, had left the Congress party due to his different opinion on how to secure the freedom of the nation from the British Raj. Through his speeches, he was asking prisoners of war (POWs) to join the Indian National Army and fight for a free India.

General Shah Nawaz Khan was simply mesmerized by Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose's powerful speeches and equally impressive slogans. Later, while accepting the enormous influence of Netaji on him during incarceration in Singapore, General Shah Nawaz Khan said, "It will not be wrong to say that I was hypnotized by his personality and his speeches. He

placed the true picture of India before us and for the first time in my life I saw India, through the eyes of an Indian."

Very soon he was not just the part of the Indian National Army but its inner core. Shah Nawaz Khan was inducted in the Cabinet of the Arzi Hukumat-e- Azad Hind (INA) formed by Bose. He was made the incharge of the top cadres of the INA and sent to lead the fight against British Raj in India. General Shah Nawaz Khan, using his expertise with the British India Army, mounted successful attacks, taking control of a large swathe of territories including Kohima and Imphal. In December 1944, Shah Nawaz Khan was appointed Commander of the 1<sup>st</sup> Division at Mandalay.

There is no denying that the Indian National Army or Aazad Hind Fauj had seen significant military action in the Imphal-Kohima sector and INA troops had become the stuff of legends. Bose himself had died in a plane crash in August 1945; though the circumstances of his death were deemed highly suspicious by many, his apotheosis as the great martyr had taken place. Nevertheless, Britain's victory in World War II as part of the Allied forces was decisive, and the INA had been disbanded in May 1945. Soldiers who had engaged in traitorous conduct could not be allowed to go unpunished.

Soon the leading lights of the INA including General Shah Nawaz Khan, Colonel Prem Sahgal and Colonel Gurbaksh Singh Dhillon were put on trial on charges of murder, abetment to murder, and "waging war against the King-Emperor". Despite the fact that Bose had lost his life in the alleged aircraft crash and the Congress leaders were behind bars due to quit Indian movement, there were huge

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demonstrations against this sham trial. Nehru, in a speech delivered on November 3, two days before the prosecution was launched, stated that "the trial of the three INA officers will be of historical importance...It touches the sentiments of the whole nation." Demonstrations in solidarity with the accused were held throughout the country, and Gandhi and Patel were among those who visited the accused in jail. A Hindu, a Sikh, and a Muslim had been put on trial, in unintended homage to Bose's own defiance of communal divisions, and the Indian National Congress successfully defended all three heroes.

Their case was fought by a defence committee headed by the likes of Asaf Ali, Jawaharlal Nehru, Sir Tej Bahadur Sapru, Bhulabhai Desai and others. The counsels said that the accused could not be tried under the Indian Penal Code (IPC) and that international law was applicable in this case. Nehru, who had stopped practicing law at least 25 years ago, donned his barrister's gowns and made a couple of appearances in court.

General Shah Nawaz Khan, the foremost leader of the INA was given the death sentence by the court. However, that sentence was reduced to cashiering by the Commander-in-Chief of the Indian Army. After the trial, Khan declared that he would henceforth follow the path of non-violence espoused by Gandhi and he joined the Indian National Congress. Having successfully contested the first Lok Sabha in 1952 from Meerut, Khan had an illustrious parliamentary career. He served as Parliamentary Secretary and Deputy Minister of Railway and Transport for 11 years from 1952 to

1964. He was elected four times to the Lok Sabha from Meerut parliamentary seat in 1951, 1957, 1962 and 1971.

In 1956, the government constituted a committee to look into the circumstances around Subhas Chandra Bose's death with Khan as the head of the committee. The Committee named as the '1956 Shah Nawaz Committee' began the work in April 1956 and concluded four months later when two out of the three members concluded that Bose had died in the airplane crash at Taihoku (Japanese for Taipei) in Formosa (now Taiwan), on 18 August 1945. This great freedom fighter breathed his last on 9 December 1983.

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## Allama Fazle Haq Khairabadi

**A**llama Fazle Haq Khairabadi's name cannot be forgotten by India. To be true, the nation will remain indebted to this great and fearless man who hogged the limelight as a confidante of the last Mughal emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar and later of another great freedom fighter, Begum Hazrat Mahal.

Born towards the end of the 18<sup>th</sup> century in the year 1797, Fazle Haq Khairabadi was not just a common freedom fighter, he was a great negotiator, a consummate manager, a top laureate who wrote numerous books on varied topics. Khairabad is a town in Sitapur district in Uttar Pradesh.

Allama Fazle Haq Khairabadi can be described as the author of India's first secular and inclusive constitution that was implemented in the truncated state, still under control of Bahadur Shah Zafar. It was well before the Mughal emperor was dethroned and thrown into imprisonment in Yangon, where he spent his life in extreme penury, destitution and deprivation.

The dexterity of Fazle Haq Khairabadi can be gauged by the fact that he occupied top posts in the courts of different rulers of North India. He was very popular not just among Muslim

nawabs, but also Hindu maharajas, showing his general acceptability across North India.

There is no denying that Fazle Haq Khairabadi was a legend who invited admiration not just from his fans, but also from his sworn enemies. He could have easily avoided being sent to *Kalapani* and die an ignominious death. It is said that as the English judge was writing his release order after he had successfully defended himself in the court, he told the judge that he had indeed released a fatwa (religious edict) ordering every Muslim to fight the British occupation. He refused to speak lie even in the eye of extreme hostility that led an otherwise high profile personality being sent to the distant *Kalapani* and die as an unsung hero there.

Fazle Haq Khairabadi had served under different governments in North India on different positions, including as a chief judge in Lucknow. When the Ghadar of 1857 flopped, Fazl e Haq Khairabadi, despite being covered by an amnesty from the queen of England, was arrested by the British authorities on 30 January 1859 at Khairabad. During a sham hearing process, Fazle Haq Khairabadi was tried and found guilty of encouraging murder and taking a leadership role in the Mutiny.

His memory was so sharp that he memorized the entire Qur'an in just four months and was already eligible to teach students double his age when he was all of 13 years. On account of his deep knowledge and erudition he was called Allama and later was venerated as a great Sufi. He received his education in Islamic sciences from top scholars of the time including Shah Abdul Aziz, and his younger brother Shah

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Abdul Qadir and in rational sciences from his father. Reports suggest that he joined the services of the British Government at the age of nineteen in 1816 and served as *Sar Rishtadar* (Chief of the Civil Court) in Delhi.

He was an exceptional poet. Historic accounts suggest that he edited and corrected the poetry of legendary Urdu and Persian poet, Mirza Ghalib, on his request.

Allama Fazle Haq Khairabadi played one of the most important roles in the entire Mutiny. It is rather disappointing that we don't hear much about him or his contributions these days. Nevertheless, the blame should be on us as we have let the world forget such great people who tried to preserve the integrity of the nation and fight the occupation forces. Munshi Jeevan Lal in his *Roznamcha* says that on the 16th of August, 1857, Maulvi Fazle Haque attended the audience in the durbar of Mogul emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar. It is also said that Khairabadi requested the Emperor to raise the grants of the freedom fighters, but the Emperor excused due to the empty coffers of his shrunken empire. To bring the empire out of the financial crisis, Khairabadi, with the permission of the Emperor, appointed the brother of his son-in-law Mir Nawab as the governor of Delhi and his son Maulvi Abdul Haque Khairabadi as the collector of Gurgaon. It is also said that Khairabadi himself was one of the members of the administrative council or governing body, which was running under Mughal Emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar during the uprising of 1857.



Historic accounts suggest that when the British Raj occupied Delhi on 20 September 1857, and thousands of people were massacred by the bloodthirsty soldiers, Khairabadi left his abode in Delhi on 24<sup>th</sup> of September and reached Alwar, where he left his children and moved towards Khairabad in December 1857. He reached his ancestral village, Khairabad, after two month-long tiresome journey.

When another citadel of the freedom fighters tumbled in the form of Lucknow, Begum Hazrat Mahal along with her revolutionary army left for Sitapur, the home district of Maulvi Khairabadi. He joined Begum Hazrat Mahal and accompanied her in the different places like Bundi, Kheri, Hargaon, Tambul, Sahupur and Darya. However, he returned to Khairabad following the declaration of a general amnesty by Queen Victoria. He met Colonel Clark at Sabiha in Sitapur on 26<sup>th</sup> December, before the end of the prosecution free period of 30th December 1858, as fixed by Queen Victoria in her proclamation.

But he was betrayed. Instead of being freed as part of the general amnesty, he was arrested and sent to Lucknow in January 1859. His trial started in the court of Captain F.A.V. Thurburn. After a sham hearing, Khairabadi was found guilty of being the leader of the revolutionary government during 1857-58, and instigating the people of Delhi, Awadh and other areas to revolt and murder. The charge-sheet also said that he actively participated in meetings of Mammu Khan, a revolutionary leader of Bundi. Authorities also accused him of issuing a religious decree (fatwa) ordering people to revolt.

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Historic accounts suggest that from Lucknow, Khairabadi was sent to Calcutta and from there to Port Blair in Andaman Islands. He didn't lose heart and continued seeking release. He sent a mercy plea to the Secretary of State for India from his prison cell in Port Blair. "I don't go into detail, I only draw your kind attention towards the decision of special commissioner and my applications to the Government of India; these will decide that how the law and proclamation of Her Excellency (Queen Victoria) has been flouted in my trial, proving me guilty and thereafter giving the decision of punishment...Her Excellency had fixed the last date of December 1858. I surrendered before the higher military officer of Sitapur before the fixed date and also sought the benefit certificate" said Allama Khairabadi.

Khairabadi breathed his last on 20<sup>th</sup> August 1861 after ten months and thirteen days in Kalapani. It is said that the day he died, his son, Maulvi Shamsul Haq, brought his release order. But the Allama had achieved eternal freedom and no occupation force could trouble him ever again.

Despite being heartbroken by incarceration in Kalapani, Allama Khairabadi didn't sit idle in the prison. On the contrary, he wrote three classic books in Arabic in the prison titled *Al Sauratul Hindiya*, *Qasida Hamzia* and *Qasida Dalia*. *Al Sauratul Hindiya* is an unmatched first person account of the Mutiny of 1857.

## Maulana Shaukat Ali

Maulana Shaukat Ali was a revolutionary leader in the truest sense. He was a scholar, a writer, a nationalist and academic par excellence. Shaukat Ali was born in the most tumultuous period when the signs of injuries sustained during the Mutiny of 1857 were so fresh and vividly present in the minds of the entire nation, particularly the Muslims who had suffered the worst.

The first war of freedom fought across north India in the year 1857, finally ended with the decimation of Muslim power as Mughal Empire and Oudh were destroyed and occupied by a marauding British imperialism.

The elder brother of another great freedom fighter and scholar, Maulana Muhammad Ali Jauhar, he was born on 10 March in what was Rampur state in United Province (UP). It was a time when Rampur was the center of art and literature and a large number of poets and scholars from across North India were being hosted there by the Rohilla Nawabs of the city state. Despite being a small principality, Rampur nawabs patronized laureates from across the nation, including the best Urdu poet ever, Mirza Ghalib.

He belonged to a family of scholars. His father was a prominent writer. After his education at the Shaikh-ul-Islam's school, he then became a well-known and excellent writer, famous from various parts of the person. He was a writer, a poet, and a player of playing cards. During his college days, he impressed early on. He joined the service of the Government of Opium in 1907. He stayed in the service of the Government of Aligarh for 10 years. He reported to the Government of Madras in 1917. As the Government of Madras was the most important nation, such a position was the first step.

He belonged to a well-to-do and rather very educated family. His father worked in the court of the Nawab of Rampur. After his early studies in Rampur and Bareilly, Maulana Shaukat Ali was sent to Aligarh Muslim University, that by then had become the foremost center of educational excellence for Indian Muslims. To be true, till then it was known as Mohammedan Anglo Oriental College, Aligarh from where he graduated in 1895. There, his overall personality came in its own, transforming into a great orator, writer, negotiator and author. Besides, he was extremely fond of playing cricket, captaining the university team.

During his time at the Mohammedan Anglo Oriental College, Maulana Shaukat Ali, was among the most impressive students. His oratorical skills got recognition at an early age as he won Cambridge Speaking Prize in 1894.

He joined the civil services in Awadh and Agra and reports suggest that he served in a senior position in Government Opium Department as Assistant Opium Agent for 17 long years. He felt stifled while serving as a civil servant, but he stayed there to fund his younger brother's education, first in Aligarh and later in England. Maulana Shaukat Ali was reportedly elected Honorary Secretary, Old Boys Association of Mohammedan Anglo Oriental College, Aligarh from 1913 to 1915.

As the colonial powers were spreading their tentacles across the Muslim lands, breaking kingdoms and destroying Muslim nations across Asia and Africa, he expressed his opposition to such colonial misadventures in Muslim lands. He was one of the founders of a society named Anjuman Khuddam-i-Kaaba

that had fundamental aim of protecting the holy places of Islam from European colonial powers including UK, France and Russia.

He was a good writer, besides being a very gifted orator and helped his younger brother Muhammad Ali Jauhar in launching daily newspapers 'Hamdard' and 'Comrade' from Calcutta and Delhi. Along with Maulana Muhammad Ali Jauhar, he was incarcerated in May 1915. The two remained behind high prison walls for the next four and half years and were finally released from the prison in December 1919.

Shaukat Ali was among the fiercest opponents of the British meddling in Turkey, India, Egypt, Malay, Afghanistan and Hejaz. In 1919, while jailed for publishing what the British authorities charged as seditious materials and organizing protests, he was elected as the last president of the Khilafat conference. He was re-arrested and imprisoned from 1921 to 1923 for his support to Mahatma Gandhi and the Indian National Congress during the Non-Cooperation Movement (1919-1922). In March 1922, he was in Rajkot jail from where he was released in 1923. Nevertheless, such regular bouts of arrests and imprisonments didn't dim the determination in him to evict the Britain from India.

Maulana Shaukat Ali called All Parties Muslim Conference in 16th session, Bombay, December 1924. He attended Muslim League Council meeting where he appealed for unity and favoured compromise with Hindus. He was apparently not happy with the increasingly communal color that the Indian National Congress was showing in areas like United Province, Bengal and Punjab, besides many other places. In

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1934, he was elected Indian Member of Central Legislative Assembly. Maulana Shaukat Ali left for his eternal journey on 26th November 1938 and was buried near Jama Masjid, Delhi.

## Syed Mahmud

**D**r. Syed Mahmud's contribution in the Indian freedom movement and in improving the lot of the Muslims in the country cannot be forgotten. He was a true nationalist who abhorred communalism and fought against it tooth and nail. A top jurist in the country, he was revered by people of all communities and loved and respected equally by both Hindus and Muslims.

He was a staunch supporter of the Hindu Muslim unity. Syed Mahmud believed that only by coming together and uniting, Muslims and Hindus can progress and prosper together. He never differentiated between Hindus and Muslims and did everything to stall the division of the nation on communal grounds.

Coming from the fertile land of Ghazipur in United Province (now Uttar Pradesh), Dr Syed Mahmud was educated at the Aligarh Muslim University. Due to his involvement with the freedom movement, he was expelled from the University. He is probably among very few people who were summarily rusticated from the university despite being Indian National Congress activists.

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It was during his stay in the Aligarh Muslim University that Dr Syed Mahmud got enamored by the freedom movement of the country. From Khilafat Movement to the Non-Cooperation Movement and then Quit India Movement, he was part of the struggle for the nation and never buckled under pressure despite repeated bouts of imprisonment.

His association with Mahatma Gandhi and the Indian National Congress began rather very early. He was among a few students from Aligarh Muslim University who attended the 1905 session of the Indian National Congress. Along with fellow student and later political leader, Dr. Saifuddin Kitchlew, Mahmud was amongst the Muslim students who opposed the pro-British loyalties of the All India Muslim League and were drawn more to the nationalist Congress.

His expulsion from Aligarh Muslim University on the pretext of association with the freedom movement proved a blessing in disguise for him. Dr Syed Mahmud went to England and studied Law at Cambridge University before going on to study at Lincoln's Inn to become a barrister. He met top leaders of the freedom movement during his stay in London. Among the people he developed close ties rather very soon included none other than Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru whom he met in the year 1909 while in London.

His biographers suggest that from London he went to Germany, still not a very popular place for Indian students and in the year 1912 obtained Ph.D. from there. Later he came back to India and launched his legal career from Patna where he soon had a roaring legal practice.



Prof Muhammad Sajjad in one of his articles says, "In 1915, he married Mazharul Haq's niece. Throughout his career he insisted on communal harmony, played significant role in the Congress- League Pact of Lucknow in 1916. Served with the Home Rule League, AICC and gave up his legal practice to participate in the Khilafat Movement. He also authored, *The Khilafat & England*. In 1922, he was imprisoned. In 1923, he was elected Deputy General Secretary of the AICC. In 1929, with M.A. Ansari, he formed 'Muslim Nationalist Party' within the Congress, and became the General Secretary of the Congress, and served in this capacity till 1936. In 1930, along with M.L. Nehru and J.L. Nehru he was imprisoned in the Naini Jail of Allahabad, for his participation in the Civil Disobedience Movement".

"The correspondences of Syed Mahmud reveal that by 1939, he had developed considerable disillusionment with the Congress on the issue of communalism, which he wanted to be addressed on priority. In fact, in 1937, when the Congress was going to form ministries in provinces, according to Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, Syed Mahmud was the most deserving candidate for Chief Ministership in Bihar, but Rajendra Prasad played a game, called two essentially caste leaders viz. Shri Krishna Sinha (Bhumihar) and Anugraha Narayan Sinha (Rajput) from the Central Assembly and got S.K. Sinha 'elected'. Azad expressed his agony in his *India Wins Freedom* (P.17), (blamed Rajendra Prasad who threw his weight behind S.K. Sinha), and said that 'the Congress failed the test of Nationalism'. Whereas Rajendra Prasad's

Autobiography fails to defend the act, only thing he says that he did not repent the decision” Sajjad adds.

Dr Syed Mahmud was alive to the increasing communalism that was creeping in India and even within the freedom movement. To reduce the Hindu Muslim divide and also Hindi-Urdu tension, Dr Mahmud started publishing an Urdu-Hindi bilingual newspaper, *Raushmi* (light).

Dr Mahmud, at the height of question of division of Punjab, authored an exceptional book, '*A Plan of Provincial Reconstruction*'. The book that touched upon many issues that had gained much publicity and needed explanation from top leaders of the freedom movement, became a best-seller within no time. Reports suggest that at least a dozen editions of the book were printed in the year 1939 alone.

Dr Syed Mahmud was a leading light of the Khilafat Movement and tried his best to expose the oppression and miseries wrought upon the Indians and in other parts of the world by the British colonial masters. He saw Khilafat Movement not just as a tool to put the British Colonial rulers in a tight spot, expose their weaknesses, present them as mere mortals like other nations, unite the Indians, particularly the Indian Muslims behind the Congress but also defeat their nefarious designs against the Indian nation.

Despite his reservation about Congress' sincerity on the issue of increasing communalism in it, he was in the leading role when Quit Indian Movement was launched. To be true, he was among those members of the Congress Working Committee who actually endorsed the 1942 Quit India

movement, calling for an immediate end to British rule. Given his tough and uncompromising stance towards colonial occupiers, Dr Syed Mahmud was imprisoned along with other top Congress leaders. Most of them were incarcerated in Ahmednagar Fort jail.

Many of the detained leaders of the freedom movement were surprised when Dr Mahmud was abruptly released from the jail. He feigned ignorance about it, but the British authorities released a letter allegedly written by Mahmud to the Viceroy of India saying he didn't participate in the passage of the Quit India Resolution. He met Mahatma Gandhi and expressed his apologies for the mistake he had committed.

His strong opposition to the politics of hate, including Muslim League's two nation theory cemented his place in the freedom movement once again. His incarceration in Ahmadnagar Fort was not the first time he was put behind bars. In 1930, he was imprisoned in Allahabad along with Jawaharlal Nehru during the Civil Disobedience Movement. Syed Mahmud served as the deputy general secretary of the All India Congress Committee. In 1929, with M.A. Ansari, he formed 'Muslim Nationalist Party' within the Congress, and became the General Secretary of the Congress, and served in this capacity till 1936. He had so close relationship with Nehru that Nehru was one of the two witnesses who signed at the time of his daughter's marriage.

He was made the Minister for Education, Development and Planning in 1937 in the Sri Krishna Sinha led government in Bihar when Congress swept elections. During 1946-52, Syed

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Mahmud was the Minister for Transport, Industries and Agriculture in Bihar.

When India gained independence, Syed Mahmud was elected to the first Lok Sabha from Champaran-East constituency and served as the deputy Minister of External Affairs between 1954 and 1957. He also won second Lok Sabha election from Gopalganj, Bihar. He breathed his last in the year 1971, four years before imposition of emergency in the country.

## Maulana Mazharul Haque

**M**aulana Mazharul Haque was not an ordinary freedom fighter. He was a father figure in India's freedom movement and patronized many other personalities who went on to become leading lights of the freedom struggle. The most important aspect of his personality and those of his friends and protégés is the fact that they all had one thing in common, hatred for communalism and differentiating on the basis of religion and castes.

Maulana Mazharul Haque was a multifaceted personality who was born merely nine years after the Mutiny of 1857. This was the time when the Muslims were still being persecuted by the British occupation forces in India. For several years after the occupation of Delhi and ignominious expulsion of last Mughal king Bahadur Shah Zafar from the country, Muslims were kept away from Delhi. Even in his native Patna district, hundreds of revolutionaries were put to death in public squares following the Mutiny. It was certainly a very tough time for Indians in general and Muslims in particular in India.

Under such tough circumstances, Maulana Mazharul Haque tried his best to infuse courage and hope among both, the Hindus and Muslims in north India. He was a man who

spoke truth even in the face of death and never ever feared anyone.

He was born on 22 December, 1866, in a rich family of Bahpura, Patna district. His father, Sheikh Ahmedullah, was a big landlord of the region with huge tracts of land under him. Mazharul Haque got admission in Patna College from where he completed matriculation. He was sent to Lucknow's famed Canning College in 1886. But the same year, he was sent for higher studies to England. He completed his law degree from there, came back to Patna and started legal practice there.

In the year 1906, he was elected Vice Chairman of Bihar Congress Committee. All the Congress movements had his significant contributions from planning to the execution. He helped organize the Home Rule Movement in Bihar and was its President in 1916. Maulana Mazharul Haque was one of the leading lights of the Champaran Satyagraha and actually planned everything for the agitation. The British government was so much annoyed by his disregard of the colonial rulers that he was sentenced to 3 months imprisonment.

Like top Muslim personalities of the time, he joined Maulana Muhammad Ali Jauhar and Shaukat Ali in launching Khilafat Movement. The Khilafat Movement sought to achieve twin goals of fighting the imperialistic powers and arousing the Indian masses from slumber, impressing upon them the need to fight the occupation. When the Khilafat Movement was launched, Mazharul Haque sacrificed his booming legal practice, his elected post as member of the Imperial Legislative Council and turned all his efforts to the freedom

struggle. By now, he was a firm believer in complete Independence being “the birthright of every Nation”.

Mazharul Haque was also a fervent believer in democratic decentralization and thus organized the Panchayats in Saran district towards meeting this vision. He also made many requests for better educational facilities in Bihar, especially for free and compulsory primary education.

Maulana Mazharul Haque supported the anti-*purdah* movement launched in Bihar in response to the Non Cooperation Movement of 1920. Mahatma Gandhi sought to bring women also into mainstream politics, to strengthen the resistance against British rule as well as empower them to play a more active role in society. The *purdah* system espoused by Muslim and many Hindu families, especially in Bihar, meant that women remained behind men in all spheres of life. In response to the call of abandoning government run colleges, he launched Bihar Vidyapeeth.

In his well-received book on the renowned freedom fighter, ‘*Mazharul Haque and Indian National Congress*’ Nirmal Kumar says, “Thus humanism flowed in heart and soul of Mazharul Haque. Alas, his desire of Hindu-Muslim unity could not be achieved. Subsequent historical events like riots of Kanpur in 1913, communal riots of 1920 and riots of Sahabad, Patna hurt him deeply. So it is very difficult task to say something on the impact of his speech or saying among the two remains a fact that Haque by quoting facts tried to place ideological background for preservation of Hindu-Muslim unity. This way might have led to independent India”.

He goes on to add, "In that very session, he concluded that there were a good number of Musalmans, who were participating as Congressmen. He wished, "wish the two sister communities to understand each other, have tolerance for each other's weakness, join hands and work together. To my mind this is one of the greatest works to which an Indian could devote his life. The Bankipur speech of Haque is a fine expression of how Hindu-Muslim communities may live together for liberating the country from foreign rule."

Maulana Mazharul would have become the President of the Indian National Congress as the INC had asked him to lead the party in 1926 Session in Guwahati. But he declined. While talking about it Nirmal says, "By Organizing Congress movement in various towns and cities of Bihar and Orissa, Mazharul Haque had occupied an admirable position among Congressmen in Bihar. In recognition of his rightful service to the Congress, it had sent a delegation in 1914 comprising Mazharul Haque, Schchidananda Sinha from Bihar to England with a view to recognizing India Council. Mazharul Haque and others worked well and it had wider influence on the British government".

Maulana was firm believer in Hindu-Muslim unity. His famous quote sums up his conviction, "Wheather we are, Hindu or Musalmaan we are in the same boat, we must sail or sink together".



## Badruddin Tyabji

**B**adruddin Tyabji was a great lawyer, a fearless and outspoken freedom fighter and a personality above communal and religious affiliations. He was the first Muslim to serve as the President of the Indian National Congress and overall the third president of the party that led the freedom movement in the latter years. He also became the first Indian judge in the Bombay High Court and first Indian to grace the post of the Chief Justice of Bombay High Court.

His achievements were unbelievable as he always looked a step ahead of the time and never complained about his personal deficiencies or the adverse circumstances in which he lived. It is all the more surprising that he suffered several bouts of ill-health from his childhood all the way to his college days.

Son of a well-known and wealthy Bombay-based businessman, Mullah Tyab Ali Bhai Mian, Badruddin Tyabji was born on 10 October 1844. He was sent to study abroad at a rather very young age. All the seven sons of Mullah Tyab Ali Bhai Mian, who was a religious leader of the Sulaimani Bohra community, were sent to England for their higher

education. An elder brother of Badruddin Tyabji was the first Indian solicitor allowed to practice in England.

Badruddin Tyabji is still an inspiration to a large number of Indian Muslims and other Indians who want to emulate his all-round achievements and serve the nation as the sage jurist did for his nation. More than hundred and ten years after his death, his popularity among a section of the population remains intact. There is no denying that it was due to sheer hard work, dedication, awareness of responsibility that fell on every citizen of the nation and his exploits as a jurist of highest caliber that won him admiration and a huge fan following across the country.

The initial education of the legend took place at his home and at Dada Makhra's Madrassa where he was taught basic Urdu and Persian, the usual pattern of education at that time. Later he was admitted to Elphinstone College that was called Elphinstone Institution at that time. He spent some times there before being sent to France for an emergency eye surgery that was impacting his vision rather adversely. Soon he was off to London where he was admitted in Newbury High Park College in London while still only 16 years old. After completing his matriculation with high ranks he was sent to the Middle Temple. Badruddin Tyabji became the first Indian barrister in Mumbai in April, 1867. It will take as much as two decades before he would be appointed a judge at the Bombay High Court in 1895.

His biographers suggest that Badruddin Tyabji started practicing at the Bombay High Court the same year he landed in Bombay. It is said that he had the distinction of

being the first Indian Barrister in the Bombay High Court. Initially he faced uphill task in setting up the practice and it was something without a precedent that an Indian will practice law in a court that had only British lawyers and judges till then. Nonetheless, as the years passed and the fellow lawyers and judges were impressed by his extraordinary legal insights, they started cooperating with him pretty soon. It is said that he had no equal in the entire Bombay High Court when it came to fluency of speech, clarity of thoughts, lucidity of exposition, skill in cross-examining and above all a perfectly dignified personality.

A book, '*Eminent Mussalmans*', while praising him says, an "anecdote illustrates the strength of the man, the quality that has been generally acknowledged as characteristic of him both as barrister and as judge. We take it from an appreciation that appeared in the Bengalee: It is some years since he appeared as counsel for an accused person in a criminal appeal before a Division Bench consisting of Mr. Justice Parsons and Mr. Justice Ranade. The case had excited some sensation at the time and it was during the hot days of May that the two judges had to hear the appeal. Mr. Tyabji began his argument with some introductory remarks giving a general view of the case, and that occupied about half an hour. He then commenced reading the evidence. He had not gone on for more than ten minutes when Mr. Justice Parsons, who always liked a short argument, said: We have read the evidence, Mr. Tyabji. Mr. Tyabji met the remark with a cool 'Yes' and went on reading the deposition all the same. Mr, Justice/ Parsons' what is the use of reading the depositions

and wasting the time of the Court when we have read them all? Better confine yourself to such comments as you may have to make on the evidence.' Mr. Tyabji; 'I dare say, my Lord, your Lordships have read the evidence but you have read it in your way. I am here to make your Lordships read that evidence in my way and it is only then that you can follow my comment.' And Mr. Tyabji had it his own way. For two days he kept the Court occupied hearing his arguments, with the result that at last he secured an acquittal for his client, and the, remark went round the Bar that Mr. Tyabji had given a good patience to the Bench”.

For initial ten years in legal practice, he wanted to excel in the field and become a prominent lawyer, so he could do something worthwhile for the community. Without the complete attention to job he wouldn't have achieved the success in a field less travelled by Indians of his generation.

Nevertheless, when he got involved in social and political causes, he did his utmost to improve the lots of common Indians and the Muslims alike. He became Secretary of the Anjuman-i-Islam of Bombay in 1880 and then President and raised the influence of that institution to be one of the most powerful in the Bombay Presidency. Anjuman-i-Islam remains a potent tool to improve the lot of Muslims in Mumbai and nearby towns even now.

Besides education, his attention was focused on improving the lot of women in general and Muslim women in particular. Tyabji was active in women's emancipation and was against the *purdah* system that he believed confined fifty percent of the population to their homes without making any

contribution for the development and prosperity of the nation. There is no denying that Tyabji was not blind to some Congress leaders' effort to give communal hue to the freedom struggle and worked to strengthen the Muslim community by working overtime for educational and overall development of the community. During his time as President of the Indian National Congress (1887–88), he focused on uniting the Muslim community and gaining influence internally.

He was one of the most prominent faces fighting for the rights of Indians and the eventual freedom of the nation from the British oppression. The book '*Eminent Mussalmans*' says during his presidential address while accepting the offer Tyabji "began by saying that he had accepted the office of President in spite of ill-health, not so much because it was the highest honour that the people could confer on an Indian, as because he was anxious to demonstrate in his capacity as a representative of the Anjuman-i- Islam, of Bombay, that there was nothing in the aims and methods of the Indian National Congress which could justify his co-religionists in keeping aloof from it. He then went on to impress on his audience the need for moderation, caution, and forbearance, a need always present, but at that time of the infancy of the Congress most imperative."

The doyen of Indian freedom struggle and an ardent supporter of Muslim emancipation breathed his last on 19 August 1906 at 61 year of age.

## Col Mehboob Ahmed

Col Mehboob Ahmed was a young officer working in the British Indian Army and was captured by Japanese forces in Burma and Singapore along with his military unit. Like many officers who were taken as prisoners of war (POWs), he too crossed over to Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose's Indian National Army that was supported and armed by Japan.

Soon he became a confidante of Netaji as he worked as his personal secretary. Like General Shah Nawaz Khan, he too was brought back to Delhi after Japan and the INA were summarily defeated by the Allied forces. After a lengthy but sham prosecution, he was awarded death sentence. But as India gained independence from the British colonial rule, the death warrant was never carried out.

Nevertheless, unlike other INA stalwarts, Col Mehboob Ahmed didn't join politics or fight elections. He is said to have joined India's external affairs ministry where he served for decades. He had a rather exemplary career as diplomat serving as ambassador and high commissioner in Indian embassies around the world.

In a detailed article on Col Mehboob Ahmed, in the Asian Age, S.K. Sinha, says “All that I know about Second Lieutenant Mehboob Ahmed of 1/13 FF Rifles (now 7FF) and Colonel Mehboob Ahmed of INA is that in 1945 he was the military secretary to Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose. In 1946 Captain SK Sinha (later Lt Gen and governor of Assam and Jammu & Kashmir) met him in a PoW camp in Insein jail in Rangoon. He had known Mehboob Ahmed from his hometown Patna. He recalls Mehboob being very proud of having fought for India’s Independence and he considered those fighting for the British as mercenaries. He was inspired by Netaji’s personality and worshiped him immensely. After the infamous INA trials held at Red Fort, Mehboob was freed and was given a hero’s welcome in Patna”.

Sinha goes on to add, “In 1972, Mahboob Ahmed, then a senior official of the ministry of external affairs deposed before the Khosla Commission and stated the Japanese respected Bose and their common interest was to evict the British from India. In 1991 Mehboob Ahmed gave an interview to Sugata Bose, a relative of Subhash Chandra Bose for his book *His Majesty’s Opponent: Subhas Chandra Bose and India’s Struggle against Empire*. If by any chance Col Mehboob Ahmed is alive today he must be a very old man. If he has passed away, perhaps he lies buried somewhere in his native Patna. I hope he is at peace with himself for having fought for the right cause”.

It is said that Col. Mahboob Ahmad retired from Indian Foreign Service in 1978 as the Indian High Commissioner in

Canada. He died in 1992 in Patna and is survived by his wife and three children.

Historic accounts suggest that he was born on 19 May 1920. He did his M.A from Prince of Wales Royal Indian Military College. Mahboob Ahmad was the son of Dr. Wali Ahmed. During the period of the British Raj he was King's Commissioned Indian Officer (KCIO King Official Officer of India). In the year 1939 Col Mahboob Ahmad was commissioned as Indian Commissioned Officer of the British Indian Army. In 1942 he was taken prisoner of war by the Japanese and entered the Indian National Army of Subhas Chandra Bose as Colonel. It is said that Col Mahboob Ahmad was Field Aide (militia) of General Shah Nawaz Khan and commanded the Battle of Imphal in which he captured the Klang Klang Fort.

After India's independence, instead of joining politics, he joined India's foreign officer. From 1961 to 1964 he was Consul General in Berlin, from 1964 to 1967 he was High Commissioner in Kuala Lumpur (Malaysia), from 1967 to 1970 he was India's ambassador to Baghdad (Iraq). From 1974 to 1976 he was India's ambassador in Jakarta (Indonesia) and from April 1977 to September 1978 he served as India's High Commissioner to Canada.



## Begum Hazrat Mahal

**B**egum Hazrat Mahal is among a handful of freedom fighters whose contribution in the first war of independence cannot be erased from the collective memory of the nation. Despite being a frail woman, she led an army against the British colonial masters who were trying to destroy the country, enslave the nation, usurp the unlimited natural resources that God had gifted to the nation and steal all the riches that India was famous for at that time.

There are some people who claim that British colonialism proved good for India as it brought railways and modern education to the country. But this argument should be thrown to the dustbin given the fact that the occupation forces completely decimated the national economy. When the Britons came to India with their cannons and armadas, the nation contributed around 25 percent of the world economy, with Indians among the most civilized people in the world. But when they were forced to flee the nation, they left a tattered economy that contributed just around one percent of the world economy and people who were made paupers by unending exploitation at the hands of their colonial masters.

Begum Hazrat Mahal was a woman made of steel. Despite being a frail looking woman, she inspired millions of people to revolt against the colonial masters when many powerful

looking people refused to stand on their two feet and see the British occupation forces in their eyes. She first took control of Lucknow the capital of Awadh and then surrounding places. She gave a tough fight to the Colonial forces for more than a year. It took a long time for the large occupation armies with powerful weaponry to subdue and defeat her.

Begum Hazrat Mahal was born in the year 1820 in Faizabad, Awadh. It is said that she was the second wife of Nawab Wajid Ali Shah, the ruler of Awadh. After her husband was exiled to Calcutta, she took charge of the affairs in the state of Awadh and seized control of Lucknow. She also arranged for her son, Prince Birjis Qadr, to become wali (ruler) of Awadh. But Prince Birjis Qadar was removed from his post by the British administration.

Nevertheless, the defeat didn't kill her spirit and she continued her quest to free the nation from British occupation. When there was a popular uprising across north India against the British (mis)rule, she again rebelled by raising a rag tag army of freedom fighters who came together under her command. Many renowned freedom fighters of the time including Allama Fazle Haq Khairabadi came along with her and not just battled against the British forces in Lucknow, they gave the British Army very tough time in beating them in surrounding districts.

Begum Hazrat Mahal's original name was Muhammadi Khanum. Her biographers are divided as to how she married the Nawab of Awadh. Nevertheless, they all agree that Muhammadi Khanum was given the title of begum after being accepted as a royal concubine of the King of Awadh,

and the title 'Hazrat Mahal' was bestowed on her after the birth of their son, Birjis Qadar.

Mohi-ud-Din Mirza, who made a well-received documentary, 'Begum Hazrat Mahal: The Last Queen of Avadh' says that her victories have been admitted by the British officers. While talking to The Hindustan Times he said, she "was an intuitive politician. She was praised for her military and administrative ability. She personally led the famous Siege of Lucknow Residency. This Queen fought the British tyrants of the East India Company and later, Queen Victoria herself. She would have been successful had the British usurpers not purchased help from the Nepal king...She led a 'peasants in uniform' military rebellion in Avadh. In no time it turned into a general uprising of the people. She established social equality between people of all castes and religions. Her militant activities against the English were not only to secure freedom for Avadh but freedom for India. Sir Henry Lawrence (the chief commissioner of Avadh) conceded defeat in a decisive Battle at Chinhat fought on June 30, 1857."

It is said that Begum Hazrat Mahal's main complaint against the occupation forces was that they demolished temples and mosques at will. In a letter she wrote, "To eat pigs and drink wine, to bite greased cartridges and to mix pig's fat with sweetmeats, to destroy Hindu and Mussalman temples on pretense of making roads, to build churches, to send clergymen into the streets to preach the Christian religion, to institute English schools, and pay people a monthly stipend for learning the English sciences, while the places of worship of Hindus and Mussalmans are to this day entirely neglected;

with all this, how can people believe that religion will not be interfered with?”

Her army that first defeated the British forces and controlled Lucknow and the nearby towns and cities, was a confluence of Hindus and Muslims. Initially, her forces were led by Raja Jailal Singh. Later she also allied with Nana Saheb. Both Hindus and Muslims fought under her banner to defeat the colonial forces.

When her forces were finally defeated, she tried to seek asylum in Nepal. After being initially denied asylum, she was given asylum and she breathed her last in Kathmandu, the Nepalese capital in the year 1879. She was buried in the courtyard of Jama Masjid of Kathmandu.

## Maulana Shafi Daudi

Without mentioning the name of Maulana Shafi Daudi, the history of freedom struggle will remain incomplete. For, he was a man of great fortitude, courage and determination and put all his abilities to use while struggling for the independence of the nation. For him, the enslavement of the Indian nation by British colonial powers was akin to death. He believed that in order to erase this misfortune, Indians, irrespective of religion, race and caste should unite and fight the oppressors and force them take a hasty retreat.

Maulana Shafi Daudi was born on 27 October 1875, at village Daudnagar in Muzaffarpur, Bihar. He began his involvement in the freedom movement as the local president of the Indian National Congress in Muzaffarpur, Bihar. Soon he rose to the provincial and national leadership and caught the attention of top leaders of the freedom movement, including Mahatma Gandhi, Muhammad Ali Jinnah, Abul Kalam Azad, Shaikat Ali, Muhammad Ali Jauhar, Jawaharlal Nehru, Rajendra Prasad, besides others.

Despite his exemplary role in the freedom movement, it is hard to find any mention of Maulana Shafi Daudi in the annals of history. Most of the books on freedom fighters and

India's history of independence movement, don't mention his name and whenever they mention his name, it is only as a passing reference.

While voluminous books have been authored by many, over the decades, on the life, work and sacrifices of different freedom fighters, not much has been written on Maulana Shafi Daudi despite his stellar services and his role as a uniting force for the Hindus and the Muslims. He was completely averse to the destructive idea of two nation theory. He worked hard for the unity of Muslims and Hindus and strengthening of their bonds of friendship, brotherhood and camaraderie.

David Page, in his well-received book, *'Prelude to Partition'* has expressed admiration for Shafi Daudi. "A thoroughly conscientious conference working secretary, Maulana Shafi Daudi was a man of great experience in many different political spheres, in local provincial and national politics. As a former Khilafatist, Daudi was well acquainted with the politics of the religion; as a non-cooperator, he had learnt how to give a programme mass appeal; as Motilal's lieutenant in Bihar, he had acquired the techniques of provincial organisation; as the member of the Central Assembly, he was well aware of what was at stake in All India terms; as a national politician, he had innumerable contacts in many different provinces. He was an extremely devoted and selfless worker in the Conference cause and to him undoubtedly goes much of the credit for the success of the organization", writes David Page.

After Calcutta session of the Congress, Maulana Daudi tried to rejuvenate the Congress and addressed a number of rallies in the region, thus increasing the popularity of the Indian National Congress. Merely a few months later, four-member committee was formed by the state unit of the Congress. The importance of Maulana Daudi can be gauged by the fact that he was one of the four members of the committee along with Maulana Mazharul Haq. When Gandhiji and other stalwarts of the freedom movement visited Muzaffarpur, they all stayed at Daudi's residence known as Shafi manzil.

Dr Mohammad Sajjad in an article says, "After the Nagpur session (1920) of the Congress, law courts came to be boycotted; Daudi gave up his lucrative court practice (of around Rs three thousand a month) and started adjudicating the disputes either at his home or at the district headquarters of the Congress at the Tilak Maidan in Muzaffarpur which became hub of nationalist activities. On the death of Tilak in 1920 a target was fixed to raise a fund of Rs ten million from across the country. It was due mainly to the efforts of Daudi that Muzaffarpur contributed Rs one lakh to the fund".

Towards the end of the year 1921, Maulana Daudi was arrested when the police raided his house. His wife Zubaida Daudi tried to fill the vacuum created by the arrest of leading freedom fighters of the area and addressed several meetings. It is said that the building of the collectorate was surrounded by agitating mobs who were protesting against Daudi's arrest.

In the year 1924, Maulana Daudi was elected to the Central Assembly. But pretty soon he got disenchanted by the Indian National Congress as it increasingly started looking anti-

Muslim to him and many other Muslim leaders in Bihar. When Simon Commission arrived, he launched a frontal attack at it and its recommendations. He led massive protests in Muazaffarpur and Patna along with leading provincial and national Congress leaders.

While writing about him Dr Sajjad says, "...the Motilal Nehru Report came. On 18 October 1928 there was a public meeting of Muslims outpouring dissatisfaction against the Nehru Report. This was preceded by such meetings in various district headquarters of Bihar. In August 1928 he had reiterated it at the All Parties' Conference, Lucknow. Motilal Nehru did not endorse it; rather he bluntly snubbed him, which shocked him deeply and he left the Congress-Swaraj Party. On 9 December 1928, an All Parties Conference of Muslims was convened to know the Muslim reaction on the Nehru Report. This conference passed many resolutions including communal amity, joint electorate, reservation for Muslims in the central assembly, provincial autonomy, and complete independence for India, whereas the Nehru Report had contented itself on Dominion Status".

He went on to form The All India Muslim Conference on October 31, in Delhi. The new front had several Muslim legislatures of the Indian Parliament. The participants drafted a most important resolution and got it passed by the AIMCs first session held at Delhi in 1929 under the chairmanship of Sir Sultan Muhammad Agha Khan III. He was the general secretary of the All India Muslim Conference from 1930 to 1932, but he resigned when the leaders of both AIMC and All India Muslim League decided to merge the two organisations.



Despite his resignation, the two parties made him a life-long vice president of the new organization. Nevertheless, he never showed any interest in the Muslim League and continued to oppose it. He fought the elections in 1937, but lost it. Disheartened he left for his village. Maulana fought the elections in 1937, but lost badly.

Maulana Daudi became marginalized later as he was opposed to the idea of Muslim League's two-nation theory and Pakistan and unhappy at the increasing anti-Muslim stance of the Congress in Bihar. Had he supported the Muslim League, he would have been among the top leaders of the organization. He joined Jamaat-e-Islami launched by Islamist ideologue, Syed Abul Ala Maududi. In January 1949, Daudi breathed his last.

## Rafi Ahmed Kidwai

The history of India's freedom struggle will remain incomplete without mentioning the name of Rafi Ahmed Kidwai. He was a stalwart of India's freedom struggle who strived hard and made sacrifices throughout his life for the cause of independence.

Indian independence would have remained a pipedream had these leaders not made Himalayan sacrifices despite intimidations, threats, and oppression by the British Raj. Colonial masters were brutal throughout the occupation of the country and they did their best to prolong the occupation and subjugation for as long as possible. Had freedom fighters and their leaders not made strenuous efforts forgoing every comfort and leisure, the occupation wouldn't have ended in 1947.

Rafi Ahmed Kidwai plunged into the freedom movement at a very young age. To be fair he gave up his education for the sake of war of independence as he left Aligarh Muslim University midway to join Khilafat Movement. Despite all efforts of a section of the ruling class, it will be utterly impossible for them to erase his name from the freedom movement of the country. His achievements as India's first Food and Agriculture Minister are legendary and there are

reasons to believe that Rafi Ahmed Kidwai laid the foundation of green revolution in the country.

Rafi Ahmed Kidwai was born on 18 February 1894 in Masauli, Barabanki in Uttar Pradesh. He was educated at home by a tutor who taught him basic Urdu, Arabic and Persian, that was the tradition in North India. He was admitted into the Government High School, Barabanki and then was sent off to the Mohammadan Anglo-Oriental College (Aligarh Muslim University), Aligarh, where he graduated with a BA in the year 1918. He wanted to be a lawyer and thus got admission in LLB. Nevertheless, he had to leave it midway due to his extreme involvement in the freedom movement.

He was incarcerated along with several other freedom fighters for his deep involvement in the Non-Cooperation Movement.

Before the end of the second decade of the last century, he emerged as one of the top leaders of the Congress in Uttar Pradesh. It is said that Rafi Ahmed Kidwai led the Non-Cooperation Movement in eastern UP with full vigour and left no stone unturned in bringing a large proportion of masses into the freedom movement. He prompted a large number of Muslims in Barabanki, Faizabad and Bahraich to side with the Congress, the main anti-imperial force in the country.

Rafi Ahmed Kidwai used different means to attract people to the freedom movement. In the year 1930, he was jailed for spearheading a no-rent campaign by farmers and villagers in

Rae Bareli district. The British Raj was incensed by this campaign of Kidwai and felt it a major threat for the imperial power. Kidwai was kept behind bars for as long as six months.

With his astronomical rise in the Indian National Congress and the freedom movement, he was among the top picks when the Congress government was formed in 1937. When G.B. Pant Cabinet in UP was sworn in following Congress win, Kidwai was given charge of the Revenue and Jail portfolios. Under his stewardship, UP was the first province to do away with some of the defects of the Zamindari system. In April 1946, he was elevated as the Home Minister of Uttar Pradesh. He made far reaching impact wherever he went and the departments that he headed as minister saw considerable improvement within a short period of time.

He was one of the two Muslim cabinet ministers in Jawaharlal Nehru government that was sworn after the Partition of the country. He became India's first Minister for Communications. After the first general elections in the country in the year 1952, he was sworn in as cabinet minister. He was given the charge of food and agriculture ministry. His biographers claim that Kidwai was a man of considerable learning, though not confined to mere academic knowledge. He was a confidante of the first Prime Minister of India, Jawaharlal Nehru, and had complete trust of the PM.

He was a workaholic and worked round the clock without ever complaining of being tired. The hard work impacted his health and soon he started suffering from bouts of cardiac asthma. He died on 24 October 1954 while still a cabinet

minister. Kidwai was laid to rest in his ancestral village with full state honours.

His stint as transport minister in Nehru's cabinet made lasting impact on India's communication scenario. He launched an Airmail Scheme, linking major airport cities of Bombay, Calcutta, New Delhi and Chennai. Mail from these airports will reach their recipients within two or three days instead of seven/eight days. The service remains the most popular service of India Post even now. Another important change he made was the introduction of the 'Inland Letter'.

## Syed Mohammad Sharfuddin Quadri

**H**akim Syed Mohammad Sharfuddin Quadri lived a rather very long life. Surviving for 114 long years, despite spending a long time behind prison cells is itself a huge accomplishment.

Syed Mohammad Sharfuddin Quadri who died in the year 2015 was born in 1901. He was a Gandhian and always remained a Gandhian despite being tested by time and fortunes. Syed Mohammad Sharfuddin Quadri reportedly accompanied Mahatma Gandhi in the Salt March of 1930 and was a prison mate of the Indian leader when they were incarcerated by the British regime at Cuttack Jail.

Earlier, he had taken part in the Khilafat movement but seems to have been a foot soldier, rather than being among the leaders on the front. Despite being among the mid-level leaders during the freedom struggle, he did everything in his capacity to help the freedom movement reach the masses. He made great use of his popularity as a physician.

Syed Mohammad Sharfuddin Quadri was opposed to the two-nation theory espoused by Muhammad Ali Jinnah and Liaquat Ali Khan, who occupied a very important ministry before the partition of the country.

The renowned Hakeem, Syed Mohammad Sharfuddin Quadri was born on 25 December 1901 in Kamrava village of Nawada district in Bihar. His father, Mohammad Mohibbudin, was a Unani practitioner and had a small clinic in the village itself.

There are historic accounts that suggest that Syed Mohammad Sharfuddin Quadri continued his association with the freedom activists and when Rajendra Prasad, who would later become the first president of India, fell ill due to respiratory problems, Quadri assisted his father in treating the future president of the country.

Besides being a freedom fighter, he also worked hard for social uplift of the population living under poverty and penury. In 1994, he assisted Syed Faizan Ahmad in founding the Calcutta Unani Medical College and Hospital. The Government of India awarded him the civilian honor of the Padma Bhushan in 2007. He died on 30 December 2015, at the age of 114, at his Ripon Street residence in Kolkata, survived by his seven children.

## Batak Mian

**L**ike many great Muslim freedom fighters of India, Batak Mian too has been completely forgotten. There is no denying that there has been a rather conscious effort to distort history and so people like Batak Mian didn't fit in the new version of the history.

Not just Batak Mian, even many prominent leaders of the freedom movement have been easily ignored and forgotten. Our history books eulogizing the freedom fighters of all hues have thousands of names, many of them who did precious little for the cause of freedom of the nation, easily forgetting Muslim freedom fighters.

There is little doubt that governments over the years haven't been very keen to highlight Muslim freedom fighters and their contribution, nonetheless bigger blame lies on 20 crore Indian Muslims who have never tried to preserve this great part of the history.

Whenever the life and contribution of Mahatma Gandhi, the father of the nation will be talked and discussed, Batak Mian's name will invariably crop. It was he who saved the Mahatma and his comrade Dr Rajendra Prasad from the clutches of a sure death. It happened in the year 1917 when the freedom



struggle was still in its infancy and Gandhi was decades away from securing the freedom for the nation.

Aijaz Ashraf in a detailed piece on Batak Mian says, “Angry at Gandhi for hopping from village to village, inquiring about the Teenkathia system, a British planter, Erwin, offered inducements, apart from issuing threats, to Batak Mian to mix poison with the food he prepared for Gandhi and his volunteers. Not only did Batak Mian refuse, but he also disclosed Erwin’s diabolic plot to Gandhi and Prasad”.

“There are other, more dramatic versions. In one, Batak Mian is said to have been the cook of British planter Erwin (neither Mishra nor anyone else knows his full name), who had invited Gandhi and Prasad over for dinner. Postprandial, Batak Mian was instructed to lace a glass of milk with poison before giving it to Gandhi, who was presumably staying overnight at the plantation. On entering Gandhi’s room, where Prasad was also present, Batak Mian instructed him not to drink the poisoned milk”, Aijaz Ashraf goes on to add.

“In another version, as retold by Varma and many others, Batak Mian entered the room and offered the glass of milk to Gandhi. Just when Gandhi was to drink it, Batak Mian was overcome by pangs of conscience. He snatched the glass from Gandhi and poured out the milk on the floor. With tears flowing, Batak Mian narrated how Erwin had threatened him and, alternatively, offered inducements for poisoning Gandhi (An even more embellished version says a cat licked the milk on the floor and died instantly.)” says Ashraf.

It is rather amazing that Batak Mian's courage went unnoticed. Neither Mahatma Gandhi wrote about him, nor Rajendra Prasad, the first President of India. It was only a few years after independence when Prasad happened to meet Batak Mian by chance that he narrated the incident to the audience during a visit to Motihari, Bihar.

It is said that Batak Mian's heroic act didn't go down well with the British officials who punished him badly for saving Mahatma. Reports suggest that British officials put him into jail and brutally tortured him. His house was turned into a crematorium and later he and his family were forced out of the village.

It is needless to say that Dr Prasad was overcome with grief when he saw the poverty that had fallen on Batak Mian. During the same visit Dr Rajendra Prasad, reportedly ordered the Bihar government officials to allot Batak Mian's family 50 acres of land in recognition of his superb sacrifice. The land is yet to be given to the poor cook's family who sacrificed everything to save the Father of the Nation.

Aijaz Ashraf while lamenting the fate of freedom fighters in the country says, "...the story of Batakh Mian also underlines the irony of our times. While Nathuram Godse, the killer of Gandhi, the emblem of Hindu nationalism, remains firmly implanted in our political consciousness, the saviour of Mahatma Gandhi languishes on its margins. It symbolises why Hindutva is on the rise and the Congress on the decline".

Batak Mian survived for full ten years after the freedom of the nation. It is very disheartening to note that he couldn't feel the change that freedom of the nation brought for him or his family. He died in the year 1957 penniless and in extreme poverty. Reports suggest that his five grandsons' struggle to get 50 acres of land promised to Batak Mian has remained unfulfilled despite promises by Nitish Kumar and other successive governments.

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